
CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE
3
YEAR 3
SYOUGO KINUGASA
TOMOSESHUNSAKU
ART BY
SCHOOL

CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE
YEAR3
3

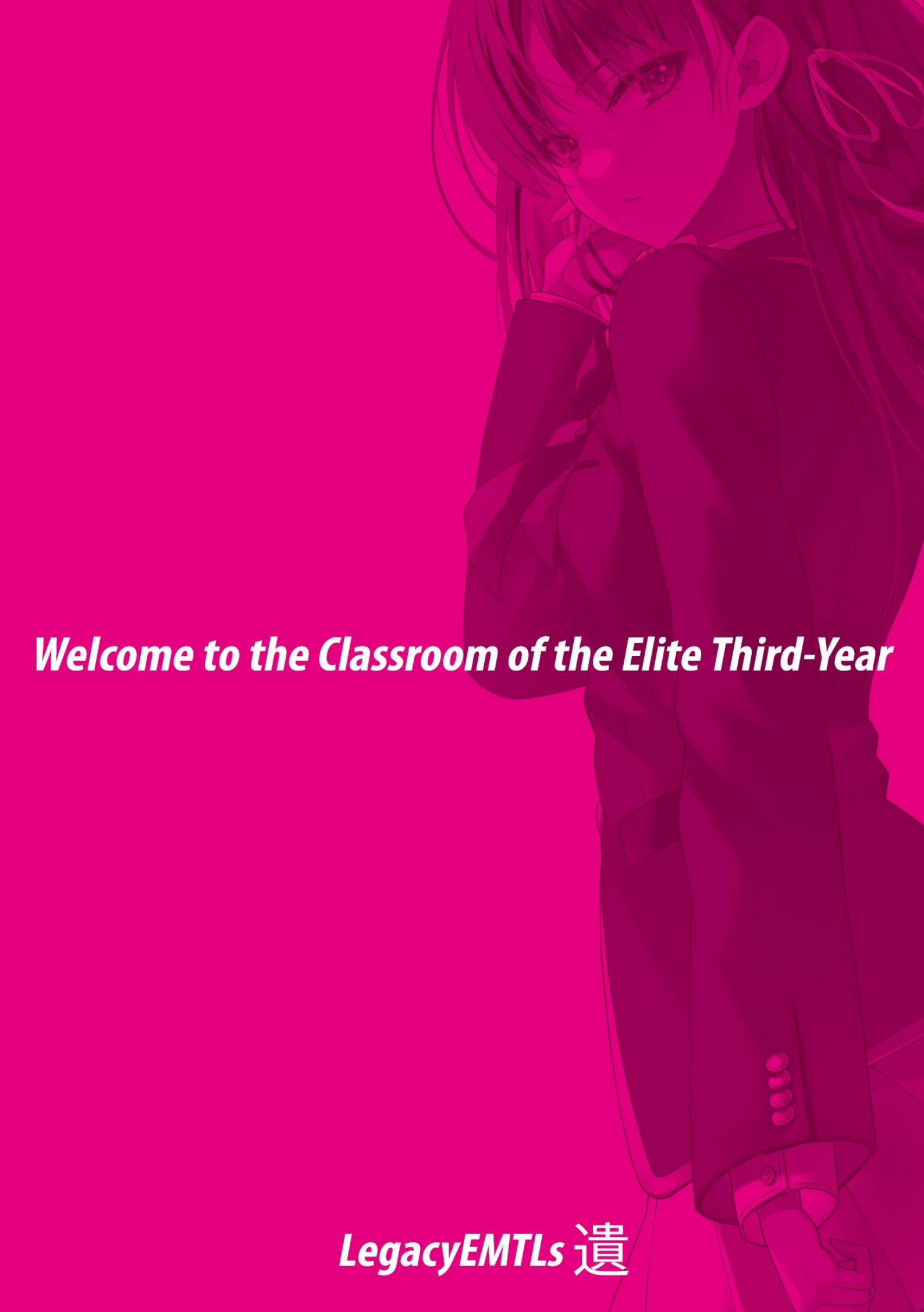
SYOUGO KINUGASA
ART BY TOMOSESHUNSAKU




遺
'At this rate, Class C might just end up losing.'
Kobashi muttered.
"That's not true."
'Huh? No? What do you mean... not true?'
Ichinose smiled and sent gentle words over the radio.
"Ayanokouji-kun won't lose. No, I won't let him lose."


"Lookin' pretty happy all by yourself, Shiina."
"Oh my, good morning, Ryuuen-kun."
Shiina, who returned the short greeting,
turned to face Ryuuen and smiled cheerfully.
"Since we're at the beach, I was taking a little walk."
遺


遺
Horikita Suzune



Welcome to the Classroom of the Elite Third-Year

LegacyEMTLs 遺


遺
A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15
N
W
E
S
ISLAND MAP

UNINHABITED ISLAND SURVIVAL GAME SPECIAL EXAM

遺

DURATION

Maximum of 3 nights and 4 days.
The exam will end immediately if a decisive outcome is reached.
The daily exam hours are from 9:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. (until 4:00 p.m. only on the final day)

OVERVIEW

Compete by using paint guns to eliminate the VIPs and guards of other classes.

Preparation

Every student will have one of five roles.
Most roles have a limit on the number of students and roles grant different privileges.

Commander x 1 Student (Mandatory)

Can track the positions of all students via GPS using a tablet.
• Class A is displayed in red, Class B in blue, Class C in yellow and Class D in green.
• GPS positions are updated every five minutes during exam hours.
Can deploy 'tactics'.
Can communicate with VIPs via radio.
Can know the information (name, role) of eliminated students.
The commander cannot be eliminated and possesses no means of attack.
Cannot leave the Headquarters Area (F14)
A substitute may be appointed, if and only if, the school approves. For example, in cases of poor health or injury.

VIP x 3 Students (Mandatory)

Can communicate directly with the commander via radio.
Possesses no means of attack.
Grants 100 points for each VIP surviving until the exam's conclusion.
At the moment all three VIPs are eliminated, the entire class will be eliminated and their ranking will be determined.

Guard x Unlimited

Possesses the only means to attack opponents, with a paintball gun.
• Eliminated students are disqualified, removed from the island and must wait on the ship until the exam ends.
Guards must bring at least one main weapon back to headquarters when eliminated.
• Any weapons lost during the exam must be reported to the school immediately.
Grants 1 point for each surviving Guard at the exam's conclusion.

Analyst x Maximum of 2

Can use a tablet to identify event locations, supply names and obtain passwords.
If there is a vacancy, a new analyst can be appointed from the remaining Guards, but they cannot return to being a Guard.
Has no means of attack.

Scout x Maximum of 1

Can detect the presence of students from other classes in the area where the scout is located and the surrounding 8 areas.
If a student from another class enters the same area, their direction from the scout can also be detected.
• However, if GPS is disabled via tactics, detection is impossible.
If there is a vacancy, a new scout can be appointed from the remaining Guards, but they cannot return to being a Guard.
Has no means of attack.

VICTORY CONDITIONS

Competition based on total points: VIP survivors x 100 points + Guard survivors x 1 point.
If a draw occurs, one student will be randomly selected from each class to perform a short-term sudden death match.

REWARDS AND PENALTIES

Rewards

1st Place: Class Points +150
2nd Place: Class Points +100
3rd Place: Class Points -100
4th Place: Class Points -150

Total Annihilation Penalty

The first class to be wiped out before the end of the exam must select one student for expulsion.

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Synopsis

Third-years, their final summer; this year’s uninhabited island exam is a class-versus-class survival game fought with paintball guns.

Students must navigate an area divided into a 15x15 grid, scavenging for food and ammunition that periodically appear while competing to eliminate students from other classes.

Making a sound strategy for both offense and defense is paramount, for the first class to be completely wiped out faces the penalty of selecting student(s) for expulsion.

Each class has a student in the ‘Commander’ role who can view the GPS locations of every student displayed in their respective class colours every five minutes, making coordinated group action an absolute necessity.

"We have their brass pinned down, but... what's your move, Ayanokouji."

"Yeah... We should be one step ahead, yet it's still terrifying after all, isn't it."

"Ayanokoji-kun won't lose. No, I won't let him lose."

Four-day, three-night special exam on the uninhabited island; its conclusion is——!?

Prologue:
Shiina Hiyori's Monologue

AS THE SEA breeze brushed against my skin, I recalled that day.

Under the sunset sky I spent with Ayanokouji-kun, in front of the school building that should’ve looked just the same as always.

To me, that was a wonderful, irreplaceable and vivid memory.

However, I couldn't take that one final step.

‘*I like you*’—in the end, I wasn’t able to say those words out loud.

But I think that was the right thing to do.

After all, Ayanokouji-kun and I are in different classes... we’re enemies.

If our class is to be defeated in this special exam as well, and the gap is to widen...

That will become the final turning point determining whether or not we can reach Class A.

I’ve always known that.

And for myself, it is a major decision—a path I choose with resolve.

To defeat Ayanokouji-kun.

To inflict defeat upon Ayanokouji-kun.

For that purpose... what must I do?

What can I do?

In this special exam, I see a path to survival and a path to death at the same time.

However—

A painful emotion naturally wells up within me.

Gazing out at the vast ocean, all alone, I continue to stare quietly—

It seems I am unable to be of use to the class and I will lose this final battle as well.

I am sorry, Ryuuen-kun.

I am sorry, Ayanokouji-kun.

Please forgive me for being so pathetic.

And please, take care of yourself.

Please...

Even if we’re far apart, my feelings will never change.

In this world with no one else, all alone—

Until the whistle signaling the end sounds, I will continue to gaze out alone

—

Chapter 1:
Opening. Survival Game Special Exam.

EARLY MORNING, LATE June.

A large cruise ship carrying students from all grade levels was crossing the open sea, heading toward a certain small, uninhabited island.

The first-years couldn’t hide their bewilderment at the sheer scale of it all.

The second-years looked tense, but still carried an air of confidence.

Oddly enough, for us third-years, this would mark our third straight year battling it out on an uninhabited island.

There was no mistaking that it was looming right before our eyes, but there was one thing that’d been unexpected.

It was the fact that the stage of our battle was the exact same uninhabited island as last year.

Still, when you thought about it calmly, it actually made perfect sense.

It was said that there were easily over ten thousand uninhabited islands in Japan, both large and small, but if one narrowed it down to islands where people could actually land, the number dropped significantly. Furthermore, if one looked for an uninhabited island with terrain usable for an exam and for which permission could be obtained from the owner, there would likely be only a handful available.

The beaming sun was intensely bright, but it was by no means too hot; rather, bathed in the sea breeze, it was somewhat chilly. The effect of moving the schedule up by about a month compared to last year and the year before seemed to be surprisingly significant.

The large cruise ship, advanced gently while cutting through the waves, eventually began to slow down to be embraced by the shores of the uninhabited island.

The time was just past eight in the morning.

"Looks like we're finally arriving."

Since we had free time until the ship arrived at the uninhabited island, Hashimoto, who’d come to the ship's café with me, muttered that while stretching and yawning.

"Ah~, I’m sleepy. I should've gone to bed a little earlier yesterday."

It seemed he stayed up late into the night and was a little sleep-deprived.

"Well then... I wonder what kind of troublesome, no, pain-in-the-ass exam is waiting for us this year."

Muttering that in succession, Hashimoto pinched the front collar of his brand-new short-sleeved shirt with his fingertips and lifted it up.

"There's probably a reason they went out of their way to distribute new gym clothes to us, too."

Upon boarding this ship from the school, all of us third-years were distributed new jersey tops and bottoms as well as shirts to wear underneath. We were obliged to change into them before disembarking. In appearance, they looked almost identical to the usual ones, but compared to our regular gym clothes, the fabric seemed slightly thicker, so it was certain that there was some kind of difference.

"But isn't this unbearable for students preparing for entrance exams? Being pulled away from their desks at this time of year. Have the third-years up until now never complained about this?"

The words spilled from Hashimoto, who for the time being had absolutely no intention of taking entrance exams.

"Who knows. But I did see Shimazaki bringing a set of study materials onto the ship."

"So he's stuck studying even on the ship, huh?"

Though I also saw him get hit by terrible seasickness and give up halfway through.

"In any case, won't they provide study time afterwards to make up for it?"

"They wouldn't cut into our precious summer vacation, would they? If that's how they ‘make up for it’, then spare me."

What kind of measures were they considering, or were they not considering it at all?

As a third-year student, I was mildly curious, but right on cue, as if someone heard Hashimoto’s grumbling, an onboard announcement came on.

'We will be arriving at the uninhabited island shortly. As previously informed, third-year students are to leave all personal belongings, including mobile phones, in their guest rooms and carry nothing. Please change into the designated gym clothes and prepare to disembark.'

Such was the reiterated notification. Since both Hashimoto and I already finished changing and were empty-handed, we only had to wait for the ship to stop without moving anywhere in particular.

"The fact that the first and second-years haven't been called yet... does that mean, by any chance, that they won't be landing on the uninhabited island right away?"

Hashimoto, who assumed it would be an uninhabited island exam where all grade levels were jumbled together from the start, looked around with a puzzled expression.

"Maybe. But speculating now won’t tell us anything."

"True..."

Shortly after, when the ship docked and the announcement came on stating that it’d come to a complete stop, I stood up from my seat with Hashimoto and headed outside from the deck.

Part 1

I COULDN'T TELL from inside the ship, but what I realized immediately upon disembarking was that the development of the uninhabited island progressed considerably compared to last year. Even regarding the travel time, my memories from last year might not be reliable.

One of the people standing nearby, likely a school official, pointed toward the beach.

"Your homeroom teachers are standing over there, so please head over immediately and line up by class."

Since third-year students were beginning to gather one after another from behind as well, I quickened my pace.

As I approached the beach, I saw a massive amount of cardboard boxes stacked up.

"I remember quite a bit. Talk about nostalgia."

During the uninhabited island survival exam held for all school years, everyone racked their brains, facing maps and moving repeatedly in every direction, north, south, east, and west.

That was why, despite the short duration, this scene and scenery were likely etched firmly into our memories.

I headed to where our Class C homeroom teacher, Mashima-sensei, was waiting, and waited for all the third-year students to assemble.

As expected, there was no sign of the first or second-year students disembarking.

Were we starting the exam ahead of time alone, or were the other grades not involved at all?

It was unclear, but the full picture would surely become clear soon along with the explanation.

All the third-year students gathered within a few minutes, but before the explanation of the exam, it was announced by Mashima-sensei, who’d moved to the center of the beach, that Nakanishi from third-year Class D would be absent from the special exam due to a fever.

"It’s unfortunate that we have an absentee, but poor health is unavoidable. In this case, the class in question will begin with one less person. Now, regarding

the start of the Uninhabited Island Survival Game Special Exam, I will explain the rules."

Nakanishi's absence was only touched upon lightly and there didn't seem to be any particularly heavy penalties. While being down a member was naturally a disadvantage, since it was Ichinose's class—which had maintained its original forty students—and he wasn't a student with outstanding grades, the damage would likely be minimal.

A rulebook containing the details of the special exam was passed down from the front row to me.

It seemed we were meant to listen to the explanation while looking at the rulebook.

On the cover, grid lines were drawn over a photograph of the uninhabited island.

The island was naturally the exact same as last year, but I noticed a certain difference immediately. Last time, the letters marked on the grid lines were A to J and the numbers 1 to 10, but this time the areas seemed to be more subdivided, ranging from A to O and 1 to 15.

Deciding to look at the map more carefully later, I opened it up right away to check the overview.

Uninhabited Island Survival Game Special Exam

***Duration**: -Maximum of 3 nights and 4 days. -The exam will end immediately if a decisive outcome is reached.*

-The daily exam hours are from 9:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. (until 4:00 p.m. only on the final day)

Overview:

-Compete by using paint guns to eliminate the VIPs and guards of other classes.

Preparation:

-To conduct this exam, each class will first assign every student to one of five roles.

Most roles have a limit on the number of people, and different privileges are granted depending on the role.

Commander x 1 Student (Mandatory):

-Can track the positions of all students via GPS using a dedicated tablet.

-Class A is displayed in red, Class B in blue, Class C in yellow, and Class D in green.

-GPS positions are updated every five minutes only during the exam hours of 9:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m.

-Can deploy 'tactics' (detailed later).

-Can communicate with VIPs via transceiver.

-Can know the information (name, role) of eliminated students.

-The commander cannot be eliminated and possesses no means of attack.

-Cannot leave the Headquarters Area (F14)

-A substitute may be appointed, if and only if, the school approves. For example, in cases where continuation is impossible due to poor health or injury.

VIP x 3 Students (Mandatory):

-Can communicate directly with the commander via radio.

-Possesses no means of attack.

-Grants 100 points for each VIP surviving until the exam's conclusion.

At the moment three VIPs are eliminated, the class will be treated as wiped out and their ranking will be determined.

Guard x Unlimited Students:

-Possesses the only means to attack opponents, using a paintball gun to eliminate them.

-Eliminated students are disqualified, removed from the island and must wait on the ship until the exam ends.

-Guards must bring at least one main weapon back to headquarters when eliminated.

-Any weapons lost during the exam must be reported to the school immediately.

-Grants 1 point for each surviving Guard at the exam's conclusion

Analyst x Maximum of 2 Students:

-Can use a tablet to identify event locations, supply names, and obtain passwords.

-If there is a vacancy, a new analyst can be appointed from the remaining Guards, but they cannot return to being a Guard. For appointment, the VIP must contact the Commander and analyst authority is obtained only after approval.

-Has no means of attack.

Scout x Maximum of 1 Student

-Can detect the presence of students from other classes in the area where the scout is located and the surrounding 8 areas, for a total of 9.

-If a student from another class enters the same area, their direction from the scout can also be detected.

However, if GPS is disabled via tactics, detection is impossible in both the surrounding 8 areas and the same area.

-If there is a vacancy, a new scout can be appointed from the remaining Guards, but they cannot return to being a Guard. For appointment, the VIP must contact the commander and scout authority is obtained only after approval.

-Has no means of attack.

Victory Conditions:

-Competition based on total points: VIP survivors x 100 points + Guard survivors x 1 point.

**If a draw occurs, one student will be randomly selected from each class to perform a short-term sudden death match.*

Rewards and Penalties

1st Place: Class Points +150

2nd Place: Class Points +100

3rd Place: Class Points -100

4th Place: Class Points -150

Total Annihilation Penalty *The first class to be wiped out before the end of the exam must select one student for expulsion.*

The rules of the special exam were explained by Mashima-sensei as we browsed through the rulebook.

To summarize it simply, the special exam was about defeating opponents in a survival game using paintball guns on this vast uninhabited island.

My first impression was that it was 'more lenient than I imagined.'

It was likely unavoidable that an expulsion would occur from one of the classes, but that was all. No matter how you looked at it, based on the rules of the exam, you could see that only one person would be expelled.

Of course, this was welcome news for most students.

The exam itself didn't seem as complex as the massive amount of explanation in the rulebook suggested; the challenge lay elsewhere. It was the fact that most students had probably never touched toys like these before, whether paintball guns, airsoft guns, or gas-powered ones. I could see a look of bewilderment spreading heavily across everyone.

"Anyone here ever played a survival game? Or know anything about it?"

Hashimoto called out in a low voice to several boys standing nearby, but not a single one nodded.

Unfortunately, it seemed that very few people in Class C, to which I belonged, welcomed this special exam.

On the other hand, looking toward Class A, I was able to confirm figures like Onizuka and Ijuuin chatting happily and getting excited. Judging by their demeanor, they might have knowledge of survival games, or perhaps they actually experienced them. Just from the expressions I caught a glimpse of, I could tell they had confidence.

"In addition to normal survival game elements, how you handle your assigned roles will also be extremely important. While the commander's tactics have usage restrictions, some can significantly alter the course of battle. The periodically triggered 'Events' will also impact the situation. Read through the rulebook and verify for yourselves what the specifics are."

Reading further through the pages, as told by Mashima-sensei, details regarding the commander's tactics and events were listed.

Tactics (Can be used by the commander at any timing):

-Global GPS Shutdown — Disables the GPS of all students in a specified class for 30 minutes.

Usage Limit: 1 time

-Individual GPS Shutdown — Disables the GPS of a specified person for 30 minutes.

Usage Limit: 3 times

Identity Check — Reveals the name and role of a student at a specified GPS location.

Usage Limit: 5 times

**Even during the use of Global GPS Shutdown or Individual GPS Shutdown, the commander of the class that used the tactic can still verify positions every 5 minutes on their tablet.*

The tactics granted exclusively to the commander seemed like they could truly turn the tide of battle if used effectively as Mashima-sensei said, but they also appeared to require careful judgment, since poor timing could render them completely useless.

The global GPS shutdown in particular seemed likely to become a trump card with a wide range of uses, such as launching a surprise attack or ensuring escape from pursuers.

As I was mulling this over, staff members began to gather, hurriedly carrying boxes and from inside them, wristwatches, that I saw last year as well, were taken out. They were distributed to each student, and once attached to our wrists, everyone performed the initial setup.

"Removal of this watch is strictly prohibited. You’re obligated to wear it for twenty-four hours a day during the special exam and anyone who removes it midway bears the risk of disqualification. In the unlikely event that a malfunction or error occurs, report it to your commander immediately or head to headquarters. Like last year, the watch displays your blood pressure, heart rate, and so on. You can also check the area you are currently in, as well as your direction. Furthermore, a mechanism is built in, where if a paintball hits your clothing, a sensor will activate, the watch will detect it and an 'Out' judgment will be issued. In other words, the moment the watch displays an 'Out' judgment, you are disqualified. Also, students appointed as scouts will have a dedicated GPS tracking function for other classes unlocked. The watch is equipped with other detailed functions as well, so please refer to the rulebook details."

There were still pages remaining in the rulebook. From there on it listed the watch's functions, how to use them and details of other rules to follow. I could just read the rest later. I already understood the contents of the exam.

"An expulsion from the class whose three VIP’s get taken out first, huh? Well, I figured they'd pull something like that."

Hashimoto muttered as he turned his wrist over to look at the watch attached to his left arm.

"Is this what you expected?"

"Well, pretty much—"

Looking at the relationship between their positions, the students moving around and fighting on the island couldn't know their exact location through a device's bird's-eye view. The same applied to the method of tracking the current locations of other classes. The fact that their only means of receiving intel was via radio from the commander at headquarters, through a VIP was quite challenging. Danger would arise not only from simple mistakes in failing to communicate, but also from discrepancies in verbal exchanges. Furthermore, students who got separated from their VIP would have to search for their teammates relying only on their watches, making them more susceptible to surprise attacks and the like.

"You should’ve finished looking through the rulebook roughly. The duration of the special exam is at most three nights and four days. You’ll attack other classes using the initial supplies distributed to each class or paintballs obtained from event supply crates and the victory or defeat of a class will be decided by this competition."

While listening to those words, I took a look at the details regarding the events one last time.

Event:

-Events will automatically activate at 11:00 AM (10:00 AM for the first time only), 1:00 PM, 3:00 PM, and 5:00 PM.

-(1) A supply crate will appear in a specific area for one hour only, and its contents can be acquired. There are three types: food, daily necessities and paintballs. Details and volume are unknown until acquired.

-Supply crates can be acquired by entering a common password.

-The common password changes every hour (carrying the crate is prohibited).

-(2) From Day 2 onward, an event will occur where prohibited areas are added sequentially.

-Areas designated as prohibited will become unusable one hour after the announcement.

-Anyone who stays in a prohibited area for more than five minutes will be forced 'Out' and disqualified.

Those were probably the core rules I needed to commit to memory.

In particular, the increase in prohibited areas was an important factor. It would occur from the second day onwards during the four daily events and

entry into those areas would become impossible one hour after the announcement. Depending on the prohibited location, it could become impossible to avoid contact with other classes or fall victim to ambushes.

Also, something that must not be forgotten was that the time from 6:00 PM to 9:00 AM was outside of exam hours. The GPS signal wouldn’t be updated, but movement was basically free during this time. However, it seemed one had to restart from the area where they were staying as of 6:00 PM the previous day. Actions such as moving a long distance during the night to catch the enemy off guard at 9:00 AM the next morning couldn’t be taken.

Considering the vastness of the uninhabited island, I tried constructing multiple virtual maps in my head of what the final phase might look like.

This time, the school explicitly stated a penalty that carried the risk of expulsion.

A student had to be selected from the class that was completely wiped out and expelled.

On the surface, they were unavoidable victims.

However, it could be said that a simple method to minimize the damage had been prepared in advance for many classes.

When the risk of expulsion was first announced, what everyone imagined was either having a 'student with Protection Points' become the sacrifice or having a powerful leader forcibly nominate someone.

The only saving grace was that it was a selection, meaning the decision was left up to each class.

If they chose a student with Protection Points, expulsion could be avoided by consuming them, but it wasn't certain that someone would accept consuming their own Protection Points.

Being in last place and the annihilation penalty were, in a sense, two sides of the same coin. It was a development every class absolutely wanted to avoid.

However, if passive fighting continued out of fear of the expulsion risk, the risk of a draw would surface.

Considering that determining the winner in the event of a draw was completely based on luck, no class would be allowed to keep running away and they would be forced to engage in combat somewhere, whether they liked it or not.

No strong tension could be seen in Mashima-sensei and the others' expressions. I didn't get a gloomy impression.

An escape route far more lenient and easy to understand than I'd assumed.

In that sense, it could be said that they were still going easy on us.

"Now, I will explain the weapons that the guards can handle."

Saying that, Mashima-sensei took out a single assault rifle from a nearby cardboard box. Its shape closely resembled an M16. Then, he held a shotgun in his other hand and Sakagami-sensei, standing nearby, took out and displayed submachine guns and handguns.

"What is that? I've never seen a paintball gun like that before."

That voice could be heard from the direction of Class A, accompanied by surprise.

"This seems to be a prototype paintball gun not yet on the market. For details—Kishinami-san, please."

When Mashima-sensei looked over, an adult I was seeing for the first time, who'd been waiting nearby, bowed slightly.

"Nice to meet you all. I am Kishinami, a sales representative for Kanto Shooter Co., Ltd., a company that manufactures and sells toy guns, specifically airsoft and model guns. This time, in cooperation with the staff and students of Advanced Nurturing High School, we've agreed to cooperate mutually to test a new competitive paintball gun that our company is developing for release in the near future. While maintaining a shape closer to a real gun, it can fire paintballs. Furthermore, the gym clothes you have changed into in advance are packed with our company's latest proprietary technology, incorporating temperature sensitivity, color reaction and impact sensors. It's designed so that if a paintball hits the abdomen or back strongly and bursts, it links with the wristwatch to declare an out. There are cases where you will not be immediately disqualified even if hit, but please consider hits to the chest or back as almost always being a one-shot out. Also, if only a tiny amount adheres to the edge of your gym clothes, the system may not activate, in which case it counts as safe. However, since it is still in the prototype stage, in very rare cases, it may not register an 'out' even with a direct hit. In that case, don't assume you're safe; please stop your attack on the premise that you're out and make sure to report it yourself."

He explained the product in a smooth tone befitting a salesman.

Mashima-sensei nodded as if to supplement the explanation and looked at the students.

"If a safe is judged as an out due to a malfunction, it will be treated as a relief measure. If an out is judged as safe, promptly self-reporting will ensure you face no penalty. Conversely, if you continue while knowing you're out, it will be judged as a serious violation and may result in the defeat of the entire class, so be careful. If you believe a malfunction has occurred, your wristwatch has a call function to report retirement or poor physical condition, so use that to inform us of the details."

That probably meant that if the school checked and determined it was safe, a return would be permitted.

In addition, an explanation was given that stealing another class's gun by any means, using it or rendering it unusable, as well as injuring the opponent's body by punching or kicking or restraining them to prevent them from firing, was strictly prohibited. If those facts were confirmed, it would result in immediate disqualification, an immediate deduction of 100 Class Points and in malicious cases, it would likely become a subject for deliberation regarding expulsion.

"Since this is an important matter, I'll continue the explanation even though there's some overlap. When a paintball hits, the linked wristwatch will make an out judgment and beep for two seconds. If the student who is out is a guard, promptly stop the attack before this sound stops. Continuing to attack despite an out judgment will result in a penalty. Also, this doesn't mean that you can continue shooting for two seconds after being hit out. If you continue to attack, resist or interfere while clearly aware of being out, we will consider it intentional and impose a penalty. Attacks outside of the exam time carry the same penalty. Furthermore, everyone should be aware that illegal acts that undermine the foundation of the special exam rules will absolutely not be tolerated."

If paint that splattered from hitting a tree or similar barely adhered to your clothes without triggering the sensor, it was probably safe to assume it wasn’t an out, but in ambiguous cases, it'd be best to check with the administrators either way.

"The paintball guns here differ not only in appearance but also in performance. This assault rifle modeled after the M16 has the longest range and the magazine capacity is 50 rounds. The shotgun has about half the range and a low capacity of 30 rounds, but it is possible to fire 5 shots simultaneously. The submachine gun has the same range as the assault rifle but a lower capacity of 30 rounds; in exchange, it is lightweight and easy to handle with one hand. Using two of these main weapons simultaneously is prohibited. However,

regarding handguns, although only two are given to each class, they’re the only ones allowed for simultaneous use. However, the user must wear a holster in a visible position on their leg. Also, all weapons have built-in batteries and can fire about 1,000 rounds, but in the unlikely event the battery runs out, there is no way to restore it other than replenishing from a supply box. And while they are equipped with some degree of waterproofing, please be careful as exposing them to heavy rain for a long time or submerging them in the sea or river may damage them and render them unusable."

The salesman took a breath, then, perhaps realizing he’d forgotten to mention something, somewhat hurriedly added, "All paintballs are designed to return to nature. No matter where or how much you shoot, it will not lead to any environmental destruction, so I hope you enjoy yourselves to your heart's content."

Indeed, it would be a problem if the paint from the paintballs led to environmental destruction, but if there was no adverse effect in that regard, it seemed there was no need to hesitate in firing.

"The number of guns initially given to each class is up to the number of guards, but there is an upper limit on the number of each weapon possessed. Not everyone can choose an assault rifle or a submachine gun, so please be careful."

It seemed the intention of the cooperating company to have us use multiple types of paintball guns rather than just one variety.

"Also, the number of paintballs supplied is by no means abundant. The weapons come fully loaded and each person is given only one spare full magazine. Therefore, wasteful consumption could see you running out in the blink of an eye. In that case, you will have to obtain additional paintballs from the event supply boxes."

Or rather, the exam was probably designed with that in mind.

"The special exam runs from 9:00 AM to 6:00 PM each day. The start and end signals will be communicated via the ship's whistle. The first event will start at 10:00, not 11:00. Thereafter, it will be executed at the times written in the rules and combat outside of exam hours is strictly prohibited. If you engage in combat outside of exam hours and take out another student, the person who violated the rules will be considered out instead. Also, should any fraudulent acts to conceal such violations be discovered, a significant amount of Class Points will be deducted from the violating student's class. If it’s malicious, immediate expulsion is possible."

The rulebook that was handed out contained numerous detailed observances, rules that had to be strictly adhered to, regulations and suggestions. If someone were taken out with a paintball outside of exam hours, it wouldn't count as an official elimination. There were also relief measures in place: if you accidentally shot someone, you could report it to your commander and the school would verify the situation and provide a change of clothes. Similarly, there were cases where if one received an out ruling due to a device malfunction, despite not being hit by a paintball during the exam, reporting it could allow for a return to the exam. Of course, these required absolute proof that you weren't hit, so if a paintball struck you after a device malfunction registered you as out, you couldn't expect any relief. On the uninhabited island, those in poor health would be immediately disqualified. Also, intentionally breaking the wristwatch would result in disqualification. If a defect was detected, the audio records from before and after would be preserved.

In that way, it was a good idea to double-check the rulebook in case any unexpected problems arose during the exam.

And what I understood from reading was that while they would turn a blind eye somewhat to minor troubles, they would absolutely not overlook fraud that deviated from the rules and shook the foundation of the special exam. Such as taking off the gym clothes that served as the source of the sensor to avoid being hit or continuing to fire after being eliminated. Given that Class Points would decrease significantly in addition to expulsion, the cost was immeasurable. It was safe to consider that no matter how much Ryuuen tried, he couldn’t destroy the rules of this exam. That applied to me as well; the risk was simply too great.

The only time one might want to push through a bit of unreasonableness would be in the case of a VIP's poor health, but a strict penalty of losing double the points had been announced, if forced participation was discovered. So in a worst-case scenario, retiring honestly would result in less damage.

Then there were the wristwatches distributed to each student, just like last year. Wearing this was mandatory for 24 hours and it constantly monitored heart rate and blood pressure. It was a mechanism where a signal would be sent to headquarters immediately if a malfunction or removal occurred.

Furthermore, in addition to a compass function, the wristwatch was newly equipped with a button that allowed for a voluntary declaration of retirement if one judged that it was difficult to continue due to poor health or serious injury.

Forcing oneself to continue while in a state requiring a medical check would likely be all pain and no gain.

"Now then, after this, I will have one representative from each class—anyone will do—to draw lots. This will determine the initial position for the 9:00 AM start. The four initial positions to choose from are C12, E12, G12, and I12. You'll likely start from locations about a 15-minute walk from each other."

Fifteen minutes was quite a fast estimate. Even if the area had been reduced, was it perhaps the influence of the maintenance work?

Even if it was said to be somewhat separated, it was a stone's throw away. Depending on the starting positions, even if the footing was poor, contact could be made in less than five minutes if one sprinted along the sandy beach with all their might.

However, that wasn't realistic. If students rushed out onto the beach trying to fight in a hurry, other classes would notice and snipe them. It was high risk with a low return.

The western C12, where one wouldn't be sandwiched or the eastern I12, where it was easy to escape, would likely be good.

Although it was a lottery to decide such an important starting position, the result would be the same regardless of who drew it, so I decided to ask Sanada, who was standing nearby. He readily agreed and went to draw the lot.

Mashima-sensei and the others' explanation to the whole group ended. Each class was instructed to distance themselves and form a circle around their homeroom teacher. Then Hashimoto approached me and called out.

"There were a lot of messy explanations, but basically, it means we just have to win a class vs class survival game, right?"

"Pretty much."

"For now, we keep our distance from the other classes and wait things out, yeah? Let's just have them crush each other."

Of course, that would be the most graceful outcome, but I didn't think it would work out so conveniently.

That was because the rules and mechanisms were set up in such a way that anyone would want to reap the benefits of the chaos.

Part 2

OUR STARTING POSITIONS were decided by lottery and we would start from area E12. Ryuuen's Class B was in C12, Horikita's Class A in G12 and Ichinose's Class D in I12.

Sanada apologized for failing to secure an advantageous corner area, but I told him not to worry about it, since there was nothing we could do about it.

Then, moving on to the next step, we were guided in front of some cardboard boxes where an explanation regarding the class-specific supplies began.

"What we have here are the initial supplies given to each class; the contents are common to every class. Regarding the items here, you may take everything here or leave behind whatever you deem unnecessary. However, once the exam starts, any leftover supplies will be collected, so you won’t be able to add more later. Bearing that in mind, judge amongst yourselves what is necessary."

A maximum of three nights and four days. We would have to think carefully about what to take with us.

For now, since there could be no discussion without knowing the contents, we decided to check the inside of the cardboard boxes directly. What immediately caught my eye was an unwelcome reality. It was a meager amount of food that anyone could see was vastly insufficient.

"There’s hardly any food... Isn't this less than a day's worth?"

The only food provided was nutritional supplement blocks and mineral water. Upon counting, there were only two per person for the class and there was absolutely nothing else edible.

It seemed they'd only prepared enough to last through the upcoming lunch.

"If we want food, we have to secure it from the event supplies no matter what, huh... They’re really something."

If event supplies became essential to secure food, the necessity of participating in events would be essential, whether we liked it or not. Naturally, the risk of matching up against other classes would increase significantly.

We could ignore the events, but practically speaking, it was likely designed so that the initially supplied materials alone would definitely be insufficient. To induce combat, such forceful measures might indeed have been necessary.

"Looking at the rules, if we can keep running away, we won't lose for the time being. Paintballs won't be consumed unless we fight, but the food problem is unavoidable."

Shiraishi picked up a box of nutritional supplement blocks and said that.

It was an undeniable fact; the classes that failed to secure food would see their range of strategies narrow, become impatient, challenge others to reckless battles and drop out.

Whether to take risks and retrieve supplies or avoid risks and endure the lack of supplies.

Or perhaps a balanced strategy that took the middle ground.

Already, the discussion within the class was heating up. Opinions were beginning to diverge.

"I definitely think aiming for nearby events is dangerous. If we're going to shoulder the risk of fighting poorly and getting out, why don't we just avoid Class A from the start and cross the mountain? That way, it'll be easier for us to monopolize the events in the northeast area. Other classes wouldn't bother traveling that far to fight us, right?"

Sugio, who'd been listening to the conversation while staring at the small amount of food supplies, proposed that.

However, Shimazaki immediately voiced his opposition.

"I'm against it. Other classes might be thinking something similar. Besides, even if we force ourselves to cross the mountain, there's no guarantee that events will necessarily occur in the northeast, is there?"

It was only the students who assumed they would be distributed evenly; we wouldn't know the actual distribution until we started.

"In that case, I think it's better not to go too far from the starting point until the first event begins."

If we went with the plan Sugio first proposed, we might have been able to avoid combat, but it entailed many risks. In addition to the stamina drain of crossing mountains, there was the uncertainty of event appearances. And the movements of our rivals. None of these could be taken lightly. Deriving a correct answer at this stage was impossible, even for me.

To head north on this uninhabited island via the shortest and safest route, one had to pass through the narrow riverside area in G8. It was conceivable that if we chased after Class A, who had the closest starting position to us, they would

likely rush there first. That could plunge us straight into battle—or something of that sort.

"Not moving, huh? I don't intend to deny that, but if we do that, it means we're resolving ourselves to a shootout right from the start, doesn't it? If, by some chance, three VIPs get taken out because of that—"

Never mind three nights; the outcome could be decided within an hour of the exam starting.

Sugio imagined such a worst-case vision and voiced it.

"Okay, okay. I get what you want to say, Sugio, but for now, let's look at the other supplies before we argue about that. Our leader will squeeze out a good idea for us in the meantime."

Hashimoto cut in between their gazes and urged them on.

Anyone could offer an opinion.

However, if one pushed that opinion through, responsibility naturally followed.

Neither Sugio nor Shimazaki possessed the resolve to shoulder that burden.

"...True enough."

And so, they paused the discussion and left the judgment to the leader.

The strategic path was put on hold, but that didn't mean the tense atmosphere vanished.

In this exam where combat and movement were frequently required, it couldn't be helped that the majority of the class was becoming sensitive.

Precisely because the members of Class C had their strengths skewed toward academics, it was proof that they unconsciously held a strong desire to absolutely avoid making the wrong choice.

Shelving the opening moves and the food issue for a moment, I checked the next cardboard box and small items like paper maps, ballpoint pens, toothbrushes and sanitary products came out. According to Mashima-sensei's supplementary explanation, it seemed these items could be taken out freely during the exam period on the condition that they weren’t discarded and were retrieved later. They weren't bulky and it would be convenient and useful to have a few on hand, including some spares.

Next, I opened the large cardboard box. Tents, necessary and convenient for sleeping, revealed themselves, seemingly prepared in large numbers according to size.

"Tents, huh? We need to think about what to take and how much right away. The question is how much of the thinking we should burden Ayanokouji with __"

Hashimoto looked at me as if asking for my opinion. I nodded once in response.

"I will provide a guideline for what supplies are necessary and how much to carry. If there are objections, voice them then with your reasoning."

First, I would create a framework and then incorporate my classmates' opinions as necessary.

That was likely the optimal method to avoid wasting time.

Regarding life in tents, ideally everyone would use one tent per person. However, everyone carrying their own tent would be bulky and labor-intensive, reducing their mobility. Instead, we should narrow down the numbers from the start and focus on two-person and multi-person tents. That way it would be easier to alternate carrying them.

More important than that was how many people we needed to prepare for in total. As time passed, people were bound to retire. In other words, by the middle game—or if things went poorly, even the early game—large tents would become unnecessary and a reversal would occur where smaller one or two-person tents became more convenient. Since small tents were designed to be set up easily, they were also easier to prepare and pack up.

While considering the balance of which and how many tents to bring, I turned my eyes to the last remaining group of cardboard boxes.

Inside were the essentials: weapons for fighting.

"They look real up close. This is my first time touching something like this."

Hashimoto immediately reached out and picked up an assault rifle. Counting them, there seemed to be a total of forty main weapons prepared: twenty assault rifles, ten submachine guns, and ten shotguns. Then there were two handguns as sub-weapons. Since each Guard could carry one main weapon to serve as their combat mainstay, it was possible for everyone to have one.

"Man, the shotguns look hard to use, though. And they're heavy."

I picked up the three types of main weapons one by one and checked them briefly. I wouldn't know their true value until I actually used them, but as the initial quantities suggested, the assault rifle seemed to be the most user-friendly and well-balanced weapon. So, we'd likely choose submachine guns and shotguns only to make up for the shortage for the Guards.

"If we start with zero analysts, it looks like we can take two extra guns; what will you do?"

After checking the number of weapons, Morishita approached me and asked.

"Getting slightly more paintballs is certainly an advantage, but we will need analysts immediately. Considering the trouble of carrying and managing the guns at that time, it's hard to say if it's worth it."

It was certain that weapons couldn't be discarded on the spot like daily necessities; carrying them around and bringing them back was mandatory. If a Guard could use two weapons simultaneously, there might be irregular ways to use them, but that was against the rules and impossible, so any surplus would inevitably occupy someone's hands.

Every time an analyst or scout was eliminated, a new one would be appointed from the Guards, so the burden would increase.

"We'll go with a policy of not increasing our luggage."

"So you don't intend to take any surplus. At times like this, human psychology makes us want to prepare at least a little insurance; one tends to get greedy."

What if the weapon breaks? What if we run out of ammo?

That was why people wanted to take as many weapons and as much ammo as possible.

If everyone could keep fighting without getting eliminated, having spare weapons and ammo would be reassuring.

Therefore, it was natural for the psychology of wanting insurance to come into play.

"If we need something, we can just obtain it through an event. That's what the rules are for."

However, proceeding through the exam unscathed was difficult and there would undoubtedly be cases where students were eliminated without using up all of their supplies. Especially in this class, there were few students who could be relied upon offensively, so having surplus weapons and ammo was meaningless if they couldn't hit anything. Besides, the candidates for surplus weapons would be the lightweight submachine guns, but each gun only had sixty rounds, including the spare magazine. Moreover, the magazine specifications were different from the assault rifles, so swapping ammo would require taking bullets out one by one, which was a hassle.

Another reason I reached that conclusion was that there were other ways to preserve supplies, such as collecting them from eliminated students if weapons ran short or stocking spare magazines in specific backpacks beforehand.

"Well, I'll leave it to you. I want to push the responsibility onto Ayanokouji Kiyotaka anyway."

"That's fine."

After confirming the class's intentions, I declared what we needed to Mashima-sensei and received the supplies.

Boys with strength and stamina took charge of heavy items like water, while those less athletic and the girls were made to carry only the minimum belongings, like their own underwear and toiletries, to minimize their burden.

"There's something I want to talk about before the exam starts. Listen up."

I called out to my classmates, who were doing a final check for missing supplies and had them turn towards me.

"I want to tell you about the case where we get wiped out first in this special exam."

"You mean you're talking about losing before we've even started? Why?"

Matoba's expression darkened slightly as he asked, maybe sensing something ominous.

Or perhaps he thought I was making excuses for defeat in advance.

"There's an unavoidable penalty in that event. We'll be forced to expel someone. To avoid conflict, I want to confirm—to decide—who will be expelled first."

With that statement, a tense atmosphere overflowed from the classmates.

"It's true that I don't want to take the exam while thinking I might get expelled, but..."

"Ayanokouji-kun, can we say that's the right judgment?"

Sanada, having grasped the situation, also spoke up in agreement with Matoba.

"No student in our class has a Protection Point. In other words, if we take the total wipeout penalty, someone is definitely getting expelled. It's nothing but a hellish topic for that person."

As Matoba and Sanada said, few students would honestly accept a situation where their expulsion was confirmed if we lost.

"Or rather, just because you're the leader, you think you get to decide? Who gets expelled?"

Not a single student wanted to volunteer for expulsion.

Even more so, if a newcomer like me were to wave the baton, the rejection would be strong.

"Shouldn't we just decide when we lose, including whoever screwed up during the exam? Or, since we're all in this together, decide by drawing lots if we lose. That's about the only way, right?"

The people around me were clearly against deciding at that point, but I had my own thoughts.

"Hashimoto Masayoshi, it seems Ayanokouji Kiyotaka's policy is already decided. I understand his decision without even receiving an explanation from him."

"Seriously?"

Morishita nodded confidently at the doubting Hashimoto.

"If we end up receiving the penalty, then Hashimoto Masayoshi will be the first sacrifice to protect the classmates. This would be the fairest and most balanced conclusion."

"I see, if that's the case, I accept—like hell I would...! Good grief, give me a break. I was an idiot for even thinking about listening seriously for a second."

"Is that so? I am speaking with absolute, total seriousness, you know? Don't you think everyone other than Hashimoto Masayoshi would happily accept this proposal?"

"Well, if they're safe themselves, I guess they would."

"See? Everyone’s saved. No unfortunate victims."

"Then are you saying it's okay to make *me* the victim?"

"That can’t be helped. You’ll protect your classmates and become a star. A hero. Goodbye, Hashimoto Masayoshi. I will make sure to remember your existence for at least a week."

"Only a week, huh? Though even if it were a year, I'd never accept it. Anyway, you just forced my name out there hoping to actually make me the sacrifice, didn't you?"

No one welcomed having their name brought up as a candidate for expulsion in a situation like this.

Because the spearhead inevitably tended to point toward those in the class who were prone to being disliked.

"Tch, you noticed?"

"You seriously just clicked your tongue at me... I can't let my guard down around you at all."

After glaring at Morishita for just a moment, Hashimoto looked at me with clear anxiety.

"If Hashimoto is willing to volunteer, that’s fine, but unfortunately, I have already decided who will be expelled, and I won't change it even if there are objections."

"Wait a minute. I said this earlier, but just because you're the leader doesn't mean you can decide everything—"

I raised my hand to stop Matoba as he tried to protest.

"If we end up receiving the penalty, I’ll take on that role."

When I answered that way, the noisy classmates fell silent in an instant.

Even Mashima-sensei, who’d been listening silently with his arms crossed, lowered his arms, perhaps unconsciously.

"...Are you serious? You're the leader."

"Taking responsibility for defeat precisely because I *am* the leader. It sounds cool if I say it like that, but the reason is different. For better or worse, I’m an outsider. Not many days have gone by since I entered this class. If I, who joined to lead the class to victory, instead lead us to defeat, then bearing that responsibility is only logical."

"No, but, it's not like this is an exam where you alone can completely control victory or defeat, right? It's not exactly our class's specialty, even if I wanted to flatter us, you know? In the first place, what happens to the future of the class if you're gone?"

"Either way, you wouldn't be able to trust a leader who lost miserably without being able to do anything, right?"

"...I see... Well, I guess you can certainly look at it that way..."

What was required of the class, sinking in the lower ranks, was the basis for winning. That single point.

"I don’t entirely fail to appreciate your willingness to take responsibility as leader. If we’re forced to produce an expulsion, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka will

disappear. Isn't it fine for now? More than anything, we’re getting our immediate safety guaranteed for the time being."

Morishita said that it was better to leave it at that for now. Not to be cold, but rather in consideration of the mental burden on the classmates.

"However, if that really happens, you should offer yourself for expulsion through self-sacrifice, right, Hashimoto Masayoshi?"

"You're really dying to sacrifice me no matter what, aren't you?"

However, unlike when he was first named, no strong rebuttal came.

Partly because arguing with Morishita was pointless, but there was another reason.

If I disappeared from the class, it was almost synonymous with Hashimoto himself disappearing. Now that he’d abandoned his chance to join other classes, there were virtually no other means for him to graduate in Class A. Of course, even if that actually happened, he wouldn't accept it unconditionally and it wouldn't be something he could be convinced of, but he might be able to resign himself to the fact that he couldn't go to Class A.

He had no choice but to believe in my ability and stand pat for now.

Without an alternative candidate, there were no other options.

"Mashima-sensei. There is no problem with speaking about this decision to those around us, is there?"

"Of course. Whether the part about who’ll be expelled upon defeat is true or a lie, there is no problem with spreading it around in itself."

"Then, do you mind if I ask one favor?"

"What is it?"

"As I just said, in the event that an expulsion occurs in the class, I want to confirm it’s me. This is to prevent something like retracting it later. Announcing and determining it in advance is unrelated to the rules of the exam, right?"

"...Are you truly serious about this?"

"Of course. These aren't words that should be spoken merely to ease the anxiety of my classmates."

Without a firm commitment, I'd be allowed to resist—to say ‘I won't drop out after all’ if we lost. Even while taking the verbal abuse from it, I’d be able to push the blame onto someone else.

"I’m sorry, but according to the rules, I cannot make it definite at this stage. However, I’ll keep that thought in mind."

"Thank you very much."

Mashima-sensei couldn’t hide his bewilderment, but since a teacher couldn’t possibly suggest another expulsion candidate, he had no choice but to respect my personal opinion for the time being.

Part 3

"WELL THEN, THE explanation dragged on, but this is finally the last of it. Starting now, you'll hold a discussion amongst yourselves and decide who will serve in each role. Be careful, as if you're unable to decide within thirty minutes, the school will select them randomly."

Then Mashima-sensei put a little distance between himself and us.

It meant the time for teacher involvement was over and the judgment was left to the students.

"Commander, VIP and then other three positions, huh? This is the first major turning point."

If we made a mistake in assigning those crucial positions, it would undoubtedly affect our chances of winning.

To give an extremely easy-to-understand example, just giving the role of commander to students like Ike or Hondou from Horikita's class, or Ishizaki or Kondou from Ryuuen's class, would significantly lower that class's probability of winning. On the other hand, since Ishizaki had relatively high physical ability and stamina, he could be a valuable asset as a guard.

Before I could speak, Morishita quietly stepped forward.

"The commander is an extremely important position. They must survey the entire battlefield, anticipate other classes' movements and above all, determine the timing for using tactics. If so, we should determine it first while we're free to choose from all thirty-seven students in our class."

"She sure says the obvious with a self-important attitude, that girl."

While Hashimoto muttered just loud enough for me to hear, Tamiya also raised her voice in agreement.

"I agree with Morishita-san too, I guess. It will likely be a tough fight without the commander's instructions. Wouldn't Ayanokouji-kun be the natural choice? He is the leader, after all."

"No, wait a minute. It's definitely true that if Ayanokouji becomes commander, he'll surely produce results. But I'm strongly against it; it's better to have him take command on the ground. Guard is his best role."

"Guard? Never mind other roles, but why a guard of all things?"

"Isn't the reason obvious? It's because I view Ayanokouji as a special combat asset. Putting it bluntly, guards are pawns, but they’re the only ones given a means of attack. Aside from me and Kitou, we don't have many students skilled in this kind of combat. That's why it's absolutely better to have Ayanokouji fight on the front lines. Besides, just because he can't directly communicate with the commander doesn't mean he can't organize the class, right?"

The class was somewhat surprised by Hashimoto's passionate appeal.

The VIP was crucial for determining victory or defeat, but the core mission was simply not getting eliminated. There was nothing wrong with Hashimoto's plan to allocate power to the guards in order to avoid being defeated.

And even without direct communication with the commander, contact was still possible via the VIP, albeit requiring double the effort. One could even have the commander activate tactics. For those reasons, even before the discussion, I’d immediately ruled out the possibility of taking on the roles of VIP, analyst, or scout for myself. However, there was room for consideration regarding whether to be commander or a guard.

The fact that only one person in the class could track every student's GPS location made the commander position extremely attractive, as it directly influenced the chance of winning.

I had no way of knowing which students from other classes were moving where, how or what they were targeting on this vast uninhabited island. I had no choice but to leave myself to the flow of events as they unfolded. That was precisely why that position couldn't be taken lightly.

However, it wasn’t as if victory or defeat could be controlled entirely solely by the commander's ability.

"Besides, even Ayanokouji wouldn't want to entrust his fate to others, would he?"

I thought the role of giving instructions via tablet and radio wasn't a bad thing, but it was an unshakable fact that in this special exam, every student capable of utilizing their physical abilities should become a VIP or guard.

"You're already thinking about what to do with the positions, aren't you? Let’s hear what you've come up with."

Five types of positions. Where I ended up would be a choice with no room for error.

The commander position in particular, stationed at headquarters, was undeniably critical. They could check the current locations of all students via

GPS and use authority and tactics that could overturn the situation. Being the only position allowed to view the battle situation from a bird's-eye view, it couldn't be entrusted to an unskilled student.

If so, taking that position was certainly worth considering.

However, even as a compliment, Class C didn't have an abundance of physically gifted students; while students who could move like Kitou and Hashimoto existed. Other than them, the percentage of students who were average or below was higher. No matter how accurate the instructions the commander issued, it was meaningless if they couldn't be executed.

On the other hand, if I took the position of guard which possessed a means of attack, I could demonstrate my individual ability to the fullest. That was because it was possible to survive with skill even without relying on the commander's information or use of tactics.

"My hope is to be a guard."

"Alright, that's the correct answer."

"But only if there's someone suitable we can trust as commander."

Who to make commander. A certain person popped into my mind.

That was Morishita. For commander, I didn't want a simple honor student, but a student who had a different viewpoint from others. For that reason, I wanted to believe in Morishita’s ability.

I really did… But her eccentricity was a major concern and the telephone game communication through a VIP could easily lead to unwanted chaos.

Even considering all that, she was still a prospective commander, but most importantly, it depended on her own will.

When I glanced toward Morishita, she snapped her eyes open wide and met my gaze.

"If you’re asking me to take on the role of commander, I respectfully decline."

She thrust out her palm in clear refusal.

"I haven't said anything yet."

"Your eyes gave you away."

"Well, it’s true that I was considering it. Let's hear the reason for your refusal, just in case."

"Reason? Because I'll participate as a guard. When I see an uninhabited island, my old blood stirs no matter what. Yes, back then, I was known and feared as the Warrior Woman of the Dense Forest—no, this is an old story, please forget it. It's not worth discussing."

She said she wouldn't talk much about it, but she talked quite a bit. Since it was obviously one hundred percent fiction, I decided to forget it without hesitation.

However, now that it'd come to this, no other classmate came to mind who could demonstrate the ability I was looking for. Unfortunately, it meant that there were no suitable candidates, but...

In that case, by process of elimination, someone like Sanada who was well-connected with the whole class—

"Ayanokouji. If you're lost on who to make commander, could you let me handle it?"

It was Shimazaki who approached, as if to interrupt the brief silence.

"I don't know how well I'll be able to live up to your expectations, but I think I can handle the role without any issues."

Since he volunteered, I had no complaints regarding Shimazaki as a potential commander.

However, for better or worse, Shimazaki was an orthodox honors student. It was questionable just how flexible or quick-witted he could be. But since I had no other candidates worth considering enough to reject him, simply turning him down might cast a shadow over our future relationship.

"Can I leave it to you?"

"Yeah. I don't really like moving around on a deserted island in the first place. I figured I'd be more useful if I could focus on thinking."

Since the role of commander inevitably carried pressure, just showing a positive attitude was enough to consider him qualified.

"Understood. In that case, I'll leave the role of commander to you, Shimazaki. However, there's no need to burden yourself excessively. There's a limit to what a commander can do. I, the one who entrusted this to you, will take full responsibility for the outcome of the exam, win or lose."

When I said that, Shimazaki's tense expression relaxed slightly.

After that, I appointed the three students who volunteered themselves—Takemoto, Shiraishi, and Nishikawa—as VIPs.

Next, I appointed Sanada and Nakajima as analysts and Tsukaji as a scout.

Naturally, the remaining students were all given the role of guards, concluding the role assignment process.

"It seems all the roles have been decided. Now then, please take the necessary supplies and head to the starting point immediately. The student serving as commander should remain here to move to the headquarters after this."

Mashima-sensei instructed the students to follow him.

Since I would part ways with Shimazaki there and would be unable to make any direct contact until the end of the exam, I approached him quickly and called out to him.

"There's something I want to tell you before you leave."

"What is it?"

"No matter how trivial, I want you to report anything you find strange or unusual without hesitation."

"I've been entrusted with an important role; that goes without saying."

"That's not it. The more you feel the weight of the commander position, the more likely you are to miss what's right under your nose. A commander from another class laughed, or got angry. Changes in the GPS that feels slightly off but doesn't seem worth mentioning. Please report anything that concerns you personally, Shimazaki."

"That's... Won't receiving miscellaneous information throw the chain of command into chaos?"

"That's true, which is why it can't just be anyone. Let's narrow it down to one person."

"Who should I report to?"

"It doesn't matter who, but let's see. Let's go with Shiraishi for now. That should make things easier for you as well."

Just like Yoshida, I knew from our earlier exchanges that Shimazaki harbored feelings for Shiraishi.

If I could increase their points of contact, even a little, then it should be something he would welcome.

As for me, looking at Takemoto, Nishikawa, and Shiraishi... I didn't know all of them very well, so I judged Shiraishi to be the one I had the clearest read on.

"No, no... That actually makes it harder... Yoshida will get mad at me."

"There's no need to favor only Yoshida. To me, both of you are important friends."

"I can't believe you can say something like that with a straight face... But, still, Shiraishi is..."

"Is that so? Then Takemoto or Nishikawa—actually, Takemoto being a guy might be the safest option?"

Since they’re close, any clumsy exchanges might be passed straight from Nishikawa to Shiraishi.

"No, actually... You're right, Shiraishi is fine. I'll do it properly, so don't worry."

While still showing hesitation, Shimazaki corrected himself and said he would report to Shiraishi.

He must have reconsidered, figuring that if he had to talk to someone, it might as well be Shiraishi.

"One last confirmation. I think you'll be watching the GPS locations, but you can basically contact any VIP you want. However, when it comes to uncertain questions or feelings of unease, use Shiraishi to avoid adding unnecessary noise. The more people playing a game of telephone, the more it becomes a source of confusion. In other words, you can tell Shiraishi anything and everything, no matter what it is."

If a situation arose where Shiraishi was eliminated, we could just discuss what to do next at that time.

"...Right. Got it, let's do that."

I then verbally relayed a few more things I wanted him to look into after he arrived back at the base and Shimazaki readily agreed.

Before we left, as a final step, we all put on safety goggles to protect our eyes. Aiming for the head was against the rules, but for safety reasons, it was recommended to wear these goggles at all times during the exam; any unexpected trouble that occurred while they were off was entirely one's own responsibility. Also, it seemed the sensors were only on our gym uniforms, but hits were apparently detected even with a tracksuit on top, so wearing one was optional. However, it was probably safer to wear one, as it would help lessen the pain.

Chapter 2:
A Surprise Attack

NO MATTER HOW much my abilities began to be recognized, their distrust didn't disappear completely.

If they had any doubts about the policy, my classmates would immediately raise their voices in objection.

But the sight of me shouldering the resolve to be expelled, going beyond the mere title of leader, had a greater effect on my classmates than they could have imagined.

I described my first strategy to them.

It was to head north as soon as the exam began and be the first to cross G8.

Class C, having started from E12, began to walk in a scattered formation toward the target area with me at the head of the group.

It was a cautious move, also to quickly escape the situation of being sandwiched between Ryuuen's class to the west and Horikita's class to the east.

There was also the option of moving to area F13, right next to the headquarters, but if both Class A and B saw that and gave chase, we could've been cornered into D14, D15, E14 and E15, losing our escape route.

However, we didn't run or anything of the sort. Pushing through an unfamiliar forest, even if it was somewhat maintained, wasn't easy and this was the result of weighing the consumption of stamina versus the risk of injury.

Less than a minute after the special exam started, the first report reached Nishikawa, one of the VIPs.

"A call from Shimazaki-kun. He found out who the other classes' commanders are."

The audio received on our radio was connected to a single earpiece and it was only through this that we could pick up the voice of the commander, Shimazaki. In other words, Shimazaki's voice was inaudible to those around us and of course, no one other than the three VIPs were allowed to listen directly.

Each of the three radios was independent and it wasn't possible to talk to Shimazaki at the same time. Therefore, the system required us to always choose one person to communicate with him.

"Let's hear it."

Hashimoto, who reacted immediately to those words, stepped closer to Nishikawa.

The means of knowing who held what position in classes other than our own was very limited.

Only the commanders were gathered in the same headquarters, so their identities were inevitably revealed.

It was the first piece of important information to come in regarding the distant, unseen enemy.

"It's Matsushita-san for Class A, Kaneda-kun for Class B and Ichinose-san for Class D."

Among the leaders of each class, it seemed only Ichinose had chosen to be the commander herself. It may have been a process of elimination, given that her athletic abilities weren't particularly outstanding to begin with and that they lacked personnel who could fully demonstrate their skills as commander.

Matsushita becoming commander was both surprising and fitting.

Class A had several smart students, but for better or worse, they were similar in type to the students of Class C—your typical honor students. They weren't particularly adept at exploiting loopholes in strategy or noticing anomalies. In that context, the choice of Matsushita wasn't bad and she could be called one of the suitable candidates.

As for Kaneda, it could be simply described as a safe and solid choice.

I didn't think he would display any remarkable talent, but I also didn't think he would make any major mistakes.

Before long, my watch vibrated once in a short burst and displayed E11, as if to inform us that we'd entered a new area.

"So this is how ya figure out when you've moved areas, huh? It's convenient, I guess... but it'd be a real pain in the ass to rely only on the watch to travel long distances."

If we knew our current area and bearing, we could manage for the most part, but in reality, it was difficult to keep moving in the same direction and we would be forced to take detours. It would probably be better to avoid traveling for long periods without support from the commander.

While we were doing that, five minutes passed and the time came for the first GPS update. It was a crucial moment to learn how each class moved from their initial positions.

That time, the report went to Takemoto.

They'd probably switched from Nishikawa, likely to check if radio communications were working without issue.

After Takemoto conversed on the radio for a few dozen seconds, he spoke with a look of relief.

"He says we can relax for now. It looks like all of Class B's GPS signals are heading straight north, into area C11. And, uh, Class A is apparently in G11, also to the north."

"It's a relief we're not starting off with a battle, but this means we haven't escaped the pincer move, huh."

Just as Hashimoto muttered, if all three classes had simply moved north from their original areas, it couldn't be called an improvement in our situation.

"But at least we've confirmed that neither Class A nor Class B wants to fight from the get-go. That alone isn't so bad."

Takemoto said that if they intended to fight as soon as possible, they would've had to move toward Class C's position.

"What about Class D?"

It seemed they hadn't heard any information about Ichinose's class, the farthest away, so he asked back on the radio. Before long, a reply seemed to come back and Takemoto looked at me.

"He says Class D started walking toward J12, so, to the east. They plan on keeping their distance completely."

Their favorable starting position probably had something to do with it, but it could be called a choice typical of them.

From this first report alone, I could clearly see that Class D's policy was to avoid pointless conflict.

"We don't need to pick up the pace, then? If Class A is aiming for G8, there's a high chance they'll get there ahead of us, y'know?"

Hashimoto, walking right behind me, asked me in a low voice if there was any change in our policy.

"Even if we were to pick up the pace, the enemy would find out within five minutes. If they knew we'd quickened our movement, Class A would do the same. That would be nothing more than an act that increases risk."

In the first place, we weren't at a distance where we could overtake them in a mere five minutes from the start.

If we provoked the enemy and it turned into a race, that would only heighten the tension leading to a confrontation.

"If a fight breaks out recklessly, Class B might join in, huh..."

"That's the situation. I don't want to do anything that would give another class the chance to profit from our conflict."

After walking north within the same area for about five more minutes, ten minutes passed since the start of the exam.

"Ah, yeah. Go ahead."

It seemed a voice had come through on the radio, as Nishikawa responded immediately.

I had figured the next report would be from Shiraishi, but apparently that wasn't the case.

"What are the other classes' movements? Has anything changed?"

"Ah, sorry, but hold on a sec. I'm listening to it right now."

Shimazaki's voice came from her right ear and Hashimoto's from her left. As she seemed to have been spoken to by both at nearly the same time, Nishikawa made a momentarily annoyed face as she focused her attention on the radio.

Morishita pointed a finger at Hashimoto, making fun of him as he apologized with a gesture.

No matter how important this special exam was, the mood was probably to be expected since we hadn't entered a tense situation yet.

"If they keep heading north, Class A will be fine, but I wonder what Class B will do. Will they cut through the area from C7 to D6 where the slope is relatively gentle? Or will they stop partway..."

Hashimoto imagined each class's route of travel while glaring at the map.

"But in the end, it all depends on the event placement, I guess. If they're concentrated in the south, they'll probably turn back. What'll we do if an event pops up at about the same distance for both of us?"

"Of course, it also depends on the number of other events and the amount of supplies we can actually get, but in a situation where we're already short on food for the day, carelessly passing one up might be an irreversible mistake."

Even if we could endure the hunger and get through one night, on the second day, a significant drop in stamina would inevitably have a major negative impact on our movement, combat ability and health.

"So, that means you're thinking that you'll fight from the start if necessary, Ayanokouji?"

"Yeah. If I determine the supplies are necessary, I'll go for them without hesitation."

I conveyed my clear policy on engagement, which had been vague up until now, to my classmates via Hashimoto.

"...Yeah, thanks. I'll pass it on."

The exchange seemed to be over, as Nishikawa looked up with a smile.

"They say Class A is heading north at an unchanged speed. And it looks like all of Class B's GPS signals moved a little away from us to the northwest. They're near B10."

Hashimoto, who'd been waiting for the report, map in hand, immediately pointed to it to confirm the details.

He never neglected communication with the commander.

The GPS location information, updated once every five minutes, would be essential in close-quarters environments.

"If Ryuuen and his crew are heading for B10, that means they'll come out by the sea. I don't know if they'll keep heading north, but it's a relief that the lateral distance has increased. So for now, I guess we should be wary of Class A?"

If we proceeded at the same speed, by the time Class A reached G8, we would be about to enter F9. We would be allowing them to get completely ahead of us.

"If by some chance they ambush us, we might not be able to get through... What's the play, Ayanokouji?"

There were many options. We could pick up the pace now and at the five-minute GPS update, the commander, Matsushita, would notice the change and inform Class A, causing them to turn back for fear of a clash. Or, they could accelerate to be the first to break through to the northern area, thinking they absolutely had to get there first. The latter was more likely and in that case, we

could deliberately slow down and let Horikita's group go ahead. Alternatively, we could turn back to the starting point now, or stop and remain in the current area.

"If we just head straight for G8 without a second thought, won't we be starting a disadvantageous fight?"

"About that—"

Just as I was about to state my policy, Yoshida approached.

"I think getting into a fight right now would be bad news. We should stop for a bit and let Class A go on ahead. It's not like we'll be in trouble just because they get the lead, right?"

"Yeah. It all depends on where the events appear. For now, there's no advantage or disadvantage."

"If you decide to fight, I'll follow you. But, isn't there something we should be doing first? We don't even really know how to use these guns yet."

Yoshida's concern was a problem all my classmates shared.

That was why they were paying close attention to Horikita's class, with whom the probability of our routes overlapping was increasing.

But it wasn't just Class A we had to watch.

"So why don't we get on with a lecture on how to handle weapons and stuff?"

"I'm in agreement with that opinion."

Morishita spoke while pulling on the sleeve of my left arm, her shoulders rising and falling in short breaths.

"Are you tired already? You're out of breath."

"That couldn't possibly be the case. It's merely that this morning, I had an excess of energy and repeatedly dashed through the ship at full speed for about an hour. Perhaps that's why I've accumulated some slight fatigue."

True to her self-proclaimed title of 'Amazoness of the Dense Forest', she seemed to impose a considerable burden on herself.

"Got it. Let's let Class A go on ahead. We'll wait here for now."

It was Hashimoto who was surprised by that decision.

"Are you for real? You agreed to that pretty easily."

Hashimoto seemed to think that as long as a conflict could be avoided, he didn't care whether we went to the northern area first or second, but my

acceptance of our classmates' opinion seemed to have sparked some dissatisfaction and doubt in him.

He was probably worried that I didn't have a clear policy yet.

"It's not like I decided this because Yoshida told me to. I was also thinking we should wait and see for a bit."

"What, is that right? Then I guess this is your decision, Ayanokouji."

Hashimoto muttered, convincing himself.

It seemed to have served as some reassurance, as he accepted the policy without any further complaints.

I turned back to the classmates who were following me.

"Ten minutes have passed and we've gotten a small glimpse of each class's intentions. Our primary objective was to pass through G8 first, but allow me to revise that. First, we'll learn how to properly handle our weapons here and once we're ready to fight, we'll check the GPS positions again. From there, I'd like to search for a new route."

"Sounds good to me. I doubt anyone's gonna argue with that."

We switched to preparing for battle. Many of the students, led by Yoshida, were relieved by that decision.

The time immediately changed to one of confirming how to use the paintball guns with each other, deepening our understanding even if just a little.

However, no matter how many simulations we ran, there was much experience that could only be gained in actual combat.

We would never get a true feel for it until we actually pulled the trigger.

Five minutes passed quickly after we stopped and the latest GPS information was finally sent from the commander to Shiraishi.

Ryuuen's class seemed to have shifted slightly further northwest, but their movement was weaker than before and their progress slowed to a crawl. On the other hand, Horikita's class was passing through G10 at the same pace as before and they appeared to still be heading for G8. And Ichinose's class, who'd chosen a completely different route, was continuing endlessly eastward.

"There's new information from Shimazaki-kun. It seems one GPS from Class A has split off and is heading towards H9. Do you know what this could mean?"

"H9? On his own?...Does that mean it's Koenji?"

H9 was in the direction of the mountains. I wouldn't be surprised if Koenji headed off alone to enjoy some mountain climbing.

"If he's not planning to participate seriously, that's convenient for us, but... you don't think he's getting fired up like on the deserted island last year, do you? How should I take this?"

Hashimoto questioned me, his former classmate, about Koenji's movements.

Last year's deserted island exam, which all of the school years participated in.

The shock of him taking first place all by himself was likely still fresh in the minds of the second and third years alike.

"I can't say for sure, but if anything, the usual Koenji has no motivation. In almost every exam, he does as he pleases, just like in the deserted island exam two years ago where he briefly enjoyed the island and then retired on his own without cooperating with the class at all. Last year's deserted island exam was an exception to the exception, solely because Koenji himself proposed a condition to Horikita: 'complete freedom until graduation,' and promised she would acknowledge it if he took first place. Conversely, he also had her promise that if he placed second or lower, he would cooperate in the next exam."

"Well, damn. So Horikita got him to contribute to the class with his performance, but she lost the bet. She probably never dreamed he'd take first place all by himself. Which means, Koenji's clearly a free agent now. If that's the case, that's a huge help."

"That's right. If Koenji were to participate, he wouldn't be an easy opponent."

That being said, there was still no confirmation that the student who started acting alone was Koenji.

It was true that Koenji wasn't the type of man to cooperate voluntarily, but that wasn't necessarily the case when Private Points were involved. If someone were to offer him points from their own pocket in addition to the deserted island exam's reward, it was possible he would lend a hand.

I should reserve judgment until I could see the state of Horikita's class with my own eyes.

"Wouldn't it be a good idea to have the commander use a tactic?"

Sanada recommended using the person identification tactic.

"Nah, we shouldn't use it yet. This could be a strategy to get us to waste one of our tactics. Besides, if he's not gonna participate, it's a waste to use it on a guy like that."

Hashimoto, on the other hand, voiced his opposing opinion that we should still save it.

If someone were to split off and act alone, there was a 90% chance it was Koenji.

As long as he didn't rejoin Class A somewhere, it wouldn't be difficult to keep tracking him on the tablet. However, once it hit 6:00 p.m., the GPS wouldn't update again until 9:00 a.m.—

"Have the commander identify the GPS of the student who started acting alone."

"...You sure? It's almost definitely Koenji."

"I don't mind. It's worth a try. Let's use one as a test."

Nodding, Shiraishi began to notify Shimazaki to use a tactic on the student who separated from Class A.

The results would be known soon after this.

Before the results came back, I decided to ask Nishikawa to pass on a message as well.

"Nishikawa, I need you to contact Shimazaki."

"Huh? Now? Isn't he still talking to Asuka?"

"It doesn't matter. Try contacting him."

"Mm, okay."

With that, Nishikawa operated the radio, but she immediately removed her earphone and shook her head.

"It's not connecting."

"I see. So when a VIP is talking to the commander, the line is busy and you can't get through."

"Oh, so that's it... That's what you wanted to find out."

In other words, the line was basically one-to-one, with no interruptions. For example, if the VIP was far away, you couldn't speak simultaneously. You had to disconnect and reestablish the link each time.

"Then, after he's done talking with Shiraishi, I need you to pass on the message."

"So there really is something to report. Okay, what should I tell them?"

"Tell them I want to know the movements of the three classes every five minutes until the event starts. After that, it'll depend on the event's content, but if the situation seems to have calmed down, we'll take a short break."

Although the GPS positions updated every five minutes, it would've been wasteful to communicate every single time the clock struck the five-minute mark.

It was because the commander and the VIP would shoulder unnecessary fatigue from the seemingly endless task.

"Got it. I'll let them know."

Nishikawa put the radio and the connected earpiece back into her right ear.

Then, Nishikawa began to relay my message to the commander, Shimazaki, rephrasing it in her own words. And as if taking her place, Shiraishi, who'd just finished her communication, approached me.

"I was able to confirm that the GPS at H9 is Koenji-kun's. His role is apparently a guard."

"So it's that guy, huh. Let's just pray he goofs around for a bit and then calls it quits."

"Understood. For now, let's move on to the next matter."

Including the handling of the weapons, I decided to take care of one problem first.

"Let's decide on our positions and formation for when the whole class moves together from now on. Depending on the width of the path, we'll basically have two to four people side by side. For the VIPs' positions, we'll disperse the risk by placing one in each row: Shiraishi in the front, Takemoto in the middle and Nishikawa in the rear."

I assigned each and every classmate to one of the three groups, just like the VIPs.

In the front row, I placed Hashimoto and Kitou as the main guard protecting the rear.

I placed a larger number of students who seemed poor at exercise and combat in the middle row.

"Hey, wouldn't it be better to have Nishikawa in the front? She can really move when it counts, y'know?"

"I considered that at one point, but I figured it's important to place someone who can react instantly in the rear precisely because she can. Besides, Shiraishi isn't good at raising her voice and it won't carry far. But Nishikawa, on the other hand, has a loud voice."

When communicating from a distance, there was a potential risk of not being heard.

"I see, so the merits far outweigh the demerits, huh."

"In any case, the focus is on avoiding a situation where we could be wiped out all at once by dividing the class into three groups beforehand. Whether we're heading to multiple locations for an event, or if we happen to get separated unintentionally, as long as we move with the VIPs at the center, it'll be easier to regroup later."

Just then, Morishita approached, weapon in hand.

"I'm not pleased with being placed in the middle row, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. I'm the main strength of this class."

"You've got some nerve coming here to complain, Morishita... The middle suits you."

Exasperated, Hashimoto shooed her away with his hand, telling her to return to the middle row.

"To demote me and place a traitor in the front row instead... It seems we've been saddled with an incompetent leader. Let us go, Yamamura Miki."

"I-I'm... in the front row..."

"Oh? So in addition to a traitor, you've appointed tissue paper to the front row. You are beyond saving."

To be spoken to like that just for deciding the formation.

Muttering complaints, Morishita headed toward the middle row.

And as soon as she reached the middle row, she looked back at us and shook her head in exasperation. I decided to ignore her.

I had Shiraishi relay the details of how we divided the rows, including the VIPs, to Shimazaki.

From now on, this would also serve as a guide for Shimazaki to look at his tablet and decide who to contact via radio depending on the situation.

Part 1

SEVERAL MORE MINUTES passed. While discussing the various ways to handle their weapons, the guards experimented with different stances and grips.

Meanwhile, I looked through the details in the rulebook, at the rules that would incur a major penalty.

Major Penalties (For each infraction, a deduction of 100 Class Points and in serious cases, expulsion.)

-Acts such as assault, restraint, or destroying or stealing guns.

-A student who has been judged 'out' intentionally continuing to fight back.

-Acts such as stealing or taking items from other classes.

-False reports in response to school inquiries.

-Other behavior that undermines the dignity of the special exam.

Mashima-sensei also verbally explained about attacking after being judged 'out', but unless it was intentional—including attacks on opponents outside of exam hours—it wasn't subject to a penalty. However, even if someone feigned an unintentional attack, the target wouldn't be declared 'out' and would be given relief, so there was little point in pushing the boundaries. Of course, it wasn't impossible to find loopholes if one looked for them, but it wasn't worth the risk of breaking the rules.

This was because the school had a strong will to thoroughly enforce the rules. It was precisely because this was an uninhabited island exam where gray areas could emerge that I understood the phrase 'behavior that undermines the dignity of the special exam' was a warning that they would show absolutely no mercy.

Since actions that were close to a gray area came with high risks, it was safe to assume that even Ryuuen wouldn't be able to execute them.

"Ayanokouji, we got a new report from Shimazaki. He says Class A's advanced to the point where they'll be entering area G8 soon."

Hashimoto was the first to react to the new report from the commander.

"Got it, the situation with Horikita's class. What's next?"

"Hold on. Before that—it seems Koenji's GPS has already entered I9."

"I9? Damn, he's fast."

There was no one other than Koenji who could move as swiftly on a mountain path as on a flat road.

"What about Ryuuen's class?"

"Hold on a sec. Shimazaki, what's the status of Class B?"

He pressed for an answer from the commander, but with the VIP acting as an intermediary, the process was time-inefficient.

"Not being able to talk to the commander directly... this might be more of a pain than I thought."

Growing impatient from the unavoidable, forced wait, Hashimoto let out a sigh.

"The exam's only just begun. There's no need to rush."

Morishita, who sat down on the ground to take a complete break, muttered without looking at Hashimoto.

"This special exam is on a deserted island, so the rewards are pretty huge, y'know. Plus, if we get hit with the total annihilation penalty, someone's gonna get expelled. It'd be unreasonable not to get fired up."

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka said as much, but when push comes to shove, Hashimoto Masayoshi is our only choice."

"Hey, don't just go deciding that on your own. You should be the one to say something to her spouting off whatever she wants."

"..."

"Ah, Ayanokouji? You're not... If we lose, you're not actually gonna make me the sacrificial lamb for expulsion, are—"

"Relax. I won't do that."

"You sure about that? What was with that pause just now? Huh?"

"I was just responding to the setup."

"...You better be telling the truth."

"You seem to have gotten more of a scare than I expected."

Hashimoto forced a wry smile, looking annoyed at Morishita for her constant retorts.

"It seems Class B has stopped moving for now, just like us."

That report came from Takemoto's mouth, and Hashimoto nodded once.

"They're probably just relieved to have gotten some distance from Ayanokouji. They're likely doing the same as us—using the time to talk things over. Whether or not you've been coached on how to use the weapons makes a huge difference in accuracy, after all. Heh, I'll bet they were on pins and needles, worried we'd come to the west side."

It seemed Ichinose's class had also stopped and perhaps shifted to discussions as well. I had Takemoto reply that no reports on Class D were necessary for the time being unless there were major developments.

A little while later, a radio call came in from the commander, this time for Shiraishi.

"He says, 'I'm reporting because we've learned a few things about Ayanokouji-kun's request.'"

After she relayed that, Shiraishi once again listened to the voice coming from her earphone.

"Apparently, the commanders were informed that during the special exam, direct contact, private conversations and any message-like exchanges are prohibited. And the tablet's screenshot function is disabled; even if you try to use it, it will only save a completely black screen as the picture—that's what he said."

"I thought I saw him talking to Shimazaki when we split up, but he even asked him to check on all that?"

"I had him look into it because I thought there might be things he could do outside of his official authority as commander, but it seems they're being monitored more strictly than I anticipated. They may be sharing the space called the main base, but the premise is likely that the commanders are all in separate locations."

"Also, it seems the GPS on the tablet's map has individual tags, and he found out it's possible to take notes on the GPS of students from other classes. So, he said he made sure to put Koenji-kun's name on the GPS marker at I9, where he's isolated."

"Got it. Tell Shimazaki I said thanks, and to let us know anytime if anything else comes up."

I broke my gaze from Shiraishi, who nodded and I took off my goggles for a moment. I looked at the classmates I'd lined up in a column and with an assault rifle in one hand, I moved to a place where everyone could see me.

"Once the event begins, our movements will become hectic. Furthermore, depending on the quality of our supplies, the possibility of combat will gradually increase. That's why I'm going to take the time now to properly lecture you all on how to use these weapons. Then, after the lecture, I want one of the guards who isn't confident in their fighting ability to temporarily give their weapon to one of the three VIPs, one after another. And every few hours, collect it and have a different guard hand over their weapon. I want them to constantly be in rotation with someone."

"What do you mean by that? The VIPs are forbidden from using weapons, right? No... is that exactly why...?"

He had a moment of doubt, but Toba immediately understood what it meant.

"Yeah. One method for identifying another class's VIP is to see if they can use a weapon. If we get into an unexpected fight, it's entirely conceivable that they'll prioritize targeting any student without one."



Of course, during an engagement, one guard would be unable to function, but I wanted to include the element of misdirection as a form of insurance.

"So this will stop the enemy from easily identifying our VIPs?"

"That's right. However, just in case, when you hand a weapon to a VIP, I want you to be sure to remove the magazine and check the chamber as well. I want to reduce the risk of them firing reflexively when attacked by another class to zero."

"Huh? What was that? Chamber?"

"The firing chamber—basically, there might be cases where a round remains inside even after you remove the magazine. I plan on carefully checking the structure of these paint guns later to see how they actually work, but if we build this routine from the start, we can prevent mistakes."

I took the assault rifle in my hands, showed them how to remove the magazine and demonstrated how to check the chamber. Then, I handed it to Toba and taught him the method via a hands-on demonstration.

"...You're awfully knowledgeable about this stuff. You look like you belong holding a weapon, too."

He muttered that after checking it himself a few times to learn the movements.

"Regarding this type of firearm, Ijuuin from Horikita's class is very knowledgeable and he taught me a few things in the past. It seems that knowledge, which I initially thought was useless, has proven to be useful."

"Is that so... In that case, they'll probably adopt a similar strategy, of course."

It was true that Ijuuin was knowledgeable about guns, but he never taught me anything in the past.

I'd never held this type of gun outside of the toy ones from the culture festival, but I knew about them because I had experience learning about firearms through my knowledge from the White Room.

That being said, Toba had no way to confirm whether this story was true, so it likely wouldn't be a problem.

"Anyway, I understand the aim. I should also practice when I have some free time, right?"

I recalled that Toba, who was athletic, was also good at basketball. Since he also achieved good results in P.E. classes, he would likely be a more capable

fighter than the other students. Perhaps it was because he felt he had to be the one to lead that he was so proactively stepping forward.

From there, I settled down in that spot, taught them how to handle the weapons and showed them things like how powerful the shots were by actually firing a few rounds at a tree.

I really wanted to let everyone have a test shot, but I wanted to avoid wasting ammunition in the current situation.

Radio reports came in periodically and after another ten minutes, Horikita's class was still pushing north without changing course, while the remaining two classes appeared to have stopped to discuss and were continuing to formulate their strategies.

Just as I was getting the hang of the weapons, Kitou approached me with an assault rifle in hand.

"...Let me confirm something, just to be sure. You're aiming to take first place in this exam... Am I right to think that?"

"That's surprising, Kitou. I didn't expect you to ask something like that."

"A survival game... This feels like nothing more than playtime, but if we're aiming to win, I'm going to take this seriously."

"Ayanokouji is betting his own expulsion on this, you know? Of course he's going to play for real."

As if worried that infighting amongst us would cause trouble, Hashimoto immediately cut in here as well.

"It's certain that aiming to lose isn't an option."

He came to get a verbal commitment to win from me, who was staking my own expulsion on this challenge.

Was it perhaps because he couldn't sense any fighting spirit from me? Or was it simply that Kitou's intuition was at work?

"But you've touched on a good point."

Either way, it seemed I had to revise my evaluation of Kitou just a little.

"Unfortunately, even if you want first place, it seems I won't be able to live up to that expectation."

When I answered him so honestly, Kitou faintly furrowed his brow and narrowed his eyes.

"...In other words, you're not confident?"

Kitou's eyes, which already held a sharp glint, grew even more intense and stern.

"I don't think it'll be an easy win, but that's not it."

I paused, looked away from Kitou in front of me for a moment and glanced around at my surroundings.

Of course, not a single student was missing.

"This is a good opportunity. It might seem like I'm derailing things a bit, but please listen."

I addressed all of my classmates, who were watching to see what I would say.

"I believe this class's ultimate goal, the rank we should be aiming for, is second place."

In an instant, everyone there fell silent.

"Second place? I mean, I wouldn't say it's a bad goal, but what's the deal with aiming for that right from the start?"

Everyone first aimed for first place. That was the natural mindset one should have.

That was precisely why Shimizu was surprised and tilted his head. He didn't even try to hide his dissatisfaction with the passive answer.

"The reason is simple and clear. I'm thinking we can give first place to Ichinose's class."

"...Huh? What the hell is that? I have no clue what you mean."

With the exception of a very small number of people like Hashimoto and Morishita, it was natural that they wouldn't be able to understand what I was saying.

The alliance between Class C and Class D that I'd arranged between Ichinose and myself.

The special exam was the most suitable time to bring up that topic and it was a situation where it was essential to announce it at this point.

"It's not easy to rebuild this class, which has fallen to Class C over the past year and raise it to Class A. I think you all can understand that, given your past where you'd all but given up."

Even after hearing the hard-to-accept statement that I intended to give up first place, my classmates were surprised and confused, but they didn't get terribly upset.

They seemed willing to listen first before raising any objections.

"I transferred to raise this class to Class A. But given that the hurdle is actually very high, we must use a strategy to win efficiently. And one of those important strategies is Ichinose's class—"

At that moment, Hashimoto showed a dubious look for an instant.

Or rather, it should be said that he couldn't suppress his impulse.

"Hey, Ayanokouji..."

He hurriedly came between the students and forcefully interrupted me.

Then he leaned in close and whispered in my ear.

"You should probably stop talking about *that* here. No matter how you look at it, now's not the time..."

We were just about to all pull together to win this special exam.

It was the most unsuitable topic to bring up at such a time.

"What is this 'one important strategy'?"

"Oh, that's— uhm—"

Even Hashimoto couldn't seem to come up with a good excuse on the spot and his agitation was clearly showing.

However, I ignored Hashimoto's advice and words and continued.

"That strategy, I believe, lies in an alliance with Ichinose's class."

I said it.

Hashimoto's expression was striking to see up close, but the looks on my classmates' faces were even more intense.

"Wait... what? An alliance...? What are you—"

In front of the bewildered students, I began to explain the advantages of the alliance.

I explained that we should form a cooperative relationship, something that couldn't be established with Class A or Class B, who we should be chasing. It was a partnership that could only be realized because we were both lower-ranked classes and because we were dealing with the trustworthy Ichinose's class.

I verbally conveyed the specific contract details of the alliance to my classmates.

When faced with an exam where all four classes competed, the win would be given to the class with even one fewer Class Point. Of course, it wasn't about giving away victory for free.

If we conceded the victory here, this class, which would then fall to Class D, would in turn gain the full cooperation of Ichinose's class.

"In this survival exam, we're supposed to be fighting three other classes. That means we're facing nearly 120 enemies, but an alliance can change that premise. I don't need to explain in detail how effective that would be."

"If Class D is on our side, we can focus just on Class A and Class B... huh."

"It's not just that. At the same time the number of enemies decreases, the number of allies increases by that same amount. That alone brings victory much closer."

Making the most of the alliance was vital.

"I think it's a good idea. It'd be no laughing matter if we gave it our all and ended up in last, or third place at best. But if we can take it a little easier and secure second, that's not a bad deal. We can steadily earn Class Points and close the gap with A and B. After this, there should be another academic exam, too."

With that, we would accelerate further and by then all four classes would be on even footing. Those were Hashimoto's words, describing a prospect that wasn't unrealistic, but many students were left with things they couldn't quite digest.

Morishita's gaze alone seemed to say, *'You really shouldn't be sticking your neck out.'*

Morishita, who also knew about the alliance, probably felt the same way as Hashimoto.

"If you're bringing up an alliance now, that means things are already moving behind the scenes, right?"

How I answered here was extremely important.

That we already formed the alliance and that it was now unavoidable.

Answering like that would be easy, but it wasn't the optimal solution.

"You could say a provisional agreement has been made. The other side is keen on it."

"Well, of course they are. They've got no way of moving up otherwise."

It wasn't just that he was looking down on Class D, but an answer based on the flow of events so far.

Not only the harsh Matoba, but many of the people here thought so.

"You can refuse—or rather, reject the idea—but it's not something we can pick up and drop as we please. If you reject it, we'll never be able to team up with Class D again and depending on the situation, there's a slight risk that Class D could team up with Class A or Class B. That's something you'll have to be prepared for."

"That's a pretty selfish proposition."

It was a normal reaction to want to criticize the part about trying to form an alliance.

Matoba was dumbfounded, at a loss for words.

As if slipping through that brief moment of silence, Motodoi lightly raised her hand.

"Let me say something, too. This talk about an alliance... do we have to decide right now? No matter how you look at it, this isn't the right time. I'll admit, this special exam isn't exactly in our favor. But to throw away first place and aim for second just to get a better advantage... I can't accept that. It's less about not wanting to let Class D win and more that I don't want to throw away our *own* chance of winning."

"I agree. So basically, we're the ones who have to suck up and bring them a gift, right? *'We'll make you number one, so let's team up.'* What's up with that? In case you forgot, we're the ones who are supposed to be on top here."

He avoided saying it directly, but he probably wanted to say that if anyone was going to be bringing a gift, it should be Class D.

I could sense that feeling from Matoba—no, from many of my classmates.

"Just when this pain-in-the-ass exam starts, you drop a bombshell like this on us. And the fact that Hashimoto's so into the idea is shady as hell."

Morishita's gaze changed to a triumphant one, as if to say, *'See?'*

Hashimoto, who was normally the type to be suspicious if anything, had been in favor of the alliance from the very first word. It was only natural for them to be dissatisfied, thinking he must have been told about it beforehand.

Wondering if he overstepped this time, Hashimoto involuntarily looked up at the sky.

"How about we discipline them?"

"No need."

But I had no intention of blaming Hashimoto for his actions and words, nor did I find him annoying.

Rather, I considered it a necessary spice.

"Look, we're not going to form an alliance just from this one discussion. There's no way. That said, I'm not going to reject the idea out of hand, either. So we can have time to really think about whether this is necessary, can't we postpone this conversation until after the special exam is over?"

Considering that no objections erupted from the other students, it seemed any further effort would be a waste of time.

There was no need to struggle here any further.

Negative opinions and criticisms of the alliance were things that could be easily overturned with a single change in perspective. All I had to do was make them feel that what they thought they didn't need was, in fact, necessary.

This was a big step toward that goal.

"My bad for bringing this up so suddenly. Like Matoba and the others said, let's talk about the alliance again after this special exam is over. For now, just forget we had this conversation."

When I answered in a way that seemed to concede, Matoba, as if his rising anger had subsided, nodded emphatically.

Just then.

A faint wind blew.

The sound of rustling trees.

At the same time, I faintly picked up on multiple other sounds from a distance.

No one else sensed anything.

Of course.

Until just a moment ago, they had been completely at ease, hearing reports on the other classes' locations from Shimazaki every five minutes.

Deep down, no one wanted to engage in combat this early in the game.

That assumption had bred carelessness.

"Hashimoto."

"Hm?"

Sensing a change in my demeanor, Hashimoto tilted his head curiously.

My gaze was directed past Hashimoto, past the rear guard and deeper into the forest where visibility was poor.

"—Everyone, run! Now!"

"Huh? What do you mean by—"

Immediately after, our surroundings erupted as if they'd been brought to a sudden boil. It was as if the volume on a muted television had been cranked to MAX all at once.

"There they are! Fire, fire, fire!!"

"It's Class C! Get 'em!"

"Go, go, go, go, go!"

Numerous shouts came from within the forest. I couldn't identify whose voices they were, but I was certain of one thing: they didn't belong to the boys or girls of our Class C.

In an instant, they appeared from deep within the trees.

At the same time, no, even before that, a rain of paintballs flew into view.

No, it might be more accurate to call it a torrential downpour raging from the side.

It was a storm of paintballs, far from accurate, that relied on sheer numbers.

More than half of them were blocked by the large, natural trees that served as cover and missed their mark, but the remaining paintballs reached the Class C students.

A paintball hit and burst on the shoulder of Morishige, who was standing at the very back.

He had yet to process what just happened and wore a dumbfounded look.

Immediately after, a paintball struck Motodoi in the hip and she let out a small shriek from the impact.

From there, their thoughts instantly plunged into a state of panic.

Some realized they were enemies and tried to raise their guns, only to be covered in paint.

Others dropped their weapons to escape, or were hit with paintballs as they went back for the backpacks they'd forgotten at their feet.

In just a few short seconds, the casualties began to mount among the classmates at the rear. Then, the figures of the enemy came into view, revealing which class was behind the surprise attack.

But there was no time to talk about that now.

"Your packs, don't forget your packs! Just run!"

Hashimoto shouted to his classmates, waving his arm broadly to beckon them over.

"We don't even know how many of them there are. For now, run! Just run!"

Hashimoto repeatedly shouted, but his voice was mostly drowned out by panicked thoughts and screams.

"Kitou—"

I was about to give an order to Kitou in the back, but it seemed there was no need for a detailed verbal explanation.

The moment our eyes met, or perhaps even before they did, his brain—or maybe his body—had already understood the predicament and he broke into a run.

For all of Class C to turn their backs and flee would only increase our losses unnecessarily.

Therefore, having a few people stay here and hold off the enemy was one of the few options available.

Kitou immediately took cover behind a large nearby tree and began to counterattack.

He showed a glimpse of skill and courage that made it hard to believe he'd never fired a single shot in a real fight before.

He must have taken out one of his opponents, as an alarm from a wristwatch rang out from deep within the unseen trees.

The enemy, who'd been attacking on the momentum of their surprise attack alone, was halted for the first time and took cover behind a large tree.

Inspired by Kitou's swift counterattack, Machida and several other boys, though a bit late, also managed to take cover and began firing back blindly, with no time to take proper aim.

"We'll leave this place to Kitou and the others and retreat."

I called out only to the front line, which hadn't taken any casualties yet and hastily left the area.

Shiraishi and Hashimoto followed, moving frantically to catch up.

Angry shouts, screams and the sounds of paint guns firing flew through the air.

With those sounds at my back, I took the lead and forged a path forward.

It became clear as I actually passed through. While nature remained untouched, simple, narrow, man-made paths were made in places to make it easier for people to walk. This uninhabited island might be subject to some changes in the future. Nevertheless, we couldn't let our guard down for a moment. One step off that path and you were in the deep woods. If we didn't flee prepared to get a few scrapes, the damage would surely have been greater.

Part 2

OUR WATCHES SWITCHED to F12 as we fled southeast.

Around that time, the distance between us and the students chasing us from behind had begun to widen slightly, so I slowed our pace.

"You've gotta be kidding me... The exam's just started, how many people got taken out just now!? Shira—no, Takemoto, hurry up and tell Shimazaki to report the situation! Why'd you let Class B get so close!?"

Shiraishi, one of the VIPs, was gasping for breath. Seeing that she was struggling just to keep up and had no energy to communicate with the commander, a classmate demanded that Takemoto send the message in a harsh tone.

Takemoto, who also seemed to be in pain, continued to jog while speaking into his radio.

"Hah? No, hah, wh-what the hell, hah... I-I'll tell him!"

A message came back from headquarters and Takemoto looked at Hashimoto, muttering as if to himself.

"He says there was no sign of any other classes approaching our vicinity on the tablet. And that Class B's position still hasn't changed!"

A sorrowful voice echoed through the forest.

"What the hell!"

Yoshida, unable to hide his irritation, exhaled a ragged breath toward the sky.

Anyone could figure out why this was happening if they just calmed down a little.

But right now, they were still in the midst of a panic and probably didn't have the composure to think.

Considering the strain on the class, I slowed my pace from a jog to about a brisk walk.

"The answer is quite simple. Ryuuen's class deliberately kept its distance after the start to make it seem like they were avoiding engagement. This is certain, since they were far away during the first three GPS updates. But it was all a pretense. A setup for an attack. All that was left was to have their commander activate the 'Disable All GPS' tactical card before the next update and their preparations were complete."

From that point, the GPS positions froze in place for thirty minutes.

The scouts' watches also showed no reaction while the tactical card was in use. Meanwhile, Ryuuen's side only had to receive information from their commander, Kaneda, at any time and charge toward our precise location.

With more than enough time, they had pulled off a successful surprise attack.

"So they used their one-time-only big move right from the get-go..."

Yoshida and the other classmates were frustrated.

Easier said than done. It was undeniably a gamble.

Even if we hadn't noticed the attack, it wouldn't have been such an easy ambush if we had finished our discussion and immediately resumed moving.

"Judging by the speed of their decision, they must have been planning to use it from the moment they understood the rules of the special exam."

At the start, every class wants to decide on a strategy and learn how to handle their weapons as quickly as possible. If anything, their decision was likely based on the assumption that our pace would be slower.

It was a strategy that truly felt like Ryuuen, a display of his decisiveness.

Of course, there were other factors behind the success of this surprise attack, but—

But there was no point in touching upon them and talking about it here and now.

"A surprise attack, huh... If they'd just waited and watched, another class might've crushed each other for them. Heh... That bastard Ryuuen, he took on a pretty big risk, didn't he?"

Exasperation, impatience and anger. And then, admiration.

Hashimoto's candid feelings were conveyed to those around him through his words.

When I looked back at the students following me, I saw one who was starting to fall far behind.

As the one in the lead, I drastically slowed our pace and came to a complete stop in about three seconds.

"Hey, Ayanokouji, what's wrong? Shouldn't we be putting more distance between us?"

"No, this is about our limit. If we force ourselves to keep going, we'll only increase the risk of our allies dropping out."

After Morishita, who'd been lagging the furthest behind, finally reached us, she plopped down onto the ground.

"Hah... hah... I suppose this is because I ran a full marathon in the schoolyard yesterday, isn't it... hah."

I wondered if she was the type of person who couldn't help but tell a needless lie about everything.

"Jeez, Morishita. You volunteered for this and now look at you."

"Don't say that. It's not just Morishita; the girls, especially, are close to their physical limits."

There was more than just one or two students breathing heavily, their shoulders heaving.

"Ah, oh, right... Yeah, that makes sense."

It would be one thing if it were a girl who was confident in her athletic ability, but it was nothing short of cruel to expect the same level of stamina from the other girls as from the boys.

"Just as it's tough on us, it's also difficult for them to have their whole group chase us. The proof is that we can't even see them right now."

The forest behind us was now blanketed in a silence that made the earlier commotion feel like a lie.

I gave instructions for everyone to drink at least one sip of water, which we wanted to conserve as much as possible.

After they finished their light rehydration and caught their breath, Yoshida, perhaps having calmed his head, spoke up.

"Thinking about it normally, there was no way to defend against that surprise attack, was there...? It's a flaw in the rules."

Leaning against a tree, he grumbled like that.

I understood how they felt, but whether or not it was truly an unforeseeable surprise attack was questionable.

What was important for noticing it quickly was a commander who could survey the entire situation.

The moment the full GPS shutdown began, the five-minute position updates would stop completely. In that case, by carefully watching the tablet, one could have noticed that no one was moving an inch. No matter how still people were, it would be unnatural if no one moved for five, or even ten minutes.

If there was no change, it was necessary to report that there was no change.

But Shimazaki overlooked it.

The commander's ability directly affected the class's overall ability.

A bad example of that had blatantly emerged just after the exam began.

Of course, I couldn't blame him. It was easy to imagine that he'd been staring intently at his tablet without letting his guard down, as the exam had only just begun. Perfectly recognizing the positions of well over 100 GPS signals was an impossible task for someone with ordinary ability.

While the confusion had yet to subside, Takemoto contacted Shimazaki and the process of organizing the information on who was safe and who was out began.

I left the exchange with Shimazaki to Takemoto and, a short distance away, went about the task of confirming what supplies we were missing.

Before long, Hashimoto, who'd been standing beside Takemoto, approached me with a grim look on his face.

"Kitou got taken out after that. Well, not that I thought he'd be able to get away."

"It's understandable. The surprise attack was likely carried out by all of Class B. He did well to buy us time under those circumstances."

If his role of holding them back hadn't worked, the damage would have been much greater.

"Apparently, the three who escaped late were Yano, Sawada and Tsukasaki. But they don't know our position or the enemy's, so they'll be wandering around on their own for a while. It'd be great if they could make it to a position where we can meet up..."

As for that, there was nothing to do but wait, since we couldn't go and get them right now.

"And sorry to keep piling on the bad news, but it seems Rokkaku left his weapon behind when he ran. Should we just be straight with the school and report it as lost? Or should we go back for it at some point?"

A short distance away, Rokkaku was bowing his head apologetically.

"Lost is fine. Tell the commander immediately and have them request the school to retrieve it. As for Rokkaku, who lost his weapon, we can just put him into one of the vacant role slots as needed."

When I asked Rokkaku directly if he was okay with that, I received a firm reply along with another apology.

Hashimoto, who'd been watching, looked at me with some wonder.

"The only saving grace in this screwed-up situation is that you're as calm as ever."

Not even an hour passed since the special exam began.

During a long special exam spanning several days, even if the current situation was a crisis, a leader who was running around in confusion wouldn't be able to pave a way forward.

"Seriously... you think we can still pull this off?"

"It'd be a lie to say it has no effect. In fact, in less than an hour since we started, our Class C's position has become terribly bad."

"...Yeah."

"Still, it's not as if our chance to win has disappeared. If one of our VIPs was taken out, we just have to take out two of theirs. If another one of ours is defeated later, we'll just take out three in return."

"I see. In that case, this is the last time I'll be acting so weak. I'll trust that if I follow your orders, we'll find a way out of this. So, what's the plan from here?"

"We have a few options, but for now, maintaining our distance from Ryuuen's class is an absolute must."

"So you're saying they might try to lure us into a false sense of security and attack again."

"I think they stopped their pursuit considering the possibility that we might turn to ambush and counterattack, but they might come for us if they see an opening. This is just a precaution."

Even though we pulled away, it was a distance they could close with just a short run.

It could hardly be called a safe zone.

"Just in case, I need you to go and check one more time if any students are having trouble at this stage. I'd like you to tell them to talk to me about anything if there's something they don't understand or are worried about."

When I asked him, Hashimoto readily agreed without the slightest look of displeasure and headed toward our classmates.

As if taking his place, Shiraishi, who'd been listening to our conversation nearby, approached.

"I overheard a little of your conversation with Hashimoto-kun. Even in a situation like this, you aren't worried that you might be the first to receive the penalty for being wiped out, are you?"

"I'm not worried. If that's what happens after we've done our best, I'll simply accept it."

"But it won't end as a simple defeat. In the worst-case scenario, Ayanokouji-kun, you would be expelled and our path to Class A would be closed off."

"If you don't like that future, then we have no choice but to win."

I thought she might be doubting our victory, but apparently, that wasn't the case.

"Then let's go and seize victory together."

When I turned only my gaze to Shiraishi, she continued to look back at me with a soft expression.

There was no trace of anxiety in her attitude or her gestures.

If anything, she even seemed to be enjoying the current crisis somehow.

Why was that?

What was the driving force behind that thought?

A faint sense of unease began to sprout.

But I put that aside.

I had to face reality for what it was.

That our class had lost fifteen people, including one VIP, who were now out.

There, I once again finished organizing all the information.

Three students, Yano, Sawada and Tsukasaki, were not out, but they were currently separated from the main group.

Shimazaki was the only one who knew their current location, but we couldn't go rescue them until Class B's GPS jamming tactic wore off. On the other hand, Ryuuen's group could see the trio's position, so it was highly likely they already formed a group and sent them out.

"If only Shimazaki had noticed something was wrong..."

Perhaps Hashimoto was thinking the same thing I was, as he muttered in a regretful tone.

"That's incorrect, Hashimoto Masayoshi. The one at fault is Ayanokouji Kiyotaka."

Morishita pointed her index finger straight out, thrusting her arm forward until it was just a few centimeters from my eyeball.

"A true leader would have told the commander—"

Just as she started to say that, I immediately raised my assault rifle.

"What do you think you're—"

Morishita, right in front of me, must have thought she was about to be shot for her insolence, as her pupils dilated slightly.

Before she could finish her sentence, I grabbed her shoulder with my left arm, pulled her toward me and pulled the trigger once.

At almost the same instant, Class B's Kondou, who emerged silently from the shadows, was about to aim his muzzle at me.

A single bullet hit Kondou square in the chest with a dry crack and Kondou, who'd been trying for a silent ambush, stood there dumbfounded.

Before anyone could understand what just happened, an alarm blared from Kondou's watch.

Frustrated that he'd been hit just as he aimed at me, he took his finger off the trigger.

"Damn it, you knew?!"

He must have been following us and searching the area for a while. Kondou's breathing was incredibly ragged.

"Impressive, hitting me in one shot... and how'd you even notice me?"

Breathlessly, Kondou asked me how I knew.

"You must have been pretty exhausted. You weren't able to completely silence your footsteps. It also helped that I was your primary target, not just anyone. Wasting time trying to line up the perfect shot was your downfall."

Despite his failure, Kondou's somewhat satisfied expression left an impression on me.

"Yeah, well... taking out the leader would've been a huge score. Guess I should've just fired randomly."

Hashimoto, while remaining vigilant of his surroundings, approached Kondou, who sat down to rest.

"That was one hell of a flashy ambush. You really got the drop on us."

Since they could still talk even after being eliminated, Hashimoto praised Class B.

"Ryuuen-san's amazing, ain't he? Well, the game is on. It's your fault for letting your guard down."

"There might be other students besides Kondou looking for us. Let's get moving."

"In that case, shouldn't we have Shimazaki check the GPS for Class B's location?"

It was Yoshida who ran up and suggested this.

But as I turned my back and began to walk away without answering, Shiraishi, the VIP, added an explanation.

"The reason Kondou-kun was able to approach us undetected is because they're using a tactic to hide all of their class's GPS signals. Since it hasn't been thirty minutes yet, contacting the commander now wouldn't give us any details."

"Oh, right, of course... My bad."

"Do your best to run and hide~"

Leaving behind Kondou, who had cheerfully uttered the taunt, we headed south as if returning to the starting point.

Part 3

GOING BACK ABOUT thirty minutes.

It was right when Kaneda used his strategy to halt the GPS locations of everyone in Class B.

Ichinose just finished checking everything she could do on the commander's tablet.

On the map of the uninhabited island displayed, the four GPS colors assigned to each class were flashing according to the number of remaining students.

For her own class, Class D in Ichinose's case, she could tap on the green GPS markers to open their tags and constantly keep track of who was who. In contrast, for the other three colors—red, blue and yellow—tapping them only brought up a blank tag.

However, since it was possible to freely enter text into these tags, one could input a name if they knew who the GPS belonged to, or a role if their position was discovered. It could also be used to mark students who were making suspicious moves.

She looked away from the tablet for a moment, placed it on the simple table set up in front of her tent and took the radio in one hand and started to walk slowly around the headquarters area.

She did that to check who the commanders of each class were and what they were up to.

During the exam, the commanders were bound by an unexpectedly troublesome restriction.

They were forbidden from talking to or communicating with the other commanders.

Even if she wanted to contact Ayanokouji, actions like calling out to Shimazaki to ask him to pass on a message were impossible.

Furthermore, there was a physical distance between the tents, making it difficult to overhear the voices of the other class commanders speaking normally. If one were to force their way closer, there was a risk of being perceived as attempting to communicate, so they couldn't approach carelessly.

And this didn't just apply to interactions with other commanders.

"I guess it's impossible after all."

The commanders were forbidden from leaving the designated headquarters area and from within that area, it was structured in such a way that they couldn't make contact with the students participating in the exam, no matter how hard they tried.

Even if students made their way to the headquarters, direct conversations with a commander wasn't possible.

In other words, they had to convey their voice to their own class's VIP through the radio.

That was the only way commanders were permitted to intervene with others.

That was why, in the opening stage, they reported the information from their tablets every five minutes.

To see if there was a risk of an enemy class engaging with them.

Since that was what they needed to confirm, it could be said to be a natural course of action.

"But—"

As Ichinose watched the similar exchanges between the three from a distance, she noticed something.

Kaneda, the commander of Class B, was the only one who was constantly talking into his radio.

He also touched his tablet without a moment's rest, as if he were in a hurry for something.

If that had been all, Ichinose wouldn't have grown so suspicious, but despite the situation, Kaneda looked up just once and spotted Ichinose observing him.

A calm, normal face, as if to say, *'What is it?'*

When Ichinose smiled and gave a small wave, Kaneda gave a slight nod with just his head before immediately returning his gaze to the tablet and resuming his conversation with the VIP on the radio.

A natural response. But to Ichinose, it seemed unnatural.

Ichinose slowly returned to her tent and once she was out of Kaneda's sight, she picked up the tablet she had left on the table.

"The place where Ryuuen-kun and the others are hasn't changed much from five minutes ago. Hmm, they haven't moved at all."

It was safe to assume there would always be some margin of error with the satellite signal due to the basic limitations of GPS.

In other words, even if everyone was sitting perfectly still, it wouldn't be strange for at least one of them to move slightly. However, she could see no difference whatsoever between their positions five minutes ago, as she remembered them and their current positions.

"Has Kaneda-kun already stopped the GPS? If so... why?"

The answer to that was obvious, even without Ichinose having to ask herself.

It was because he judged that using his trump card, the GPS shutdown right at the start of the exam would be effective enough.

A plan to attack Class C, who were located closest and were the most likely to have stopped moving.

Of course, the possibility wasn't a certainty, but it was better to warn them of the danger just in case.

Thinking this, Ichinose hurriedly moved to a position where Shimazaki could see her.

Speaking, gesturing, or even mouthing words would be a strict violation of the rules, so Ichinose wouldn't and couldn't risk it.

But she decided that the act of just staring at Shimazaki probably wouldn't fall under the category of communication. If she received a warning, she would just have to back down then.

If they made eye contact, he might realize that she was trying to tell him something.

However, Shimazaki's attention was focused on operating his tablet and he didn't look up.

For a minute, then two, Ichinose continued to stand there, waiting for Shimazaki to look up.

Finally, just as five minutes were about to pass, he looked up and lightly rolled his neck as if to loosen his stiff muscles. His eyes met Ichinose's for a moment, but that was all. Shimazaki immediately dropped his gaze back to his tablet.

From his perspective, Ichinose was an enemy.

And he was also keenly aware of the rule that forbade any communication.

"It's... no good."

There was no way for Ichinose to warn Class C of the danger any further.

Believing that interfering too much risked a penalty for Class D and that it would be even more dangerous to stay too long and draw Kaneda's attention, Ichinose reluctantly distanced herself from the area and returned to her own tent.

Over the radio, she spoke with Class D's Kobashi, firmly emphasizing their safety and instructing them to avoid combat on the first day to focus only on events, also relaying a few possible routes in case other classes pursued them.

Five minutes later, the GPS updated again. Ayanokouji's Class C's GPS was active, but their position was fixed; they were perhaps resting or having a strategy meeting. In any case, they were not moving. Meanwhile, the GPS for Ryuuen's class was also completely stationary.

"As I thought... Given the time, they might be reaching Ayanokouji-kun's group right about now..."

An anomaly that Ayanokouji would have surely noticed had he been the commander.

The frustration of sensing it but being unable to tell the other class.

Ichinose prayed for Class C's safety.

What Class B was trying to exploit was a weakness in Class C.

She understood well that in this special exam, the brain and the body were separate.

Ichinose was impressed, judging that the decision to take them by surprise was the correct one if Shimazaki was the commander.

Being caught by surprise might have been unavoidable, but even so, Ayanokouji would not be completely wiped out.

If so, Ichinose considered what would happen next.

If they suffered a devastating blow, Class C would be forced into a difficult fight.

What, then, would Ayanokouji do?

Ichinose instantly judged that this was the best moment to bring up talk of an alliance and picked up her radio.

"—-I want you to listen to me very carefully."

So from that point on, Class D could rush in at any time to help Class C—no, to help Ayanokouji.

Part 4

WE MADE IT to F13, right next to the headquarters.

While remaining wary of our surroundings, I first contacted the commander to confirm the current situation.

"Thank you very much. I'll inform Ayanokouji-kun's group right away."

Ending the call with Shimazaki, Shiraishi lowered the radio and quietly raised her head.

"The GPS of everyone in Class B was just updated significantly. It appears that many of them have moved from the C11 area where they were originally located and are now concentrated in F10."

This made it clear that the effect of their tactic had worn off and it could be said that the risk of them lurking nearby had also been significantly reduced.

"Also, the three who strayed have all been eliminated. Unfortunately, it seems they headed toward the vicinity of F10 and were taken down."

"Can't be helped, I guess... Without the VIP, you can't tell what's goin' on. Hey, but what do you mean, 'concentrated in F10'? That doesn't mean everyone, right? Give me the details."

Unflustered by Hashimoto's prodding, Shiraishi traced a thin, white fingertip along the unfolded map.

"As I mentioned, the blue GPS signals—that is, the people believed to be Class B's main force—are gathered here in F10. However, another ten blue GPS signals have also moved to the area one-southeast of here."

"Ten people? Is a detached unit comin' after us?"

"No, I wonder about that. If we reason it out normally, there's a possibility that one or two students followed us on impulse, like Kondou and the VIP and their guards accompanied them to pick them up. The large number is likely due to their concern that the commander would use a tactic to identify the individuals."

"I agree with Ayanokouji Kiyotaka's reasoning. If just one or two of them were to carelessly go and pick up the stragglers, it would be like proving they were the VIP."

"So that's the most likely scenario, huh. But we can't let our guard down yet, can we? They can only use the group-wide GPS once, but they can use the

individual GPS stop three times, right? There's still a chance they've followed us this close—"

"That's unlikely. It was a successful operation because it combined two things: a surprise attack and a group-wide attack, strategy and firepower. Even if they used their three chances to fake the GPS locations of three people, they wouldn't have a follow-up. Without moving the VIP, it's also difficult for them to grasp our precise location."

"...I see. So that means we can finally relax, huh."

Even Hashimoto, who'd been shouting and barely escaped the storm of paintballs with his life, looked utterly exhausted. Everyone, including Shiraishi's group, sank powerlessly to the ground.

Eighteen people were left. The expression "half-decimated" was a perfect fit.

Two VIPs, one analyst and fifteen guards.

From there, Rokkaku became the analyst to fill Nakajima's place, leaving fourteen guards. The scout position was also vacant, but for now, we prioritized the number of guards and put that on hold. We were put in a difficult situation where we couldn't afford to clash head-on with other classes.

It was my misjudgment to stop for so long, thinking the enemy wouldn't attack once we had put some distance between us.

A situation brought about by none other than the carelessness and arrogance of the Class C leader.

It was a battle that would make anyone, both inside and outside the class, think that way.

Chapter 3:
The Unseen Pressure

IT HAPPENED LESS than an hour after the start of the special exam, which was set to be a long battle.

Those who looked frustrated.

Those who still couldn't grasp the situation.

Those who laid prostrated on the ground, unable to move.

And those who glared as if holding a grudge.

The near-destruction of Class C, brought about by the surprise attack from Class B, led by Ryuuen.

Looking down at the Class C students with their various expressions, Ryuuen quietly exhaled.

From the moment he deciphered the rules of the special exam and the lottery placed them starting in the area next to Class C. Ryuuen decided to immediately execute a certain strategy.

It was a strategy to defeat Ayanokouji.

In a long battle spanning four days and three nights, everyone wanted to save their tactics with strict usage limits. Everyone would first think to avoid conflict. He turned that on its head.

It wasn't simply a reckless gamble that would determine victory or defeat within the first hour.

In a way, Ryuuen considered it the most effective countermeasure against Ayanokouji.

Superhuman physical abilities and intellect.

The longer the special exam dragged on, the more time it would give Ayanokouji to think.

He would come up with effective ways to use their tactics.

And he would likely read the thoughts of Ryuuen, Horikita and Ichinose completely.

In that case, it was best to strike Ayanokouji before he could devise a clear plan.

That was precisely the result of his judgment bearing fruit.

As Ryuuen stared at the results of the surprise attack, Katsuragi quietly approached him.

"I've finished confirming with Kaneda through the VIP. We have three casualties and they have fifteen. Among those fifteen were our target, Kitou and the designated VIP, Nishikawa. This is undoubtedly a great success, more than we could have imagined. Furthermore, it appears Class C got separated from three of its members while fleeing and they're still wandering around this vicinity. We'll take them out if we can before our tactic expires—I take it you have no objections?"

"Yeah. If things go well, that's eighteen people. Not bad."

"However..."

Katsuragi, who had a slight concern, hardened his expression and continued.

"Kondou and Komiya chased after the fleeing Class C and haven't returned. It seems Kondou will catch up to Class C soon if he doesn't take a wrong turn, but Komiya has strayed far off course and is isolated."

It was bad news received from the commander.

"It's probably better if Kondou doesn't catch up. I can't imagine him accomplishing anything by jumping in alone against a cautious Ayanokouji. Leave him."

"Then, may I send Yamashita to retrieve Komiya? If you're concerned about a girl going alone, I think we could assign a male student as an escort."

To find the stray students, a student who could coordinate with the commander was indispensable.

"Yeah, that's fine."

Ryuuen initially agreed with Katsuragi's proposal to dispatch the minimum number of personnel.

"No—send ten people."

He immediately retracted his statement and re-instructed him to significantly increase the number of personnel.

"Ten people? The risk of engagement seems low, but is this for insurance? I have no objection, but it will be a needless drain on their stamina."

"I almost forgot myself, but moving in a small group will just give them a hint."

"...I see, that makes sense. The GPS-Jamming tactic will expire soon. When that happens, our current location will be pinpointed by the other classes all at once, is that it?"

"That's right. They'll know there's a VIP mixed in with the group we send out."

Because there was a tactic called Identify Person, which revealed the identity of a designated GPS signal, there was a risk of giving away the information that Yamashita was the VIP at a low cost, depending on their movements and timing.

However, if they moved as a unit of ten, the odds of identifying the VIP among them would be one in ten.

He figured that even if the movement was suspicious, the enemy would feel a strong reluctance to use Identify Person.

"That may be true, but... are you sure? This will interfere with our plans for later."

"More importantly, how many bullets do we have left?"

"About half, I'd say. We'll definitely need to resupply at the next event, but we can still fight as planned."

Even after receiving Katsuragi's report, Ryuuen's expression didn't relax; on the contrary, his vigilance only increased.

It was a success so great that wanting anything more could be called a luxury.

However, for Ryuuen, there was a reason he couldn't rejoice wholeheartedly.

"Your strategy was a magnificent success and yet you don't look happy at all."

Just as Katsuragi, wanting to know the reason, was about to ask Ryuuen for an answer, Ishizaki came running up, panting heavily.

"Ryuuen-san! Let's go after those Class C guys right now and finish 'em off! We're all set to go, sir!"

As if to follow Ishizaki, the students who were confident in their physical abilities gathered behind him.

The second the order was given, the pursuit of Class C would begin.

"—-No, this is as far as we go."

However, Ryuuen ordered a retreat, rather than the attack they originally planned.

"Huh!? Wh-what do you mean!? It went perfectly, didn't it!?"

Before they launched the surprise attack, Ryuuen suggested they would press the attack if their targets fled. Since the operation was a success, Ishizaki assumed they would give chase.

Katsuragi, too, showed some confusion at Ryuuen's surprisingly timid move.

"Are you certain you don't want to pursue them? If we let Class C gain distance on us here, we might not be able to recover."

They could still close the distance with Class C. Looking ahead, where tactics like disabling the GPS would be useless and surprise attacks would be difficult, they should strike while they had the chance, Katsuragi said.

"Is there something on your mind?"

"If the ambush had been a *total* success, sure, I would've been planning to hunt 'em down 'til they were wiped out."

"You don't consider this outcome a success?"

"He held out longer than I expected."

Ryuuen muttered this toward the back of Kitou, who'd been taken out and was now heading back to the starting point.

"It certainly took some time, but our losses were minimal."

"This ain't about our losses. The problem is we failed to take down the one guy we needed to. If we'd gotten Ayanokouji in the ambush, I would've been fine with letting you and Ishizaki go and mop up the remaining small fry like you wanted. But as long as the most troublesome bastard is still standing, I wouldn't be surprised if he managed to turn the tables on us even when we've got twice the strength."

If they got greedy and pursued too far, they could be counterattacked from an advantageous position.

Or they could risk walking into some kind of trap.

Considering those factors, Ryuuen decided to call off the pursuit.

"W-well, it's true Ayanokouji's a monster, sir, but this ain't a fistfight. With this thing, even *I* might be able to take him down."

Saying so, Ishizaki raised the shotgun he was holding.

"Maybe, if we were to surround him or chase him into a corner with no escape."

Ryuuen's gaze fell on the deep forest where Ayanokouji and the other Class C students fled.

Visibility was even worse there than here and the footing was poor.

And large trees grew thick enough for them to regroup and hide themselves.

Besides, if the other three classes aside from Class C chose to avoid conflict, Ayanokouji's class would be guaranteed to finish in last place.

"Now that one of their VIPs is down, Ayanokouji has no choice but to go on the offensive, like it or not. So there's no need for us to jump the gun."

After hearing this, Katsuragi processed Ryuuen's decision to retreat in his own way.

"I can't say the thought that you're being overly cautious with Ayanokouji hasn't crossed my mind... but if we're speaking from a position of maximum vigilance, then perhaps pulling back here is the best move. Just having our ambush succeed is a victory in itself. It's an undeniable fact that we've blunted Class C's opening gambit. And the fact that we've proven even Ayanokouji has openings we can exploit is also a major gain."

"Exactly."

In reality, what Ryuuen gained from this surprise attack wasn't just taking out half of Class C, including Kitou and a VIP.

What was more significant was that not even Ayanokouji was infallible. If Ayanokouji were omnipotent, he would've been able to foresee the ambush, quickly distance himself from Class B and escape.

The fact that even the most formidable opponent had a slight opening to exploit was a great relief to Ryuuen.

"Very well, then. Let us assemble a ten-person search party, including the VIP Yamashita and send them out without delay."

Katsuragi called Nomura over, told her what they just discussed and had her take action immediately.

Although some of the students, like Ishizaki, who were still excited from their victory, felt somewhat unsatisfied, they swallowed their feelings and accepted the decision, as it came from none other than Ryuuen.

Part 1

ONCE THE PERSONNEL had been organized and redeployed, Hashimoto called out again.

"No problems here. We're ready to move whenever, wherever."

An hour had passed since the exam began. With ten o'clock just a few dozen seconds away, the first event that would finally set everyone into motion was about to start.

The map was divided into areas, one square at a time, from A1 to O15 and an event would occur in one of those areas.

As it was the very first event, we would need to start by getting a feel for things, grasping the scale and details. What we knew beforehand was that events wouldn't occur in the three areas where the commanders and teachers were gathered—E14, F13 and F14—or in any area that was entirely ocean. This was clearly stated in the rulebook.

With Shiraishi and her radio at his side, Hashimoto spread out the map.

Sanada, our analyst, also waited for the signal on his tablet, ready for anything.

And then—the scheduled time arrived.

"It looks like there are ten events in total for the first round. I'll read out the locations first. B7, D14, E5, G7, G13, H9, J12, L14, M4—and finally, N7."

As Sanada read them off precisely, Hashimoto marked them on the map. Two other students who were on standby immediately jotted them down on their own maps by hand.

Each event would be active for one hour from now. If we were even a second late, the revealed password would become invalid, which meant the places we could go were inevitably limited.

"The one we can get to right away is G13, right next to us. After that, D14 looks like a safe bet. Based on distance alone, we could probably reach H9 and J12 within the hour, but Class A and Class B have a huge advantage for H9..."

"The supplies at H9 are food, right? If it's within our reach, we'd want to get our hands on it..."

While it was a question of whether we could even get there in time, the top two classes were close enough to reach it in ten or fifteen minutes. Even if we got lucky and made it, the supply crate would probably be empty by then.

"It's like pullin' someone else's chestnuts outta the fire, y'know? Worst case, it'll be a three-way shootout. No, wait, if Class A and B fight it out, maybe we could hit 'em from behind?"

Hashimoto touched his chin with his fingertips and ran the tip of his pen over the map, simulating the movements.

But now that our numbers were halved, launching an attack came with a huge risk.

"For what it's worth, if I were the leader of Class A, I would abandon H9, at the very least. If they were to rush over just because it's the closest, it's plain to see they would be attacked from behind by the aggressive Class B."

Morishita joined the conversation.

Sanada, who was still looking at his tablet, also offered his opinion on the matter.

"In that case, couldn't they split their class in two and form a defensive line? Even Class B wouldn't charge in so easily if they knew they were walking into an ambush—"

"I wonder about that. It seems more likely they would take advantage of their current momentum and initiate an attack. Rather than taking such a risk, since they went to the trouble of being the first to break into the northern area, collecting G7 and heading for E5 would be the safe and certain option."

Abandoning the nearby food supplies would be frustrating, but that did seem to be the most sensible route.

I couldn't imagine Horikita would want to get into a fierce battle with Class B right away.

From what I heard from our commander via Shiraishi, abandoning H9 without a second thought was the right call.

"We'll start by securing G13 and D14 for sure."

"That's more straightforward, yeah."

G13 was ammunition and D14 was daily necessities.

We decided to postpone the food problem until the start of the next event.

"The main unit will move to G13 and we'll form a separate detachment with four people to escort our VIP, Takemoto. Only the VIP can receive their exact coordinates from the commander, after all."

If an analyst wasn't going to accompany them, it would also be crucial to relay those details to the commander.

Coordination was essential to accurately align the location of the supplies with our own.

"Yeah... The watch only tells you if you're in the current area or not."

For now, there were no signs of other classes around D14, so it was free, but the event's location was still just *somewhere* in the area and without a tablet, we would have to search for it on foot. In other words, if the search proved difficult, we would waste time.

To maximize our chances of acquiring the supplies, the VIP's presence was indispensable.

"You're gonna coordinate closely with the commander and bring back those supplies."

"Five people in total? Couldn't Takemoto go alone?"

"Just getting there wouldn't be a problem, but no matter how safe D14 is, I want to avoid a situation where we can't find the event location, or the supplies are too much to carry back all at once."

"Ah, right, gotta think about carrying it all back, too."

After opening it with the password, could we still take things out after the hour was up, or could we just take everything out and leave it there? Since those points were unclear, we had to prevent any mistakes we could.

Then again, if we sent too many people, it would just force them to move around and needlessly drain their stamina.

The balance of it would likely change depending on the conditions of the supply crate.

"Five people is plenty. Besides, if there are no enemies, I don't think there'll be any trouble. Leave it to me. By the way, should we just come back here to regroup?"

"Yeah. The base is an easy landmark, so F13 is fine. We'll need to grab the supplies at G13 quickly while also keeping watch from F12 or G12 to see if Class B heads south."

If we moved on D14 with a large group, there was a chance Ryuuen would send a large number of his guards toward our base.

If that happened, we would be driven into a dead end with no escape.

As we immediately started preparing to depart, I spotted Yamamura with an anxious look on her face.

"What is it? If you have a problem, I'll hear you out."

"Ah, no... it's not that... it's just..."

"Just?"

"It's just... it's scary, isn't it? If I get separated, I won't have any idea where my allies are or where the enemy is, right?"

Perhaps her imagination was stirred by listening to the exchange between the VIP and the commander.

Because Class C lost Nishikawa right after the start, their situation was equivalent to having already lost one-third of their mobility. It was no wonder she felt anxious over such a trivial matter.

"And there's nothing I can do to be of use..."

"That's not true. Our class was half-decimated due to my poor judgment, but at least we still have half of us left. As long as half of us are still here, it means there's still a chance to win. If you, Yamamura, can just stay in for even one second longer without getting out, that alone is useful."

"Is that... really all it takes?"

"That's what's important. Even if you can't shoot, as long as you don't get shot, that alone is a huge plus for the class. You should remember that the value is the same."

The point was to keep remaining until the very end, even if more classmates were eliminated from that point on.

After thinking for a moment, Yamamura gave a small, but definite nod.

Part 2

HORIKITA PEERED INTO the tablet of Shinohara, who'd become the analyst and confirmed the event area.

Then, she immediately contacted Matsushita, the commander and received the latest GPS information.

"I think we should head north without hesitation. If we carelessly get involved in the central area of H9, we might have to fight Class B... or even Class C."

She couldn't afford to be blinded by supplies whose quantity and other details were unknown, only to lose her precious classmates in the process.

Hirata proposed fighting defensively without hesitation.

"I agree. In this special exam, losing classmates early on limits our strategic options and it's clear we'll just be worn down. We can't take a big risk for the first supply drop when we don't even know how much we'll get."

Above all, to avoid engagement, they'd chosen to start from G12 when they won the right to choose in the lottery. Simply to break through to the northern area via the straightest, shortest route.

Even if an event happened to appear nearby, they shouldn't carelessly get involved unless it was extremely safe.

Maintaining a situation where not a single person was missing for as long as possible was the simplest and most reliable way to aim for the top ranks in the special exam.

They stopped to assess the situation, but Horikita soon began to move toward G7 with Hirata by her side.

"Man, serves Ayanokouji right. Got his ass kicked by Ryuuen and ran back to the starting point. And one of their VIPs got taken out, right? Even if they run around, if the exam ends like this, they're guaranteed last place."

From behind her, she could hear Ike and the others laughing as they talked about it.

Sudou, who'd been listening nearby, crossed his arms, nodded deeply and walked over to Horikita.

"Suzune. About that fight between Class B and Class C just now. Honestly, I was surprised."

"Me too. To use a tactic for an all-out attack right at the start... even if you thought of it, it would take considerable courage to execute. To be so bold when they've barely gotten the hang of using the guns... But, it might have been one of the optimal choices, timing-wise. Right after the start, we also had moments where we were defenseless and stopped to focus on strategy. The thought that we might be surprise-attacked with a tactic... we weren't on guard for that."

She confessed that she'd been concentrating solely on reaching the northern area.

"Yeah. But still, for Ayanokouji to get taken down so easily..."

"...I suppose so."

It'd been obvious that fighting Ayanokouji would make victory extremely difficult.

At the stage where everyone started on equal footing, the class she wanted to fight the least was Class C.

That was because she'd thought that if she attacked them carelessly, they would surely be countered.

"What do you think about him losing, Horikita-san?"

Hirata, walking beside her, turned his gaze to Horikita and asked.

"My honest impression is, 'Really? Is it possible?' I was certainly surprised by the boldness of using a trump card at the very beginning, but I never imagined they would take such a major blow."

"I feel the same way."

"Ayanokouji-kun is—how should I put it... He's not the type of person to be careless in this kind of fight."

That was precisely why, like Sudou, her surprise was the only thing that preceded all else.

The preconceived notion that he wouldn't be defeated without a reason made it difficult for Horikita to judge the situation.

It was a dangerous way of thinking, close to faith or worship, that Ayanokouji had no weaknesses.

"But if he anticipated the preemptive strike, he shouldn't have let his class get half-wiped out. He could've escaped quickly, or even met the attack head-on and had an even fight, don't you think?"

The actual result was a crushing defeat and a rout.

The number of Class C students who vanished from the GPS told the story, allowing no room for concealment.

That was a slight opening that Ayanokouji had shown, a clear and undeniable fact.

"Is there absolutely no way it's part of Ayanokouji's strategy? Like, to reduce the hassle of gathering food."

"It's true that with fewer people, food problems are lessened. But you could just have people retire later if you run into trouble and it would be the same thing. There's no merit in reducing your numbers from the start. What's more, even their VIP was taken out, so their efficiency at gathering supplies will also drop."

Hirata's words were correct. And yet, while they were correct, she just couldn't bring herself to be convinced.

No, the feeling that she didn't *want* to be convinced was growing stronger.

"I probably... just don't want to frankly acknowledge it. Acknowledge Ryuuen-kun, who managed to get the better of him."

She focused on creating distance, turning her back on a powerful enemy.

Even though she knew it was a choice made to win, there was a somewhat servile emotion to it.

"It's all right, Hirata-kun. I won't laugh at his defeat, nor will I let my guard down. If we, or Class D, had been in Class C's position, it's highly likely we would have ended up with the same result."

Looking at the GPS signals moving away, Horikita murmured that a feeling of relief had undoubtedly come first.

"But let's gratefully accept the result. The situation is now slightly in our favor."

"And with their numbers down, a point gap's opened up, too."

Class C, having taken heavy damage, became last place and Class B, who attacked them, also lost four guards. With that, the scores of Class A and Class B became even, so if they could make it to the end without fighting, a sudden death match would be held to decide second place. The addition of that condition wasn't bad news.

"But we should probably estimate our score as one point lower. That guy Koenji could retire at any moment. It'd be nice if he at least used the ammo he took to take out one person... but that's probably not gonna happen."

Sudou snorted in a way that could be taken as either irritation or exasperation.

Shortly after the exam began, Koenji ignored Horikita's instructions and turned his back on them, saying he would enjoy himself by getting some exercise on the deserted island. He didn't see it as a special exam, but rather as a simple vacation. It could be easily inferred from his actions two years ago that he would return to the ship as soon as he got bored.

"As long as he doesn't get in our way, I suppose it's fine. Unfortunately, I'm in no position to expect more from him at the moment."

Horikita managed to save up Private Points in her daily life, but she made a large expenditure to secure Koenji's cooperation in the last special exam. If she were to try and secure his cooperation for a long-term special exam like this one, he likely wouldn't agree for merely two or three times the amount of Private Points he had previously.

"Even without Koenji-kun, our situation isn't bad."

"Our top priority should be to quickly head north. That will allow us to safely maintain our advantage. Let's hope that Class B and Class C continue to fight amongst themselves."

"Still, I wonder why I can't feel relieved in the slightest, even though Class C is in a jam."

"That's true... We should be one step ahead and yet it's still frightening."

Horikita's expression tightened.

"It's because Ayanokouji's still in—"

Horikita affirmed with a slight nod.

As long as Ayanokouji wasn't out, they absolutely couldn't afford to underestimate him.

If anything, he was sure to come up with some clever trick to cancel out their mistake and make a comeback.

That was precisely why they were moving to the northern area, to gain enough distance so they couldn't be taken by a surprise attack, no matter what tactics he used.

"Even though their numbers have been halved, I still can't help but feel this invisible pressure."

Although it was clear that there were no enemies nearby at the moment, Horikita couldn't shake a lingering anxiety that they might still get attacked.

"I feel the same way. In fact, precisely because they lost half their people, I'm thinking they're gonna stage a comeback with some outrageous move."

"Ryuuen-kun probably feels the same. That's why he didn't give chase; he couldn't."

After a brief moment of hesitation, Sudou shyly placed a hand on Horikita's shoulder.

"Well, let's just focus on what we can do. If it comes to a straight-up fight, we'll crush 'em, whether it's Class B, Class D... or even Ayanokouji. Right?"

At least Sudou was more confident in his physical stamina than anyone else.

He would fight with all his might to protect the class, no matter how much effort it took.

He was prepared for that.

"Let's move. First, we'll head north and secure as many event locations as possible. We need to gather supplies to avoid needless conflict."

Seeing Horikita stride forward purposefully, Sudou gave a short reply and the class proceeded north.

Part 3

WE SUCCESSFULLY RETRIEVED the event supplies at G13. About thirty minutes later, Takemoto and his group safely reached D14 and ten minutes after that, the commander informed our VIP, Shiraishi, that they retrieved all the supplies. In total, we'd succeeded in securing two locations.

The paintball supplies included two empty magazines for an assault rifle and a hundred paintballs in a bag. And the daily necessities included one lighter, three mess tins and three pairs of disposable chopsticks. Many students were disappointed with the daily necessities, but from the contents, it became clear that simply collecting food wasn't enough.

The possibility that opening a food supply crate might only reveal uncooked rice grew stronger. It seemed we needed to aim to acquire food and daily necessities as a set.

What both types of supplies had in common was that they were hidden by being about halfway buried in the ground, making them difficult to find just by walking around, except by chance. If you entered the correct password and opened the lid, you could take the supplies out directly, so there was no need to dig the box itself out of the ground. We were able to gather information, such as the fact that the size of the box seemed to be directly linked to the quantity of items inside.

Then there was H9, where there'd been a possibility of engagement, but Class A, led by Horikita, decided to retrieve the supplies at G7 and head for the northern area.

It seemed they disliked the risk of their classmates getting eliminated by engaging in combat.

On the other hand, Class B, led by Ryuuen, split their team in two, with one heading for H9 and the other to take the distant B7. They achieved results by choosing a small, elite group of physically fit students to exit onto the beach from C10 and run straight north.

As a result, in that first event, each class succeeded in retrieving supplies from two locations, ending in a draw, at least in terms of numbers.

After that, the second event at 1:00 p.m. and the third event at 3:00 p.m. were announced as time passed, and the four classes repeatedly secured paintballs, food and daily necessities while avoiding combat.

And soon it was 5:00 p.m. on the first day, the time for the final event.

"So far, we've managed to collect a total of five sets of supplies. A total of 200 rounds, 1.5kg of rice, eight assorted cans of food, some nuts, chicken and a few provisions. And on top of that, 15 liters of water—I guess you could call it a minimal harvest."

Calculating backward from the nutrients a person should consume, it couldn't be called sufficient; it was clearly not enough.

A total of thirty-nine event supply crates had appeared so far, so we hadn't managed to get very many of them.

"Being pinned down like this is just so unpleasant. They're practically stalkers at this point. Stalkers."

It was the presence of Class B, who, ever since their surprise attack, had constantly maintained their main camp between G9 and G10, lying in wait.

Because of their presence, we'd been unable to break out of the area surrounding our headquarters.

The supplies that appeared on the west side and near the center were being collected by Class B at their leisure, all within their reach.

On the other hand, all we could do was either reach out toward the beach area slightly east of our headquarters or retrieve supplies from the areas further south.

I understood why Morishita would call them stalkers, but it could be called a near-ideal position and strategy.

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. You could just charge in by yourself and annihilate the enemy unit, you know?"

"I can't exactly pull off something like the protagonist of an American action movie. At best, I'd get taken down after defeating two or three of them."

"Just that many? How pathetic. If it were me, the so-called 'Amazoness of the Jungle,' I could easily dispose of a hundred of them."

If that were true, I wanted her to defeat every class right away and lead us to victory.

"Didn't you say 'Amazoness of the Dense Forest' a moment ago?"

"You're such a stickler for details. 'Jungle' and 'dense forest' mean basically the same thing. In fact, it's a bit of a scale-up, so wouldn't you say that makes it even better?"

I didn't think so, but it was a waste of time, so I decided to stop arguing and just nodded.

"Morishita's proposal is something else, but can't we actually break through somehow? Like just forcing our way through?"

Unable to hide his irritation, Matoba nervously bounced his right foot up and down.

"That'd be rough. Attacking them from our position is a complete suicide mission. Besides, where would we even go if we broke through? Head north and Class A's there to greet you; head east and it's Class D. There's no escaping a scenario where we get pincered by Class B coming up from behind."

"Maybe Class A and D will let us pass, afraid of getting hurt themselves..."

"I'm sure they don't *want* to fight. But we'd be crashing an event they're trying to claim in safety, right? You think they're just going to say, 'Let's all be friends and split the supplies'?"

If we were in their shoes, we would naturally move to eliminate any approaching class.

Matoba, who must have easily imagined the same, clicked his tongue.

"Damn it... We're seriously, seriously one step behind. So does that mean our only option is to wait for them to attack?"

"If they were to attack us, we would have the option of using our geographical advantage, but it's unlikely they will rush in so carelessly. It's in their best interest to continue leveraging their absolute superiority in numbers, after all."

Faced with that harsh reality, the group fell silent for a moment.

Trying to do something about the oppressive atmosphere, Hashimoto shifted his gaze to his backpack.

"But man, we're barely managing to endure this as it is. Classes with forty people must be struggling big time."

They could probably get through the first day with what they were given at the start, but unless they acquired more provisions in the second day's events, things would likely become progressively more difficult.

"Now that our class has been cut in half, the food situation should be easier to handle."

"Even so, that doesn't change our disadvantage. The three other classes are collecting supplies at their leisure."

Class D acquired the most supplies with ten boxes, followed by Class A and Class B with nine. Even looking only at food items, the gap was more than one box.

It was 5:00 p.m. in area G12. The number of supply drops for the day's final event was—nine locations in total.

"And now we get the fewest of the day?"

"Moreover, you could hardly say these are favorable areas for us, either."

The analyst, Sanada, lightly pressed the side of his glasses with his palm as he pointed to each drop location.

There were no locations they could target while avoiding a confrontation with Class B, who watched them like a hawk, leaving only the dangerous D12 and I10. Since the next closest was G8, the only two locations they could realistically target were those first two.

"Class B has no intention of letting us escape, so we'll definitely be competing there. We'll only be evenly matched if they split into two groups. If they concentrate their forces on one side, I doubt we stand a chance."

"How about a strategy where we risk it and escape to the east? Class D is at N12 right now, right?"

It seemed Matoba hadn't given up on escaping from the southern area.

"If we get caught in a pincer attack, things will be even tougher than they are now. Are you okay with that?"

"That's why... we'll just have to pray that doesn't happen..."

"You can't call leaving things to chance a strategy."

The current situation was still difficult, but the option to escape to the east certainly existed.

However, if they made that choice now, Class B would undoubtedly follow.

If that happened, the next time they tried to escape, there would be no path left but the dangerous one over the mountains.

How many students in Class C could cross the mountains and reach the northeast area?

And even if they did cross, what benefit would there be?

It was hardly a feasible plan.

Putting aside what to do about their future base, the immediate problem was supplies.

The supplies that appeared at D12 and I10 were food, so they wanted to move to secure them at all costs.

"We're staying based in the southern area and securing the supplies."

"...So we're prepared to fight, then."

Sighing, Matoba's expression hardened with resolve.

"If we were only thinking about today, avoiding them would be fine. But tomorrow's event isn't until 11:00 AM at the earliest. And since there's no guarantee we'll get food, I want to secure both spots if possible, or at least one of them."

"Understood. So, what's the specific plan?"

If they were going for supplies with enemies present, cooperation with the commander was as essential as ever—no, even more so.

Therefore, they could split into two groups of equal number, led by the VIPs Shiraishi and Takemoto and prioritize balance, or concentrate all their forces in one location.

The students looked at each other, speculating which plan it would be.

"Going after the supplies means we're not gonna back down easily, right? Then shouldn't we concentrate our forces? We've only got half our strength left. Even if they split up, they'll still outnumber us two to one. If we clash, we could get wiped out."

It was only natural that the morale of a class already falling behind was low and that anxiety would take precedence.

It seemed opinions within the class were divided, but there was no time for a leisurely debate.

Within the limited one-hour timeframe, Class B would start moving at any moment. No, they might have been moving already.

"We're still going after both supply drops."

"Are you serious? They'll probably come for both too. If you're so sure of that, we'd be better off concentrating on one. When it comes to a fight, it's pointless unless we're on even footing in terms of numbers."

Matoba explained just how risky it was to face an enemy with twice their numbers.

"I agree with Matoba-kun. Isn't it an option to play it safe and just go for one? If we all move together, even they won't be able to easily charge a group

of nearly twenty people. And if they decide to gather their entire class, we can just retreat."

It was true that if we focused on one location instead of two, our safety would increase dramatically.

To fight a consolidated Class C, they would need more than half their students to gain an advantage and to guarantee victory, they would have to gather everyone.

However, such a large-scale movement, barring the use of a tactic, would definitely be detected by the commander and the VIP would be notified of an approaching presence immediately.

That was precisely why Matoba's idea of moving as a whole group sounded clever at first glance, but it was proof that he hadn't considered it from the enemy's perspective.

"If I were Ryuuen—no, if I were any other class, I'd be grateful to see Class C moving in one big clump. I could judge that you've chosen the path of self-destruction without me having to risk a fight. I could ignore the supplies Class C is targeting and go collect a ton of events instead. By tomorrow morning, you guys will be unable to bear the hunger, your stamina and intelligence will have dropped and you'll be forced to take on even harder events."

"...I see."

"The other classes are the ones who desperately need supplies right now. If we group up, we'd just be helping them out, huh."

"Sorry, but we don't have time to debate this any further. This is my decision as the one temporarily in charge of Class C. If you still have objections, you'll have to face the appropriate consequences."

Appropriate—meaning, they would have to bear the risk of expulsion.

I didn't even need to wait for an answer; Matoba and the others likely didn't have that kind of resolve.

"...Fine. How are we splitting the teams?"

With limited time, the farther the distance, the faster they needed to move.

Heading to I10, where the supplies were located in the mountains, would be tough.

"I'll go to I10 alone. Even if I don't know the exact location of the supplies, the watches have a built-in compass and a function to check our current

location. It won't be that hard to reach the designated area itself. The rest of you, head to D12."

"Alone...? Are you for real? They're definitely moving with their VIP. If they spot some guy moving on his own, he's bound to be a target."

Since time was precious, I had them start preparing while I continued my conversation with Hashimoto.

"Even so. I have no intention of changing my decision."

"...Right. Well, if that's what you've decided, I won't argue any further, but..."

"Alright. Takemoto, Hashimoto and the rest of you, hurry to the designated area, find the event and secure the supplies. After that, we'll regroup in one to one and a half hours. The primary rendezvous is F12. Even if you get separated from the VIP, it's near the base, so you'll be conspicuous and easy to spot. However, if other classes surround us there, we'll have no escape route. Therefore, if the commander gives a signal, I'm designating H12 as the secondary rendezvous."

If, by some chance, another class approached the rendezvous point, it had to be avoided as a meeting spot. That was because the commander was always fully aware of the other classes' movements.

"What do we do if Ichinose's class attacks?"

"Considering the distance, there's no way Class D will force an attack on us."

Because the VIP was worth one hundred points, it was easy to lose sight of other things, but even losing a single point from a reduced number of guards would become a major handicap in determining the final rankings.

"But there's no guarantee they won't attack, is there? I'm sure they want to win when they have the chance."

"Basically, if we don't attack, we won't be attacked. Operate under that assumption."

"...Guess I've got no choice but to believe that for now. So, how are you planning to meet up with us? You won't have any way of knowing how the situation changes moment to moment, right? It'd be hell if you got separated."

"Don't worry about me. More importantly, let's talk about what happens if you're attacked by Class B while securing supplies. You are only to engage them if their numbers don't exceed ten. The moment you confirm they have more people than that, you're free to retreat."

It was extremely difficult to capture a fleeing enemy on this vast, deserted island.

Deducing how the three classes would move for the last event of the day required no great thought.

I sent everyone ahead to D12, while I headed for I10 alone.

Part 4

IT WAS PAST 6:00 p.m. As I made my way forward, Hashimoto, who noticed my approach on the GPS beforehand, came over to meet me.

"Impressive stuff, Ayanokouji. I was watchin' the whole time on the analyst's tablet and saw you reach the event and secure the goods. Heard you went straight for the destination, huh?"

"I actually had to search for a bit. It helped that it was placed in a surprisingly easy-to-find spot. Inside the supply crate were five small mess tins, five small bags of white rice to go with them, five 500-ml bottles of water and five small, simple loaves of bread."

For a class maintaining a group of nearly forty people, these were meager provisions. It symbolized how a single event wasn't enough and how we had to keep moving.

"So it's not much, huh? Sorry, but we pulled back without a second thought. A big group was comin' our way. Guess you could say we succeeded in drawin' 'em out, though."

Having fewer people was a disadvantage not only in terms of points, but also in combat.

But if there was one advantage to be found among the many drawbacks, that was it.

The Class C students began to assemble the tents and make their beds.

The tents that could sleep three or more people were for the boys, while the smaller one- and two-person tents were mainly for the girls and to keep things fair, we used rock-paper-scissors to assign who would use which tent.

"The girls are settin' up the simple tents and makeshift toilets now and they're pretty damn good at it. I mean, for Japanese high schoolers, we're probably top-class when it comes to roughin' it in the wild, huh? I thought it was a useless experience at first, but it might actually be a handy skill."

Hashimoto said with admiration and he was right.

"In a disaster-prone country like Japan, it's not a bad thing to have experience with things like living in a tent and using outdoor toilets. No, in fact, it's probably one of the things that should be encouraged from now on."

This was the third year and the third time we had an uninhabited island exam.

It seemed that holding them consecutively had been rare until now, but when considered as an important experience for the future, it wasn't hard to see why.

In the future, if we were ever caught in a situation where electricity wasn't readily available, wouldn't we be able to handle it without panicking?

A short while later, once the setup was more or less complete, we gathered the food we'd brought back in one place and began to calculate how much each person would get if we divided it.

Of course, we would collect as much as we could from future events as well, but it was always better to keep track of our current caloric intake and hydration levels.

This was to avoid heading to an event when we didn't need to gather excess supplies, which could lead to unnecessary confrontations and casualties.

Furthermore, to maintain fairness, the food we obtained was distributed equally among everyone.

And so, while commiserating over the day's fatigue, the students brought the modest meal to their lips.

"Hey, can I ask you somethin'?"

Matoba, who'd approached me, said so hesitantly while looking at the food.

"How effective is it, really, to eat and drink in small portions? It's not like we're light on luggage and food takes up a lotta space, right? Wouldn't it be better to just eat when we can?"

"As an extreme example, the energy efficiency of splitting one meal into three is overwhelmingly higher than stuffing yourself with one meal a day. The human body is limited in how much energy it can store when consumed all at once. Carbohydrates are a good example; even if a small amount is stored in the liver and muscles, the rest is converted into fat. Of course, energy is also consumed during the conversion process. Water is even more pronounced; drink too much and it can't be stored, instead being expelled as sweat or urine. Moreover, the human body adapts to starvation and transitioning gradually to a low-calorie state slows the metabolism and suppresses consumption."

Even in survival manuals for disasters, the basic principle was to consume small amounts for as long as possible.

"So, even with the same food, how long it lasts is completely different."

Matoba understood that even if it was a bit of a hassle, it was definitely better to carry the food.

After that, the students who finished their meal enjoyed their free time.

A few students came forward saying they wanted to practice shooting for tomorrow, so I gave them permission after limiting the number of bullets they could use.

As long as they didn't shoot others, firing a gun outside the designated times wasn't, in itself, a violation.

If anything, it was important for them to hone their skills.

I spread out the map and reflected on the day.

Class C, half-destroyed in a surprise attack; Class B, which was all but unscathed.

Class A and Class D succeeded in keeping a firm distance from the other classes, navigating the events safely and only collecting supplies.

The effect of sinking to a provisional last place was significant and few of my classmates were smiling.

"Man, everyone's lookin' so gloomy. Well, can't be helped, given our results so far."

Hashimoto muttered as he looked around, a nutritional block held in his mouth.

"Isn't there somethin' you can say as our leader? Like, 'We'll definitely win, so don't worry,' or whatever."

"I can't say something baseless. If I were to say that now, I'd only earn their resentment and they'd ask, 'Who do you think you are?'"

The leader who couldn't foresee the surprise attack and was nonchalantly lecturing on how to use the weapons.

It was perfectly obvious that I would be met with looks and words of contempt.

"And yet, you seem to be havin' a pretty good time."

"Do I look that way?"

"Just a hunch. How can you enjoy a situation like this?"

"I suppose it's because I don't dislike the deserted island exam itself. It's an intense way to experience things you could never go through in a normal school

life. I get to see so many expressions on my classmates' faces that I've never seen before."

"Well, that's somethin' else. So you're sayin' you're satisfied in a way that's got nothin' to do with whether we're winning or losing the exam?"

"It would be a lie to say I'm not. Of course, I have no intention of losing, either."

"I'll take you at your word. Anyway, I guess when things are this gloomy is when it's my time to shine, huh?"

With those words, Hashimoto clapped his hands and made his way toward his downcast classmates.

"It's not like we've lost the exam yet, y'know. If you get all down in the dumps, we'll lose a battle we could've won, don'tcha think? How 'bout you try to have a little fun with this deserted island life?"

Whether he was encouraging them or provoking them, Hashimoto continued on.

"It'd be one thing if we were in the lead, but do you really think we can enjoy ourselves while we're losing?"

For Class C, who weren't used to losing, the defeat in the end-of-year special exam, the previous loss by a narrow margin and now this difficult situation was a series of misfortunes.

The human brain receives roughly twice the emotional impact from a loss as it does from a win. They were a class that'd won many times before, but that, combined with their current position as Class C, was becoming an unbearable shock. Because they were nearly the polar opposite of Horikita's class, their state was, after all, very interesting to just watch.

Part 5

AROUND 8:00 P.M., the Class C students started trickling into their tents.

It was still the first day of the exam and aside from the surprise attacks, not a single engagement with another class had occurred.

As tomorrow and the day after arrived, the scent of battle would inevitably draw closer.

Avoiding needless exertion and striving to recover our stamina was the best move we could make right now.

Five of the boys had gathered in the large tent I was using, but surprisingly, they were lively and engaged in idle chatter, showing no signs of negativity.

A major factor contributing to this positivity was undoubtedly Hashimoto's presence.

He constantly brought up new topics to keep us from falling into the mindset that we might lose.

My classmates weren't fools. If they dwelled on their current predicament, things would inevitably become gloomy. That was why they were quick to join in, allowing themselves to be influenced by Hashimoto's demeanor.

The idle chatter shifted away from class matters and moved on to funny stories from the past.

Once Satonaka finished his story, all eyes turned to Hashimoto, who was sitting beside him.

"Well then, guess I'll tell a story I just remembered."

Without refusing, he cheerfully began to speak.

Seeing that made me realize once again that being a cheerful character is a talent in itself.

"Back in my third year of middle school, I met up with a classmate from elementary school and we biked to this ramen and udon place. It was a big place and there were a bunch of bikes in the bike rack. But then, there was this one bike parked outside the rack, in a car's parking spot. We didn't think anything of it and parked our bikes on either side of it. Just as we were about to go in, the guy who owned the bike in the parking spot—some gloomy-looking college-aged dude—came out."

Hashimoto continued, laughing amusedly as he recalled the memory.

"As we passed each other, he was looking at our bikes and muttering complaints. So, I asked him what was up and he goes, 'I can't get my bike out because yours are in the way.' But like, there was plenty of space between our bikes, you know? Anyway, I figured I'd just move it for him, but as I started to, he said, *'Don't park here, it's a nuisance.'* That kinda pissed me off, so I shot back, 'You're the one parked in a car's spot.' Then he starts yelling back at me all fast, spouting some lame excuse like, 'Well, you guys parked two bikes'—"

"Dude, if you parked your bike in a car spot too, then you're also in the wrong."

A punch of pure logic flew from Matoba.

"Yeah, well. I know that, but it was just funny seeing him get pissed at us younger guys like he wasn't at fault at all. If it'd been some scary dude parked there, he definitely wouldn't have said a word. The moment we glared at him, he just muttered something under his breath and took off."

Regardless of whether Hashimoto was in the right or not, I figured everyone probably had one or two funny stories from before high school.

"You tell us something too, Ayanokouji. It can be a stupid story like mine."

I had a feeling my turn would be coming up soon.

However, I didn't have a single funny story to share.

"Sorry, but I have to step out. An issue came up that I need to deal with for tomorrow."

I sat up and gave my excuse.

"Oh, is that so? Can't be helped then."

If it was a problem related to the special exam, no one, including Hashimoto, would object.

Hashimoto seemed to have started another funny story from his stockpile, so I left the tent, relieved.

It might have seemed like I was running away, but I hoped they'd forgive me since it was true that I had a problem to deal with before the special exam resumed tomorrow.

It was past 9:00 p.m. and as far as I could see, everyone was inside their tents. Few seemed to be asleep, however, as the sound of chatter was constant. A short distance away in the darkness, lanterns glowed faintly in several of the tents standing side-by-side. The entrances were open, but a mesh screen kept insects out. It was as if the students, protected by their small sanctuaries, were

trying to escape their anxiety and enjoy their current circumstances in a positive way, all while maintaining their distance.

"It seems they still have some mental fortitude left."

Or perhaps it was because they felt such hardship that they huddled together for protection.

Either way, that wouldn't be a problem until the exam started tomorrow.

The tent used by the person I was looking for was a two-person model and its flap was closed.

"I have a small favor to ask of you, Shiraishi. Do you have a moment?"

I didn't think she would be asleep yet, but I called out to her tentatively.

Then, I heard the faint rustle of fabric from inside the tent and the closed entrance soon opened. She held a lantern in her hand and its light softly spread to the surroundings.

"Good evening, Ayanokouji-kun. Is something the matter?"

Shiraishi, who was using a two-person tent, handed the lantern to me for a moment and then quietly crawled out.



"I'd like to talk for a bit. Can you spare the time?"

"To talk...?"

Shiraishi showed a rare moment of bewilderment. From behind her, another person, her tent-mate Hoashi, peeked out, unable to hide her grin.

"Hey, hey. You should probably make sure the other boys don't see you, you know? It'll be a huge mess if they do."

"It's not like that. Right, Ayanokouji-kun?"

"Yeah—it's not like that."

What did she mean by 'that'?

For a moment, I considered it, but the faces of Yoshida and Shimazaki immediately came to mind.

The act of calling Shiraishi out of her tent in the middle of the night would certainly appear suspicious if anyone saw.

"You can relax. It's about the exam from tomorrow onwards."

I explained as much to Hoashi just in case, but her eyes were smiling and it was doubtful whether she believed me.

As Hoashi saw us off, I moved a short distance away from the campsite with Shiraishi, who held a lantern in one hand.

"Is this a private matter?"

"Something like that."

Shiraishi's expression, illuminated by the dim light, had already returned to its usual—to borrow Yoshida's words—mysterious atmosphere.

"So, what was it you wanted to discuss with me?"

"If there was anything about my command and actions today that made you feel uneasy, I want you to tell me. I'm starting to have doubts about how to proceed from here."

"Unease and doubts?"

Although she immediately understood why she'd been summoned, Shiraishi brought her free hand to her mouth, looking puzzled.

"It's quite unexpected for you to harbor such unease and doubts, Ayanokouji-kun. I thought you were the type of person who considers everything and arrives at the answers all on your own and without any hesitation."

'Unexpected.' That one word from Shiraishi, casually included in her sentence.

I felt a new sense of unease.

The feeling I got from Shiraishi right after the surprise attack began to magnify.

The outcome of the attack that made even Hashimoto concerned.

In contrast, Shiraishi showed no doubt whatsoever that we might lose.

But for now, I decided to continue our conversation.

"I apologize if I seemed like an unreliable leader."

"That's not true at all. At the very least, I trust you. I believe that in the end, you will most certainly meet my expectations. Therefore, there's not a single thing I'm uneasy about."

Staring straight at me, Shiraishi answered without a hint of hesitation.

"If you were hoping for a reprimand, does this mean I failed to meet your expectations?"

"If you don't doubt my ability, even though I couldn't predict the surprise attack, then that's fine. I understand now that you trust me, Shiraishi."

Nodding yes, Shiraishi gave me an even wider smile.

"Then I'll make use of that trust without reservation."

"I'm prepared to help with anything, as long as it's within my power."

I finished my conversation with Shiraishi and walked her to her tent.

Hoashi's surprised greeting of, "You're back already?" was rather memorable.

On my way back alone to the tent where Hashimoto and the others waited, I glanced back at Shiraishi and Hoashi's tent.

Shiraishi, who'd nodded without hesitation that she trusted me.

A divergence from the impression I'd had of the student named Shiraishi Asuka.

She was able to show respect for others. If she thought it was for their own good, she would tell a gentle lie without hesitation.

Conversely, if she thought it wouldn't be for their own good, she would speak her true feelings.

She hadn't even tried to blame me for my mistake and said that she trusted me from the bottom of her heart.

The damage from the surprise attack was considerable; it wasn't something that could be overlooked as a simple mistake.

Shiraishi, with whom I'd first spoken to alone in an empty classroom early in the morning on the second day of Class C.

That scene had certainly been a gift of chance, but I questioned whether the same was true for our other encounters.

It was still June; I'd only spent about two months with the students of Class C.

True, it wasn't as if we'd had no contact at all during our first and second years, but I had only very recently begun to take the lead.

Even the boys, Yoshida and Shimazaki, didn't understand me well yet and it was likely the same for Hashimoto, who acted as my aide.

It was an incident that would cause anyone—Hashimoto, Matoba, Hoashi, Morishita—to feel a touch of unease.

Since they didn't know me well, it was normal for them to have doubts.

Yes, that was the part that was abnormal.

Why had she found it surprising that I, as the leader, would feel anxiety and uncertainty?

She wasn't a student incapable of thought.

A statement she couldn't have made unless she'd known me from before we became third-years.

"A connection to Sakayanagi... or perhaps, a similar—student, is it?"

Either way, it was a trivial matter.

Still, I made a point not to forget to keep it in my memory.

Chapter 4:
A Chance Encounter

IT WAS EARLY morning, just past 6:00 a.m., a time when most students were still asleep.

The one to slowly emerge from a one-person tent was Ryuuen Kakeru, the leader of Class B.

He spread out a map to reconfirm the last recorded GPS positions from yesterday and with a mind refreshed after a night's sleep, stared at the situation of each class he marked.

What'd been troubling him from the middle of the night until then was who to fight next and how.

What he needed to do to ultimately come out on top of the other three classes.

He had to decide how to act moving forward, setting those immediate objectives by 9:00 a.m.

First, he ruled out Class A and Class D, who'd set up camp in the north and east areas.

What was important was his own class and Class C, both clustered together in the southwest where their base was.

After the successful surprise attack, Ryuuen dedicated all his resources to events, making his classmates run around to secure supplies.

Even so, food was always in short supply and they were forced to actively participate in events to sustain their class size. Even though their numbers decreased, Class C, unable to secure supplies, was in the same state of deficiency.

That was an adjustment intended by the school.

They were clearly being guided toward a gradual decline, tempted to launch an attack.

But the students were no fools. They weighed the risks of combat against the contents of the supplies and chose to endure hunger rather than lose their VIP or escorts. At least, that's how it went on the first day.

So, what would happen on the second day? It all depended on the addition of new restricted areas and their scope.

If the usable area for Class C, currently holed up near their base, were forcibly narrowed, they might finally resolve to cut off their escape routes and fight for real.

"I've got him cornered... but how're you gonna move, Ayanokouji?"

One thing was certain: Ryuuen had no intention of remaining on the defensive.

Ideally, he wanted to launch an all-out attack on Class C, even by force and sink them to last place.

He judged that no matter if Ayanokouji was there, they had a 99% chance of winning right now.

However, that came with the precondition that the special exam would end at that very moment.

After defeating Class C, it would be extremely difficult to defeat Class A and Class D with their remaining forces.

"There's always the option of crushin' that eyesore Class A first... but that'd just make the guys at the bottom happy."

If it turned into a war of attrition between two classes, the remaining two would simply profit.

"Quite an early morning, isn't it?"

Sensing a presence, Katsuragi came outside and called out to Ryuuen as he approached.

"Are you deliberating on which class to target?"

At those words from Katsuragi, who sensed his boiling blood up close, Ryuuen gave a small laugh.

"Something like that. Well, the main target's always Class C."

"Being belligerent is all well and good, but even if we don't force an attack, time, coupled with a lack of supplies and the restricted areas, will inevitably force a fight. Is there really a need to squander the advantage we gained from the surprise attack on Class C at this stage?"

"Sure, maintainin' our numbers advantage ain't a bad thing. We're the ones holdin' the initiative here. But we already used our main tactic yesterday to get the first strike. Since they still have the right to use theirs, it means they can launch a surprise attack too. Striking before that happens is one option. And if

he decides he can't fight and uses tactics to escape, well, that ain't half bad for us either."

Then Ryuuen looked at the supplies placed in front of the tent and continued.

"When you're hungry, your stamina drops whether you like it or not. It's frustrating that we won't be able to use the strength of those idiots."

There were many big eaters in Class B, but for that reason, they still had plenty of stamina for now.

The more time passed, the more their advantage would fade, Ryuuen explained.

Katsuragi folded his arms, mulling over Ryuuen's words.

He understood his intent and it wasn't as if it lacked reason.

"...You have a point. If we use the supplies we desperately scraped together for breakfast, we'll have almost nothing left. That said, having them continue to collect supplies on an empty stomach is problematic. However, that is precisely why I believe we should prioritize collecting from events on the second day as well."

Katsuragi had come to that conclusion after discussing it with Ryuuen late last night.

His opinion hadn't changed and he advised that they should basically remain on the defensive.

"Only Class C should be feeling impatient. For now, we should simply keep a close eye on the other classes. That line of thinking was part of your original plan, was it not?"

Katsuragi knew that Ryuuen wasn't making light of the risks of attacking.

Still, what he couldn't get behind was his abnormal obsession with Class C.

To be precise, he was concerned that his fixation on defeating Ayanokouji would end in futility.

"It's a strange thing. They should've been half-destroyed by that surprise attack, but lookin' at this map, I can't see Ayanokouji showin' any sign of weakness."

Ryuuen stared at the mark in the south. Katsuragi, who looked at it as well, nodded once in agreement.

"It's the fear of not being able to see your opponent's face. The stronger the enemy, the more one's imagination is stirred up with wild ideas of what they might do to outmaneuver you."

Ryuuen partly agreed with the 'overthinking' part, but he learned that lesson the hard way over more than two years of fighting.

The plan succeeded and damage was dealt.

In other words, it meant that even Ayanokouji had an opening. However, it was a minuscule one.

The difficulty of continuing to press that opening was incomparable to the initial surprise attack.

"In any case, don't overthink things with Class C. If you truly cannot suppress your urge to fight, shouldn't you turn your attention to Class A for now? We won't become Class A unless we defeat those above us."

"—Maybe so."

Ryuuen looked away from the map and up at the trees, where the sun was just starting to shine through.

Part 1

AT EXACTLY 9:00 AM on the morning of the second day.

The first report came in from the commander, Shimazaki, to the VIP, Shiraishi. That was because all GPS information had remained frozen from 6:00 PM to 9:00 AM, the hours outside the exam.

That said, students had to restart the next day from the area they were in at 6:00 PM the previous day, so there was no need to worry excessively unless an enemy remained in the same area.

"It seems the GPS locations have been updated. Not a single one is missing and their movements appear to have been minimal within the same areas. Koenji-kun, who's isolated from Class A, is also still present and is said to be in D6."

I'd expected that someone might report feeling unwell overnight, but it seemed everyone managed to get through it.

"I knew he crossed mountains and rivers in a day, but he's completely enjoyin' himself, ain't he? He can't have any extra food, so what the hell's he doin'? Don't tell me he's livin' off the land?"

I wasn't an expert on the wild plants of the uninhabited island, but I hadn't seen enough of them to supplement one's nutrition. One could catch fish in the sea, but there were no fishing rods among the supplied items this time. That meant it had to be something one could find on the beach, but judging from his movements yesterday, his GPS hadn't reached the sea.

"Well, whatever. He can't get any extra supplies without the password anyway, so we can just leave him be."

It was unclear whether he would become a threat, but it was certain there was zero merit in us getting involved.

"Koenji, huh—"

I hoped he would've voluntarily retired during the off-hours, but he was still there?

"Is something the matter? I believe it would be best to leave him alone, as Hashimoto-kun said."

"That's our common understanding, but there's just a certain... creepiness to it. It's because I don't understand the reason why he's still here instead of retiring."

"You're the one who thinks he's not motivated, right?"

"It's more accurate to say that's how I saw him. That's why I expected him to have already retired by this morning. I also considered the possibility he might approach the base by nightfall."

Koenji's current position was quite far from the base, deep within the uninhabited island.

"He probably just thinks it's a vacation, right? That's his character, after all."

"This place is the same as last year. There shouldn't be anything new about it for Koenji."

Follow Horikita and participate in the special exam...?

No, of course I wouldn't say the probability was zero, but it still wasn't very high.

My own thoughts, from having analyzed the student known as Koenji Rokusuke.

"Isn't it a waste of time just thinkin' about it? Even if, by some chance, the guy is motivated, we have no way of knowin'. He's alone and as long as we don't make contact, there's no problem, right?"

Unable to contact his commander, Koenji didn't know the location of his allies or his enemies, so even if he had the will to fight, it was true he couldn't find an enemy on his own.

In other words, the idea that there would be no problem as long as we kept track of his GPS location was fundamentally correct.

However, there was the unavoidable case of accidentally running into him.

Or, even if he had no intention now, there was also the case that Horikita might plot to make him move in the future.

It was important not to dismiss him as just one person and to always keep an eye on him.

"What's everyone's condition?"

"Can't say we're in top form, not by a long shot. To be honest, I'm hungry too."

The food we secured yesterday. If we were to use it all up, we could fill our stomachs temporarily, but looking ahead to today and tomorrow, we had to refrain from wasteful consumption.

"Unless the other classes make any suspicious moves, our basic strategy is to wait until an event occurs."

I conveyed our tentative policy and spoke once more to Shiraishi and Takemoto, telling them to maintain close communication between the commander and the VIPs.

Part 2

IT WAS 11:00 a.m. for Class D.

Their plan to avoid conflict as much as possible was set to begin crumbling from this time on.

Kanzaki stared at the tablet operated by their analyst Andou and couldn't help but hold his breath.

The announced supply drop points were E4, E9, G8, G11, H5, J8, J13, K3, M12, N9 and O14.

And—a screen with numerous gray squares added, a clear difference from the day before.

It also covered O14, where a supply drop appeared.

"Hey Kanzaki, does this... mean what I think it means...?"

"It's too early to draw conclusions, but if the next event has a similar mechanic, the probability will be orders of magnitude higher."

The 11:00 a.m. event on the second day.

A warning flag was raised on the basic assumption that they'd simply repeat what they'd done four times the day before.

The map was divided into a 15x15 grid. Its outer squares were, of course, mostly sea, but it'd been announced that all of these outer squares would be designated as completely prohibited areas starting in one hour. In an hour, this gray would turn pitch black and a rule would be activated that would get you eliminated in five minutes for entering.

But that alone would have no effect on their current situation. However, what would happen in two hours, at the start of the next event? If the outer squares were similarly made prohibited, that would mean the map would silently shrink, layer by layer from the outside, with each future event.

Today, tomorrow, the day after. There were 10 events left, not including this one. While it was hard to imagine the perimeter shrinking in all of them, if the rule didn't change, the four classes would end up clustered near the center. If that happened, the enemy would be right under their noses.

"There's no way to avoid a fight from here on out—"

Dark clouds began to gather over Class D, whose primary goal had been to make it through the exam just by staying in the eastern area, where they could maintain their distance from the other three classes.

"If one or two more prohibited areas are created today by shrinking the perimeter, we should probably consider making a major move."

Returning to the center from the north would require a time-consuming detour. Furthermore, Class A was in the northern area, creating the risk of an ambush. On the other hand, if they leaned too far south in an attempt to return to the center early, the terrain might be unsuitable for collecting event rewards.

Unable to take his eyes off the tablet, his thoughts spun round and round in his head.

"Kanzaki-kun!"

Kanzaki, shaken by the shoulder, realized his name had been called repeatedly and looked up.

"...My apologies. What is it?"

"A message from Honami-chan. She says she'll think about our course of action, so don't worry."

It was a message from Ichinose, as if she'd been watching Kanzaki's near-confusion from the side.

"It seems she wants you to focus on the event in front of you for now."

"Yes... you're right."

"She also said we don't have to push ourselves for O14, just in case."

If they headed to O14 from their current position and had trouble recovering the supplies, there was a risk of being eliminated.

"For now, we'll move to secure it. O14 has little land, so the supplies themselves should be easy to find."

Not going after the event would mean losing the opportunity to collect the supplies.

"...We'll split into three groups at once and head to collect the event rewards."

He kept their goal unchanged: to play it safe by repeating the same actions and work hard to gather the supplies needed for everyone to get through the day.

Part 3

THE CLOCK'S HANDS ticked forward, from 11:28 to 11:29 AM.

Class B had been divided into two ten-person groups to retrieve supplies under Ryuuen's command and a main force to hold back Class C. The guard group, led by Komiya and accompanied by the VIP Morofuji, was headed for the supplies that appeared in E9.

Normally, the E9 location would've been completely clear. It was difficult for either Class A or Class C to target and Class B thought it would be an easy acquisition.

However, just before 11:00 AM, one concern emerged regarding the retrieval of those supplies.

A lone GPS signal that had strayed from Class A, which appeared at D6 at 9:00 in the morning.

They were now in a situation where they might coincidentally run into it.

"R-Report. Looks like that lone GPS signal is still heading our way."

Showing a slight bewilderment, Morofuji relayed Kaneda's report to her classmates.

"You say he's comin' our way, but it's just one guy, right? Some scrub like that doesn't even know where we are, so there's no need to sweat it. Besides, if we spot him, we can just shoot 'im."

With nine guards and a VIP, there was no way they could lose, Komiya replied with an air of confidence.

"But... that's probably Koenji-kun, right? There's no doubt he's a dangerous guy..."

"Don't matter. This ain't a fistfight, it's a survival game, ya know? Doesn't matter who pulls the trigger, the result's the same, so there's nothin' to be on guard for. More importantly, we gotta grab the supplies and get back to the main unit, or we'll be in deep shit if Class C makes a move."

The number of students in the main unit and in Class C were evenly matched. It wasn't out of the question that Ayanokouji, seeing it as an opportunity, might suddenly go on the offensive. That was precisely why Ryuuen ordered them to return as soon as possible.

"What should we do, Oda-kun...? Is it okay to let him go?"

Oda, having been called, thought for a moment before telling her to contact Kaneda and ask for Ryuuen's instructions and then decided to follow Komiya.

Unable to hide her anxiety, Morofuji operated the radio again and again.

However—

"It's no use. He must be talking to someone else, I can't get through at all."

There was only one commander and if communications with the VIPs were congested, the line wouldn't connect.

When he was communicating with someone else, a period of radio silence was inevitable.

"See, I told ya you're worryin' too much. If we run into him, I'll put a round right through his heart. With this partner of mine that took out four guys during the ambush!"

Laughing, Komiya took the shotgun in his hands and struck a pose as if to show off.

"Where are you, Koenji!"

Shouting confidently, Komiya ran out and pointed the muzzle of his shotgun left and right.

"Here!? It's over here, huh!?"

With a *Bang! Bang!*, he fired the shotgun twice into the dark forest.

"Hey, don't go wasting so many shots~"

"Heh heh, what's the harm? He could actually be hiding, you know."

Looking amused, Komiya took out the magazine and reloaded it.

"That guy's getting carried away. That's totally a death flag, isn't it?"

Laughing in amusement, Yamawaki spoke to Kinoshita, who was walking beside her.

"Guys are so dumb. To think they could find fighting with these things fun."

Kinoshita sighed, staring coldly at the assault rifle in her hands.

"You say that, but when we charged Class C, you looked like you were having fun shooting. I saw you."

"Th-that was... I mean, I just got kinda caught up in the moment, you know —"

Blushing that he'd seen an unexpected side of her, Kinoshita sharply smacked Yamawaki on the shoulder.

"Agh—!?"

Immediately after, a voice cried out in agony.

"H-Huh!?"

She didn't remember hitting him that hard, Kinoshita thought, but the voice that cried out wasn't Yamawaki's. It was Komiya, who was walking at the front. He crumpled to the ground.

He simultaneously dropped the shotgun he'd been holding loosely.

For a brief moment, the students walking behind Komiya couldn't comprehend what happened.

"Hey, Komiya, what are you doin'—"

Immediately after, Kinoshita, who was right beside Yamawaki as she started to speak, also felt a sharp pain pierce her abdomen.

Splat!

Along with that sound came the sensation of an impact and liquid spreading across her abdomen.

"Ow!"

The impact itself wasn't that strong, but such a cry escaped her at the unexpected shot.

It was then that Yamawaki finally understood what was happening.

"Gah—she’s been shot! There's an enemy!!"

Triggered by Yamawaki's shout, a paintball landed on the side of Yabu, who was standing dazedly nearby and another on Sonoda's left thigh and 'out' warnings were issued from their wristwatches.

It was only then that the panicked students each raised their paint guns and with many eyes, frantically scanned left and right, focusing on the area ahead.

However, they couldn't spot the enemy that was shooting at them.

"I-It's gotta be Koenji! Koenji's close! Isn't Kaneda gonna say anything!?"

He exploded with frustration at the commander for not reporting the approaching danger.

"I haven't been able to get through at all!!"

"This makes no sense!"

They continued to shout in a panic as the guards formed a circle to protect the VIP, Morofuji.

But they couldn't find Koenji, or even a single human figure.

"Where are they shooting from!?"

"I dunno!"

A sharp sound rang out and by the time they noticed, a paintball struck someone else.

Not a single wasted shot and each one was precise.

Another shot flew from out of nowhere and Yamawaki was hit.

Predicting their opponent's position from the point of impact, the remaining four fired back.

But still, there was no one in sight.

"Why are you attacking us, Koenji!"

There was nothing strange about it, as they were enemies, but Komiya, who was now 'out,' shouted at the unseen Koenji, not having expected him to participate in the exam.

"It's just one person, isn't it? We can't lose to him!"

The girl, Nishino, exhaled and started running toward the direction the paintballs seemed to be coming from.

"Wait, Nishino!"

Oda shouted, but immediately after, Nishino was also shot and she fell forward in shock.

The Class B students were deeply shaken by the extraordinary situation of six students being eliminated in less than thirty seconds.

They fired their guns wildly, paintballs hitting and splattering on trees, the ground, leaves—everywhere.

"Where the hell are you!"

"It is Koenji, right!?"

"I don't know!"

One by one, they were taken down, until all eight guards surrounding Morofuji were 'out.'

"What's... what's happen—"

Suzuki was stunned as his allies were taken down one after another by an unseen enemy.



At that moment, just as a call from Kaneda came in over the radio for Morofuji, that very Suzuki was shot in the shoulder and his wristwatch issued an alert.

Morofuji, the VIP who was being protected, frantically tried to run away, but she tripped and fell.

"M-Morofuji! He's here, he's here! Run!"

From the direction the eliminated student had shouted toward, Koenji appeared, walking with a confident stride.

Morofuji picked up a weapon an ally had dropped and aimed it at Koenji.

"D-Don't come any closer!"

"You're the VIP, aren't you? If you were to fight back, you would simply be eliminated for nothing."

In response to Koenji's calm admonishment, Komiya stood up and ran over.

"What do you think you're doing!"

"There is nothing to it, is there? I am from Class A, you are from Class B. We're enemies."

"Th-That's...! I mean, how'd you find us when you're all alone!"

"My, my. I had no knowledge that I would stumble upon you. However, when one hears voices and gunshots so unsuited for this great wilderness, it is something one would understand whether one likes it or not. Am I wrong?"

The sound of a cocky Komiya provoking Koenji and the sound of gunfire.

That was what led him to their location, Koenji answered.

"I enjoyed the uninhabited island for a day and thinking I had my fill, was on my way back to the ship—but I thought I'd give this a try for the novelty of it. That is all."

Saying so, he raised his assault rifle and grinned.

"Damn it, this is your fault, Komiya!"

"S-Sorry..."

"Don't be so quick to blame him. Thanks to him, I've had some fun. Now that I've tried it for myself, this so-called survival game is quite entertaining, you know."

The muzzle pointed at them came from Koenji, who'd just thanked them.

Sensing she was out, Morofuji closed both eyes, but there was no sign of her being shot.

"Have you come to collect the supplies in this area, perhaps?"

"W-Well..."

"I should think it would be for your own good to answer honestly."

"...Y-Yeah. There's ammo... so we came to get it..."

"Is that so? In that case, you may take the supplies and return with them to Class B."

"What... do you mean?"

"Being defeated by me was nothing more than a series of unfortunate events. It would be a pity to single out Class B and bully them for no reason, wouldn't it?"

"Don't you dare fall for it, Morofuji! He's bound to shoot you in the back once you open the box! Koenji wants the ammo!"

"Y-Yeah!"

Morofuji nodded, taking the advice from the student who'd been eliminated.

Seeing this, Koenji let out a light sigh.

"My, my, that's quite the misjudgment. For me, winning or losing this special exam is a matter of supreme indifference. I have no interest in whether I defeat the VIP here, or whether I obtain the supplies. However, for all of you, the VIP's points are a crucial element, are they not? And the supplies as well..."

"Oh, well," Koenji muttered and began to walk away.

"A-Are you really letting me go?"

"You're quite persistent, aren't you? If you desire it so much, shall I eliminate you here and send you on your way?"

When he pointed the muzzle of the assault rifle at Morofuji, the sheer force of it made her shake her head vigorously from side to side.

"Very well. I shall take my leave now. I trust you will take care not to get in my way again. I am, after all, thinking of returning to the ship soon."

It was an act of kindness, in Koenji's own way.

And it was also a strong warning that absolutely must not be defied.

Part 4

ABOUT 30 MINUTES before the Class B students were suddenly attacked.

At 11:00 a.m., Class C reached the first event time of the second day and upon receiving information that all squares on the outer perimeter had been designated as restricted areas, they immediately began a new strategy meeting.

Although the sea accounted for most of it, the fact that a total of 56 squares had become restricted left the students unable to hide their surprise.

"Does this mean the restricted areas might...grow from the outside in?"

As Hashimoto murmured his hypothesis, Morishita immediately added to it.

"That's a definite possibility. If the map ultimately shrinks to a single area, a fight will be inevitable. Don't you think Ayanokouji Kiyotaka would agree?"

It was a simple and effective way to forcibly gather the classes that'd been keeping their distance until then.

"I agree. Even if the map doesn't converge perfectly on the center, expanding the restricted areas from the perimeter inward is one of the most logical ways to lead us toward the end goal of this survival game: defeating opponents with paintball guns."

If all the remaining outer squares became unusable with each event, an additional 48 squares would be lost. On the third occasion, another 40 would disappear and by tomorrow, it would shrink to the final square. Considering the three-night, four-day duration, the pace of reduction would inevitably be a bit slower, but it was best to keep in mind that it would likely end up that way by the final day.

Northeast, northwest, southeast, southwest, or the center.

The probability that it would narrow from one of these points was high, but it was still impossible to determine which one for now.

Or rather, the school probably wouldn't narrow it down in a way that would be easy to figure out early on.

That was precisely why each class was racking their brains, trying to decide where to move while still participating in events.

The starting point wouldn't be revealed until the third day at the earliest, or perhaps at the time of reduction on the fourth day.

"Right now, everyone's focused on moving around the island, gathering supplies and staying healthy, but that's nothing more than a prelude. It's become more likely that the class that can secure the best position for the final firefight or the one that can seize even the slightest momentum, will be the victor."

"So it's like this whole thing's going to be settled with a pure survival game? Well then, I'm ready to show my stuff."

Morishita clenched her fist.

The possibility that the outcome would be decided by pure combat had indeed increased. No matter how many rounds of ammunition or how much food one gathered, a moment of carelessness could take out ten or twenty people. So what was the point of these three nights and four days? Of course, it served as a mechanism to create small advantages, but it seemed too elaborate for just that. Was it an opportunity to experience life on a deserted island and learn from the extraordinary? The food obtained from supply crates was by no means plentiful and they were forced to manage their health under difficult conditions, so gaining survival experience separate from the game itself wasn't a bad thing... but.

Was this survival embedded in a survival game, or a survival game embedded in survival?

Or would this lead to something completely separate from the special exam?

"It'd be great for us if the other classes just started fighting each other in the smaller area. No doubt we'll be at a disadvantage in a firefight if we don't close the numbers gap, even by a little."

Ignoring my classmates who continued their discussion, I narrowed down the possible scenarios to a few patterns and plotted them all out on the virtual map I'd already constructed in my mind.

The chaotic battle in the endgame was unavoidable. If the three VIPs were unfortunately taken out by stray rounds, it would be checkmate. On the other hand, if only the VIPs were to flee, their allies would lose contact with their commander and wouldn't know the enemy's location, which would also increase the risk of the VIPs being targeted and picked off. The existence of tactics for identifying individuals was likely a weapon for just such a situation.

In the end, even if I could wrack my brain and increase our odds of winning, I couldn't bring them to one hundred percent.

Still, I had to build a strategy to increase our chances of winning, even by a single percent.

How would the four classes move in response to the restricted areas? What're they planning?

I had to construct the logic and predict several outcomes.

I thought faster than anyone else about how I could intervene to reach the ideal outcome.

I deduced the psychological states of each class, considering the presence of the VIPs, their movements within the deep forest and where they would end up.

The future-oriented movements of Class A and Class D.

To what extent did Class B intend to suppress Class C?

Taking a composite view of all those factors, I first considered how my own class should move.

And then there was one other lingering concern: the likely route of Koenji, who moved freely and capriciously on his own. He was a presence that had surely been plaguing Horikita's mind from the start.

Thinking of it as a chance to provoke him and observe his movements, perhaps she would try to control him a little, even if it was a long shot.

While weaving together the event area displayed on the analyst's tablet and the reports from the commander, I raised my head to look at my classmates.

"We're leaving now. We're going to secure the supplies and food at G11."

Even if we ran, a fight would occur eventually. It was a decision to strike rather than wait.

Hearing that, my classmates looked at each other, their expressions showing a hint of confusion.

"It's tough that no supplies spawned in an area we can safely secure, but going for G11 means we'll run into Ryuuen's class, right? Besides, they're a little closer."

Matoba said he didn't like a gamble where, even if they headed out immediately, there was a chance the supplies could be collected first.

He continued, saying they should consider waiting and seeing for this event, but I strongly rejected that and reiterated that we would be going on the offensive.

"Enough idle talk. It's precisely because the enemy is closer that we must get there first."

Ryuuen's group would probably take ten to fifteen minutes, while it would take us fifteen to twenty.

Swift action was essential to close that five-minute gap.

"Ayanokouji's the leader. We trust him and follow his orders, right?"

"...Well... I guess so. All right."

Even with Hashimoto's words, Matoba couldn't seem to shake his anxiety, but that feeling itself wasn't wrong. After all, jumping into a place where the enemy was lying in wait was akin to a suicide mission.

I didn't address their unease and we began to move. At the GPS update five minutes later, all of us moved into area G12.

"Class B's GPS shows they're currently split into three groups. One group of ten is heading toward area E9. Another ten are in G8. And the rest are all gathered over by G11."

As I took the radio report, information regarding the other classes' situations was also relayed.

"So the real fight is finally starting, huh... Even though they're missing twenty-something people, that just barely makes us even. No, maybe I should just be grateful we can fight on even terms...?"

"That's not necessarily true. They've realized we're heading for G11 at this point, so they might just turn back and launch an all-out attack... What'll we do if we see signs of that?"

"That's unlikely to happen. Even if it looks like we're targeting G11, they can't gauge how serious we are. If they were to call back the group they sent to retrieve supplies, we would naturally retreat. They know that."

Class B, who could reach the target area first, gained an advantage at that point.

Being in a position to intercept us created a significant advantage. It wasn't too late for them to fight for real after they probed just how serious we were about capturing the supplies.

We rearranged our formation, solidifying the front to middle ranks with boys as guards. The two VIPs were placed in the back, I stood in front of them and Hashimoto took up the rear, as if to protect the VIPs' backs.

"Gotta admit, even I'm getting a little tense here."

Perhaps his weapon-holding hand was sweating, as Hashimoto supported his weapon with his left hand and lightly wiped his right on his jersey. Once he

finished, he did the same with the other hand. The time was 11:15 a.m. I received the latest information and learned that the GPS signals of Ryuuen's group, lying in wait, were packed together just ahead. After that, I also received the routine report on the locations of the other GPS signals.

"They're just ahead... maybe two or three minutes... if we walk that far..."

I gave a hand signal, instructing everyone to stop.

"We'll wait here for five minutes."

"Five minutes? Is that okay? Won't they take the supplies during that time if we're not careful?"

"They don't have that luxury."

They were likely planning to lie in wait and intercept us with a flawless formation. If they carelessly focused on the supplies, their initial reaction to our attack would be delayed. Before long, our surroundings fell silent.

A silence to ensure we wouldn't miss the sound if, by some chance, they attacked first.

A time when only the tense breathing of my classmates echoed through the forest.

As time ticked by, feeling more like an hour than just five minutes, Shiraishi spoke in a low voice.

"There seems to be almost no movement. They're completely wary of us and have stopped. Shimazaki-kun says to let him know whenever you want to use a tactic."

"We're not using any tactics. If we save them, the enemy will have to remain constantly on guard. More importantly, tell me the GPS locations and details for the other classes."

I got looks from several people, as if asking why I needed information on other classes in that situation, but I got the details from the commander and had Shiraishi relay them to me.

"We'll wait another five minutes."

"...Seriously? Well... Roger."

How we would fight after that was already decided.

We could've attacked then and we could've attacked five minutes ago.

And—I already knew the result.

But, if we were going to attack anyway, it was better to do it at the ideal time.

We spent another five minutes in silence and the time passed 11:25 a.m. Immediately after confirming through Shiraishi that the targets ahead had barely moved and after receiving the status report on the other classes, I raised my arm.

"Let's advance. Once you find the enemy, you have my permission to attack without hesitation. Also, Matoba, you'll take command during the battle."

"What? Aren't you going to take command, Ayanokouji?"

"I thought it best to leave it to you in the front lines, for the sake of class coordination."

"...I see... In that case, I accept. Let's go...!"

It probably wasn't an appointment he was happy about, but Matoba accepted readily without arguing.

"Ayanokouji, you just stay back here and protect the VIPs, okay? As long as they're safe, I still think we can win this,"

Hashimoto said in a small voice, considering the possibility that Matoba might fail.

"Understood."

Matoba ran to the front, let out a word to fire everyone up and moved forward.

Immediately after, there was a loud cracking sound of a branch breaking in the woods ahead—

Right after, a series of gunshots that seemed to rip through the forest air flew at us.

The bullets tore through the air and leaves scattered, leaving behind the specks of paintballs.

Several people in the front line flinched, their shoulders trembling.

The enemy's first strike. Class B spotted us first and made their move.

"They're firing! Fire! Light 'em up!"

It didn't go like it did in practice; the students kept their fingers on the triggers and fired on full auto.

The return fire split thin branches diagonally, leaving marks like blood splatters with every impact.

But hitting them wasn't easy. The distance was still fifteen to twenty meters or more.

The enemy had taken up positions between the trees and rocks and only small parts of their faces and bodies were visible.

Just when they were spotted, they immediately pulled back and returned fire when they saw an opening.

"Three to the front right! I've confirmed one more in the back!"

"Hold them down! Concentrate fire on the base of that tree!"

At Matoba's command, the front line fired all at once.

Paintballs flew in succession, chipping away at the tree's bark.

However—the alarm that was supposed to sound from a wristwatch upon a successful hit never went off.

On the contrary, a counterattack came back immediately.

An enemy's shot flew in as if sliding from a low angle, striking one of the Class C vanguards squarely in the chest. Bright red paint spread as an electronic sound rang out.

"One person's out! Fall back a bit!"

"Shit, where the hell are they shooting from!?"

Panic spread in an instant. Not missing this opportunity, Class B laid down a barrage from the cover of the woods on both sides.

A dozen or so dry popping sounds rang out in succession. The formation fell into disarray and the situation was disastrous.

"Ugh—!"

A second and then a third, were hit in quick succession.

Unable to expose their bodies to defend themselves, they were taken out one after another, starting with those with the largest exposed areas.

Hashimoto immediately shouted, the smile completely gone from his face.

"Front line, fall back to the trees and use the cover better! Mid-rank, provide covering fire!"

The students moved according to the orders, but the trees were close together and visibility was poor.

Class B's shots were clearly more accurate than ours; they read our positions and adjusted their angles of attack.

Even so, one of the shots they returned miraculously hit its mark.

A faint electronic sound rang out from deep within the forest and one of the opponents stood up.

In that moment, the atmosphere on our side shifted slightly.

"A hit! We took one down!"

"Nice, keep 'em pinned down!"

The rhythm of their firing returned for just a moment.

But the enemy also regrouped immediately.

Matching our gunfire, they fired back with precision, as if pinpointing our locations by sound.

A paintball grazed past someone's head and spectacularly splattered a tree behind them.

"Three to the front left! There's another guy aiming from deep in the woods!"

"It's too dangerous to circle around, keep your distance!"

An order was given, but a student on the right couldn't react in time and was shot in the shoulder, triggering the fourth electronic sound.

Then another, someone who had been behind a tree, was shot in the leg and the 'out' signal rang.

A fifth person. Deeply colored paint dripped onto the ground.

The firefight lasted only a few minutes, but it was so intense it left them breathless.

"I'm hit! I can't even tell if we're hitting them at all!"

A student, crouching to stay out of the way, punched the ground in frustration.

"No, we hit 'em! My shot hit just now!"

"On the right side, there's five of them!"

I took a moment to compose my breathing and surveyed the scene before me.

Class B remained hidden in the shade of the trees. The tempo of their shooting didn't falter.

They probably had the advantage of having secured more paintballs than Class C with their provisions, but the difference in quality was clear.

Even if the numbers were equal, Class B was overwhelmingly superior in terms of supplies, momentum and composure. That much was clear even just watching from a short distance away.

Compared to our casualties, the enemy had at most one or two.

If it continued, our losses would only grow.

It was safe to conclude that the outcome of the battle had been decided in an instant.

Calmly and briefly, I gave the order.

"Continuing any further will only worsen our losses. We're retreating."

"R-Retreat? We're retreating, right!?"

I announced the retreat to all the remaining classmates and had the front line fall back by walking backward so they would not be pursued. It was then that Morishita also hurried from the middle line to the rear.

A Class B student closed in, their gun's muzzle taking aim at Morishita.

"Watch out, Yamamura Miki—"

Morishita shouted and just as she grabbed both of Yamamura's shoulders, a single paintball hit her in the back.

"Kgh...!"

An expression of anguish. Immediately after, a second and then a third shot landed on her back.

Hashimoto hurriedly fired back but missed and the Class B student retreated as if to flee.

"Ugh..."

A groan. Morishita was done for now, the alarm on her wrist blaring mercilessly.

"M-Morishita-san!"

"It would appear... this is the end for me. At the very least, you must escape..."

"No... Why would you protect someone like me...!?"

No, had Morishita really protected Yamamura? It looked to me like the gun had been aimed at Morishita and realizing she was the target, she had tried to use the nearby Yamamura as a shield to save herself, but failed... No, surely even Morishita wouldn't do something like that— Actually, she just might.

"I, too, had some goodness left in my heart. That is all there is to it."

Whichever her true intentions were, there was no time to find out now.

"You must live, Yamamura Miki. And, in my stead, as an Amazoness... Ghk."

"Morishita-san...Morishita-san..."

Morishita had closed her eyes and leaned limply, but then she suddenly snapped them wide open.

"I believe it would be best for you to flee quickly. Pursuers may be on their way."

"Eh, ah... Um, that is, yes..."

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. I leave the rest to you. I shall be taking it easy on the ship."

For someone who'd just been eliminated, she didn't seem to mind at all. In fact, she even seemed happy that things had wrapped up so quickly.

And so, the 'Amazoness of the Dense Forest' who even volunteered to be a guard was out, disappearing from the class without making any major contribution.



At the very end, a strange, relaxed atmosphere hung in the air for a moment, but we hurried to continue our retreat regardless.

Part 5

WE WITHDREW FROM area G11 and fell back to the evacuation point at H12, the designated spot in case of defeat. I had my classmates take a rest while I went a short distance away to talk with Shiraishi and Hashimoto.

As it happened, Yamamura was there by herself and she tried to leave when we approached, but when I told her it was fine for her to stay, she gave a hesitant nod.

"It seems we're not being followed. I believe we can rest easy for now."

"We're totally screwed... It's like, I really felt the strength of the side that just waits. Or rather, they just have more guys who are genuinely better at survival games than we are."

While there was a big difference between attacking and defending, Hashimoto muttered his honest impression from the firefight with a hint of surrender.

To be honest, I didn't think there was a huge difference in skill itself, but Class B's fighting spirit and intensity were far superior. It was proof that Ryuuen's high-pressure morale and orders were working in their favor.

"I've just received one piece of good news."

Shiraishi, who continued to communicate via radio even after confirming Class B wasn't in pursuit, cut in during a lull in the conversation.

"Apparently, the GPS signals for the ten Class B students who went to E9 have all been eliminated, save for one."

"...Huh? The hell? What's that supposed to mean?"

"It appears to be the result of their route completely overlapping with Koenji-kun's GPS."

"You're not serious. He took out nine guys all by himself?"

"The situation would suggest so. It's hard to say if he listened to Horikita's instructions or if it was just a whim. Given how things have played out, the latter seems more likely."

"Heh, if that's the case, we've turned a disaster into a blessing. That bastard Ryuuen must've taken some serious damage."

Hashimoto spoke cheerfully. It was true that this was likely an unforeseen battle for Ryuuen. The recent fight against Class C had an ideal outcome of six

to one or two, but behind the scenes, he lost nine people. This was damage that couldn't be ignored.

"Still, we struggled just to take out one or two people and Koenji goes and solos nine? What a hell of a trade that turned out to be."

"Koenji-kun has not been eliminated and is apparently still staying in E9 alone."

He took out nine people and still managed to survive without being eliminated?

"An unexpected outcome. Still, there's a big gap between Class C and Class B."

I knew he was the type to swat down an annoying fly if it buzzed in front of his face, but it seemed he made contact and engaged them in a small area. The result appeared to be a more overwhelming victory for Koenji than I'd imagined, but it was unclear if it would motivate him. In fact, it seemed entirely possible he might just be satisfied and call it quits.

However, I couldn't be as genuinely happy as Hashimoto and the others about Koenji defeating nine people.

At first glance, it seemed like only a good thing for the other classes, but there was the matter of balance.

I was fifty-fifty on which way I wanted things to turn out, but it looked like I needed to give it some thought.

As Hashimoto, Shiraishi and I were talking, Matoba, who'd been fighting on the front lines, walked over, his expression one of utter exhaustion.

"...Can I talk to you for a minute?"

"If you're gonna blame Ayanokouji for this situation, give me a break, man. He's doin' his best while we're half-destroyed as it is."

"I know. That's why I want to continue our talk from yesterday... no, the one we cut short."

"The one we cut short?"

When I tilted my head slightly, not understanding what he meant, Matoba spoke hesitantly.

"It's... about the alliance with Class D."

"We can take our time and discuss that matter after this exam is over. Even if I get expelled, the deal won't fall through, so don't worry."

"No... it's because we're in this situation that I want to talk about it now. You probably think this is self-serving, but I understood it clearly in that last fight. We can't push back and what's more, we can barely even move. It's a certainty that the area will shrink from here on out and Class A or Class D might come to finish us off while we're weak. There's just no way I can see us surviving."

Having fought them head-on, perhaps his spirit had been broken by Class B's aggressive stance.

"It's frustrating, but I can't deny it. I'm trying my best to win for real, but there's no guarantee we can turn this disadvantage around."

"I know. That's why I'm asking if we can make the alliance... official, right here and now."

"An alliance?"

"Well, if Class D will have us, I want to join up with them right away. I thought that would be for the best. If the alliance is formed, we'll have a huge force of about fifty people. We could make a full recovery, not just some kind of rally, right?"

As if it was their only option, he cast aside his pride and opened the lid he himself closed, making his appeal.

Hashimoto reacted immediately, patting Matoba on the shoulder.

"Nah, I was thinking the same thing. I've already told the class about the alliance talks and the C and D alliance is gonna be exposed soon anyway, right? It might be a little earlier than planned, but I think it's the best way to protect ourselves."

While he followed my instructions, he would likely welcome any plan that was safer.

A brief silence fell as everyone held their breath, waiting for my answer.

"It's my fault things got this bad; I let my guard down. But it's true that because we left the possibility of an alliance open, it might just be our last hope. Matoba, if you and the rest of our classmates can agree to it, then it's worth taking that bet."

Just as Matoba nodded, Hashimoto clapped his hands together with a *smack*.

"I'll talk to the other guys. You cool with that?"

"Yeah, I'm counting on you."

"Alright. Leave it to me."

Thumbs-up and looking pleased, Hashimoto ran over to his battered and bruised classmates.

Yamamura watched the exchange without saying a single word.

However, she looked at me hesitantly, as if she had something she wanted to say.

"What is it? If you have something on your mind, say it."

"Ah, no, it's just... you accepted Matoba-kun's... reproposed alliance so readily... I was just thinking... I'm sorry."

"Was that wrong?"

"N-No, of course, I also felt that merging with Class D was one of the best choices to protect our class now that we've been cornered this badly. It's just... if this was going to happen, I can't help but wonder if it might have been better to discuss the alliance again much sooner... Morishita-san might not have been eliminated and..."

It seemed Yamamura was thinking that I, of all people, could have tried to bring up the alliance again after we were ambushed.

"I was told to drop any talk of an alliance, so I couldn't bring it up."

"...Right, of course... I'm sorry for saying something so strange."

Even after hearing my answer, far from looking relieved, an even deeper shadow fell over Yamamura's expression.

Chapter 5:
The Alliance

THE 1:00 PM event only brought about the appearance of new supplies without expanding the restricted area. Having lost the direct confrontation with Class B, we immediately began moving east. Our goal was to make contact with Class D, who were gathered at M10. Meanwhile, after watching us move, Ryuuen's class split back into three groups and began to move out to secure the large number of supplies spread across the southern area.

Koenji, who launched a surprise attack, had been wandering around B8 and B9 alone since noon. He might have been enjoying a carefree swim in the ocean.

It was a fortunate development for Class C that supply crates with ammunition appeared at K12 and L13. Since there were supplies we could easily secure during our retreat, we were able to collect them safely.

Then, at 3:00 PM, the third event of the day was announced and on the analysts' tablets, another outer ring of squares was colored gray.

As most expected, it seemed the usable area was shrinking in a circular pattern.

In response, an hour later, Class A made a new move. Having been scouting a wide area in the north, they began to converge on the center of F and G, preparing to escape to a safe zone in advance of the 5:00 PM event or the new restricted areas that would appear on the following day.

Meanwhile, Class D was also wary of the outer restricted areas expanding. Seeming to have concluded that heading north was too risky, they hastily began to return to the center through N13 and N14. At that rate, we would soon run into them.

We all stopped for one last confirmation.

Hashimoto spoke to the students who still looked somewhat uneasy or dissatisfied.

"We're lucky Ayanokouji brought up the idea of an alliance. If no one had even mentioned the word 'alliance' at this point, there's no way one would've been formed during this special exam."

With Ichinose, there was a good chance she would've considered and formed an alliance even in a tight spot, but Hashimoto didn't let on anything of the sort. He hyped up the fact that I'd formed an alliance as a golden opportunity. However, there were likely still parts the other students couldn't believe.

"Is this for real? What if they just decide to finish us off while we're wounded?"

"Don't you worry about that. Ayanokouji'll handle the talks. But we're in an overwhelmingly weak position. We'll probably have to accept whatever demands Class D makes, though."

As the ones being helped, most of my classmates had no choice but to swallow it and move on.

"...Well, to be honest, there are still parts I'm not entirely convinced about. But our class isn't exactly good at these kinds of exams, to put it nicely. I was worried about how well we'd be able to hold our own against people like Ryuuen and Sudou. Instead of getting stuck in third or fourth, making an alliance or whatever to take second place... I guess I can't say it's a bad thing... but..."

Of course, it still meant giving up on first place, so it wasn't something to be unconditionally happy about.

Still, if we could walk away with second place from that point, it was more than enough as a compromise.

"If we concede the win—even if we concede it, will Ichinose really follow through in the next special exam?"

I decided it would be better for me to explain that point instead of Hashimoto, so I interjected.

"If you've seen the kind of student Ichinose is, you should understand that she can be trusted. Besides, they have no merit in betraying us just because we let Class D win this exam. It's not like taking first place one time will get them to Class A. If they were to carelessly throw away our alliance, the backlash would be greater than you can imagine. The collapse of a class that's been built on trust would be inevitable."

That was why, I explained, there was no way they would unilaterally terminate the alliance.

"...I see."

In exchange for the appeal of the reward decreasing, the risk of placing in the lower ranks was reduced.

And if the goal was to make the current Class A and Class B take those lower spots, it wasn't a bad plan at all. In the short term, we'd be saddled with the Class D title, but what was more important was closing the gap with the upper classes.

"Class C and Class D form an alliance and take first and second place. If you can guarantee that outcome and those rankings you're talking about, we'll accept the alliance on positive terms. Are we good with that?"

"That's enough."

Pragmatism over empty gestures. Whether we were in an alliance or not, the most important priority was ensuring our own victory.

My classmates considered and accepted that fact in a very short amount of time.

The color returned slightly to the faces of the students who'd grown pale after losing the battle with Class B.

On the other hand, you could never really know people. It was Hashimoto who'd taken it upon himself to persuade our classmates about the alliance, but he seemed unable to completely shake his own doubts.

The moment everyone looked away, he approached me and spoke in a low voice to confirm.

"You're sure this is gonna be okay, right?"

"What's wrong? Are you worried about the alliance after all?"

When I gave him a probing look, he averted his gaze with an awkward expression.

"...Nah, forget I said that. It's your plan and you're the one who said you'd drop out if we lose. What choice do I have but to believe you?"

Given that he was the type to start from a place of doubt, Hashimoto's reaction was understandable.

"I don't mind. In fact, actively speaking your mind is a benefit to me, not a detriment. If you have any concerns, feel free to voice them or consult with me whenever you like."

"Oh, really? Well, I appreciate you sayin' that, but..."

We continued to walk after that, taking breaks in between, for another thirty minutes.

Just as we neared the border of L13 and M13, a report came from the commander that the positions of Class C and Class D were just a stone's throw away.

"We'll wait here for now. I'll go talk to them by myself first."

I handed my weapon to Matoba. Hashimoto, as if confirming his resolve, followed suit and handed over his own.

Then, the sound of running came through and he immediately stood beside me.

"I'm going too and don't try to stop me, alright? If they start shootin' without askin' questions, I can be your shield. If you, the leader, survive, we'll still have a chance to win, right?"

"I suppose I'll gratefully accept your sentiment."

If Ichinose intended to betray and defeat me, she would do it after pretending to be an ally and luring in all of Class C. It was highly unlikely she would open fire at this stage.

However, there was no need to dismiss Hashimoto's spirit and determination, so I permitted him to accompany me.

"So now we've got no way to fight back, huh. If they shoot, it's all over for us."

"It would be the same even if we had our weapons. Standing up to them would be futile against their overwhelming numbers."

"...That's true."

With our concerned classmates watching from behind, we started walking toward Class D's standby point.

Part 1

AFTER PROCEEDING THROUGH the forest for about five minutes, the two of us arrived at our destination.

"—Halt."

The Class D students must have been watching the two signals on their GPS heading toward them.

Ten male students, led by Kanzaki, formed a wall to protect their classmates behind them, mercilessly pointing their guns at us.

"Looks like we're gettin' a warm welcome."

Faced with a reception that made it impossible to hide, let alone escape, it seemed Hashimoto could only laugh.

"We have no intention of attacking."

Hashimoto and I raised our hands, showing that we held nothing.

"I wonder about that. There's a possibility your allies are hiding nearby."

"Nah, that ain't it. You guys are always watchin' the GPS, right?"

"If your commander is using tactics, that's not necessarily the case, as you should be well aware."

"Nah, you can only fake out the whole GPS or an individual's GPS, one or the other, y'know? There's no way to freeze the GPS of only the people other than us."

"However, it is possible to target up to three people individually."

The possibility that we had three allies use the individual GPS jamming tactic to outsmart them and lie in wait behind us, or somewhere nearby, couldn't be denied.

What Class D was wary of were three invisible, armed enemies.

While it might not have been enough to overturn a situation where they were at an overwhelming disadvantage, it could be called the only way to inflict major damage.

"Just three people ain't gonna do nothin'."

"If you were to jam the entire GPS right this instant, it would no longer be limited to three people. Am I wrong?"

"...Fair point."

Kanzaki declared to Hashimoto that there were any number of ways to deceive Class D.

"But in reality, we have no desire to fight Class D. First, let us talk."

"There's no need for that."

Saying that, Kanzaki approached us, his gun still raised.

"It seems you were caught in a surprise attack by Ryuuen and lost the morning battle as well."

"So you got a good look at our pathetic state, huh."

"If we defeat the two of you here, we can significantly lower our chances of coming in last. This is a golden opportunity."

"That might be true if you're only looking at this special exam. However, even if you defeat us, there's no guarantee you can beat Class A and Class B. Your goal isn't to avoid last place, but to aim for the top. Surely you understand that much without Ichinose having to tell you?"

Although they'd been wounded by Koenji, it remained doubtful just how much of an advantage Class D could gain against Class B, who already had combat experience, with numbers alone.

"Let's join forces. That way, Class C and Class D can form a group of fifty."

"An alliance... What if we trust you and are betrayed? That would be a crisis for our class."

Although he wore a stern expression, I didn't get a strong sense of hostility from Kanzaki.

"That's why I refuse—or rather, it's not that I don't feel like saying that and sending you away... but I can trust you, right?"

The atmosphere changed. It was a reaction as if he already understood everything about why we came.

Ichinose, their commander, had likely already given them some sort of message.

"Right now, we need Class D's help. And we believe we can be the strength that Class D needs."

As soon as I answered, Kanzaki lowered the gun he'd been holding.

As if on cue, the boys standing behind him all lowered their guns at once.

"You can bring your allies. As you wish, let's talk first."

"I'm grateful we didn't get shot, but... you're being awfully reasonable, aren't ya?"

Hashimoto, whose imagination hadn't yet reached the behind-the-scenes interactions between Ichinose and Class D, suspected this might be a trap to lure us in.

"Ichinose told us that Class C might make contact at some point. She also warned us not to make the first move until we were attacked."

"Well, what do you know— You're sayin' Ichinose saw it comin' that we'd ask for your help?"

"I also heard about the alliance. Considering that, a request for cooperation is hardly a stretch."

He shifted his gaze from Hashimoto to me, so I gave a slight nod.

Part 2

A FEW HOURS before Class C and Class D made contact and were about to form an alliance.

It was when Class B and Class C were engaged in a battle over supplies at G11.

Ichinose quietly watched the battle's progress on her tablet.

The time from the close-range standoff to the actual combat was truly brief, yet it was a battle that definitively produced a winner and a loser.

After confirming on the GPS that Class C was fleeing to the southeast, Ichinose took her tablet and stood up from the chair placed beside her tent.

It was now the second day of the exam. If one glanced down every five minutes as the GPS updated and watched Class C's movements as frequently as their own, their understanding of the one leading the class, Ayanokouji, would naturally become clearer.

Class C, half-destroyed by Class B's surprise attack on the first day, had been forced onto the defensive yesterday and today, pinned down in the southern area near the base.

Their recent attack, an attempt to make a comeback by recovering at least one more supply cache, also ended in failure and looking only at the results, it meant they made a huge blunder twice in a row.

What did Ichinose think as she watched those events unfold?

Ayanokouji's uncharacteristic carelessness and his clumsy way of fighting—that was what left a strong impression.

'It helps us out that they're fighting, but Class C is really in a bind, huh?'

The voice of Kobashi, the VIP, reached Ichinose through the radio.

She then continued.

'We're just going to keep our distance like we've been doing, right?'

That was the safe play. All the classes would maintain their distance and concentrate only on recovering supplies.

They only needed to fight when absolutely necessary. That was the better way of thinking, the standard strategy.

'At this rate, Class C might just end up losing.'

Kobashi muttered.

"That's not true."

'Huh? No? What do you mean... not true?'

Ichinose smiled and sent gentle words over the radio.

"Ayanokouji-kun won't lose. No, I won't *let* him lose."

Having said that, she once again explained in detail the story of the alliance she made with Ayanokouji.

'...Does that mean we're supposed to help Class C?'

Without denying the question, Ichinose continued in the same tone.

"If we absorb Class C, we'll become the largest force. No matter how belligerent Ryuuen-kun is, he can't carelessly attack a class with over fifty people. Of course, the same can be said for Class A."

If that happened, Class A and Class B would have no choice but to crush one another. If first place became impossible, the battle would shift to one of trying to force the other into third place in order to aim for second.

"I need you to tell everyone in the class properly beforehand. Ayanokouji-kun will be making contact with Class D, so when he does, make sure we absolutely do *not* attack first."

It came through even over the radio that Kobashi, who hurried off to get Kanzaki, was conveying Ichinose's words with gestures. He might have wanted to object, but there would probably be no arguments.

Judging that her class was ready to accept Class C for the time being, she quietly stood up.

And then she gazed at Class C's current location.

"Mhm..."

Ichinose hugged her tablet and her thoughts drifted to Ayanokouji.

"—I understand, Ayanokouji-kun. I know what you're thinking."

As if trying to link her thoughts with his more than anyone else, her consciousness was always directed toward Ayanokouji.

'Kanzaki-kun wants me to ask, just to be sure, if this will really be for Class D's benefit. He seems anxious after seeing how Class C has been acting so far...'

"That's a needless worry. Because Ayanokouji-kun is—"

Quietly over the radio, Ichinose stated her thoughts.

Part 3

TIMIDLY, WITHOUT COMPLETELY letting their guard down, the students of Class C joined Class D at their campsite. It would be difficult for them to open up right away. In some cases, their wariness might not fade until the exam ended; I myself anticipated as much, but that prediction was soon overturned in a good way.

The unique characteristic of Class D. The trust Ichinose cultivated. Towards the members of Class C, who were unable to readily reach out, the Class D students actively spoke to them, treating them no differently than they would during their usual school life.

And they even encouraged active mingling between students who didn't usually have strong connections.

In a situation where it would've been perfectly normal for Class D, with their numerical advantage in the special exam, to try and take the lead, they treated them as equals. That opened the closed-off hearts of Class C and rapidly lowered their guard.

Of course, complete trust couldn't be formed immediately. However, there was no doubt that they made an impression strong enough to make one think that if they were to be betrayed by Class D, then it couldn't be helped.

"The charm Class D possesses is incredible."

Shiraishi, too, seemed to be one of those impressed by the sight.

"I'm surprised, too. It's a strength that can't be seen from class rankings or test scores alone."

"To maintain an alliance, both sides must be equal. It would never work if the powerful party tried to dominate from above, if one side became too subservient, or if mutual suspicion were allowed to spread. With Class A or Class B, it would've been impossible from the start."

“The information that Classes C and D may have formed an alliance in this special exam, based on GPS movements, has likely been reported from the commanders to the VIPs and shared by now. At this stage, it's become difficult to oppose the combined force of the C-D alliance, which is now the largest group."

But we couldn't let our guard down for a moment. If anything, we had to become even more vigilant.

"How do you think the top two classes will assess this situation and act from here on out?"

"If I'm just stating my wishful thinking, I'd want them to crush each other somewhere that doesn't involve us. Even though our alliance has the numerical advantage, if either of them challenged us, more than half of us would be eliminated. If that happens, the remaining class can aim for victory by taking advantage of the conflict."

However, the same could be said from any class's perspective.

Naturally, making the first move wouldn't be easy.

Part 4

IT WAS 6:00 PM on the second day. The supplies we acquired included food such as nutritional bars, two kilograms of white rice and canned goods. In addition, there were five new plastic bowls and cups and thoughtfully, five pairs of disposable chopsticks as well. We decided who would eat the white rice with a fair game of rock-paper-scissors, under the condition that no one could refuse without a reason and I became one of the winners. I decided to gratefully accept the warm meal.

White steam billowed gently from the lid of the mess tin over the evening campfire. With the orange-dyed sky at my back, sweat beaded on my hands as I judged the fire's heat. Before long, after the quiet crackling of scorching rice echoed through the quieting forest, I opened the lid and a cloud of fluffy steam billowed out.

Under the setting sun, the freshly cooked white rice shone with a particular brilliance.

Just as I picked up my chopsticks, Shibata, who'd been watching me from a distance, approached with his lips pressed firmly together.

"H-Hey, Ayanokouji. Sorry to bother you before you eat, but you got a sec?"

"I don't mind. What is it?"

"Uh... how should I put it? We're allies now, right? So, I just wanted to say hi, or something..."

He said it while his eyes darted around, scratching his head vigorously.

"Um... this is kind of a weird question, but—uh..."

"Go ahead and say it."

When I prompted Shibata, who was unable to get to the point, his averted gaze met mine.

"The thing I want to ask is...!"

Just as he seemed to have made up his mind and opened his mouth wide, another person approached from behind.

"Pardon me, Shibata, but could you give us a moment? I have something to discuss with Ayanokouji."

It was Kanzaki, who'd taken the lead on serving duty; he approached with an empty mess tin in one hand.

"O-Oh, yeah, n-no problem at all. See ya later, Ayanokouji...!"

As if fleeing, Shibata ran off and left the area.

"Do you need something?"

"I forgot to tell you something important. Regarding the chain of command from here on, Ichinose has said to entrust everything to you, Ayanokouji."

"I see. I appreciate that, but are you ok with that?"

"My satisfaction is irrelevant. Ichinose is the leader of Class D. There are no longer any students in this class who would object to that."

"Such impressive loyalty."

Or perhaps their fangs had already been broken and they simply stopped caring about such trivial matters.

In any case, if things went smoothly, I had no complaints.

Even after I told him what I'd forgotten to mention, Kanzaki made no move to leave.

"Is there something else?"

"...There's something that I just can't seem to accept."

Having said that and pausing for a moment, Kanzaki continued.

"Why did you propose something as unprofitable as an alliance with Class D? I don't understand why you'd go out of your way to lend us a hand and give us a chance to get back on our feet."

"There's no 'why' to it. We were hit with a surprise attack from Ryuuen's class and lost half our classmates in an instant. Without this alliance, we would've inevitably ended up in last place in this special exam. That means the alliance was certainly meaningful."



"That's just looking at the result. You were scheming with Ichinose behind the scenes to form an alliance before the island exam, no, even before we became third-years, weren't you? At the very least, I can't imagine Class C had any need for it at that point. You should be able to recover on your own and compete with Class A and Class B."

Kanzaki had met my father, Ayanokouji Atsuomi. And just as Kanzaki's father admired that man, so did he. Consequently, his opinion of me, Atsuomi's son, was also inevitably high.

"You're overestimating me."

"I'm no fool. It's not just because of your father; I've watched you for more than two years now, so I'm well aware. You have the power to turn the tide of battle all by yourself."

"That's an odd thing to say. I lost half my classmates to Ryuuen's surprise attack. And just this morning, I took an all-or-nothing gamble, lost six people and failed to secure any supplies. If you don't call that overestimating me, what do you call it?"

"Of course, no one is perfect. Anyone can make a miscalculation like that. Or rather, even before that, Class C just isn't suited for fighting."

"That's precisely why. Can't you think of the alliance as insurance, just in case? It won't have a major impact on Class C if Class D rises up a bit. And it's useful in other ways, too. If we couldn't count on Class D growing and rising over this next year, then Horikita and Ryuuen would only have to focus on Class C. It's easier for us to operate if their attention is divided. I'm not extending a hand for nothing."

In terms of overall strength, Class C was certainly a step ahead.

But in reality, it was Class C that was now asking for help and Class D accepted.

"Class D is still developing. You can count on your potential for growth."

"Still developing when we're a lap behind?"

"There's plenty of time. If we can manage a one-two finish in this special exam, the gap with the top classes will be trivial. Am I wrong?"

"I can't shake the feeling that they're still out of our reach... But I suppose Ichinose believes; believes that with you, we can aim for that—even after all these failures, Ichinose doesn't seem to doubt your abilities."

That was probably connected to why she said she was leaving the command to me.

I finished my white rice and gently closed the lid of my mess tin.

Then I stood up and moved to Kanzaki's side.

"It would be a problem if Ichinose were the only one aiming for Class A. You, Kanzaki, need to be on the same page as her and more than anything, you need confidence and resolve."

"Confidence and resolve..."

"If you still don't get it, then you should take a good look at the view from here. You may want to deny it, but the strength that only Class D possesses is on clear, almost amusing, display."

In the scene spread out before him, students from Class C and Class D were conversing without any wariness.

"You should try to better understand just how incredible it is to be trusted."

It was an environment where Class D, superior in numbers, could defeat Class C with a single surprise attack if they so chose.

If their opponents were Class A or Class B? They definitely couldn't have felt at ease. They would've been fraught with anxiety, wondering when they'd be backstabbed.

"Why don't you come visit the sports gym sometime?"

"...That's out of the blue. What brought that on?"

"It's what they call being 'so close, yet so far.' You should start by getting to know what kind of person Ichinose is up close."

I knew I might not get a favorable answer now, but it would be enough to simply plant the thought in his mind.

Chapter 6:
The Real Goal

CLASS B SPENT that night in tents pitched on the edge of the beach at E12, so the sound of the waves could be heard nearby even from inside. Ryuuen laid in his tent, lost in thought as he stared at the low ceiling. When he heard footsteps nearby, a faint shadow appeared.

"It's past nine o'clock."

At Katsuragi's quiet report, Ryuuen silently sat up and went outside his tent.

The students who'd been waiting for Ryuuen to emerge greeted him one after another.

He ignored them and walked over to Katsuragi, who was waiting with a map spread out.

Ibuki and Ishizaki were also waiting for him with grim expressions.

"From last evening to this morning, no students from Class C or Class D have been eliminated. In fact, the two classes are now clustered together, intermingled."

"So they teamed up, huh?"

"I thought it was strange there were no signs of combat from the moment they made contact, but...for it to come to this."

"It's the only way for the nearly-annihilated Class C to survive, I guess. Heard they were making some weird contact with Ichinose, too. Means they were plannin' to team up from an early stage."

Now that it'd actually happened, it seemed like the best possible move for the wounded Class C to take.

"Yesterday's battle with Koenji was also a huge blow. Losing nine people is a considerable loss. The fact that Morofuji survived without being eliminated was a silver lining, but..."

"Man, I really wish he'd just charged into Class C and Class D instead."

"In this matter, the fault lies heavily with Komiya's group for their rash, semi-provocative actions after their paths crossed. Had they quietly let him pass, it is highly likely a conflict could have been avoided."

He said after summarizing the report from Morofuji, who desperately returned to the main force yesterday.

"Oh, but Ryuuen-san, that Koenji guy retired just a little while ago!"

"Guess he's satisfied after hunting down some small fry. What a self-centered bastard."

"The sacrifices were not insignificant, but it means one threat has been eliminated. That's precisely why the frustration with Komiya's group's failure is mounting, however..."

"But Morofuji's group *was* trying to contact Kaneda before they fought Koenji, weren't they?"

As Ibuki interjected, Ishizaki also spoke up defensively.

"Right at that moment, the Class C guys attacked to secure supplies, so the radio was tied up, right? I don't think it's fair to blame only Komiya's group. They just had bad luck."

Katsuragi, to whom those words were directed, looked quietly at Ryuuen and opened his mouth.

"Bad luck... was it? Do you really think so?"

"Nah. The timing was just too damn perfect. If they were serious about stealing supplies, they should've been able to rush over a bit sooner. Maybe they delayed a little to aim for when Komiya's group would run into Koenji."

The main force and the detached unit. It was obvious which radio would be prioritized. If Ryuuen had been speaking directly with Kaneda, he could have relayed a message to Komiya's group with little time lost, but with a VIP in between, there were inevitably delays and errors in the information transmission.

"You mean *he* planned that? If so, that's too perfect. I can't believe it."

Katsuragi folded his arms and once again recalled the events of yesterday.

"I also believe, as Ryuuen said, that there's no doubt Ayanokouji orchestrated this, aiming for the moment Komiya's unit and Koenji would overlap. However, he likely didn't think the probability of an actual engagement was high. It is more natural to see it as him aiming for a by-product of his own attack."

If Komiya's group calmly altered their course or hid themselves, they wouldn't have ended up in a fight, judging from what Koenji said to Morofuji.

Ryuuen and Katsuragi had the same thought. Even if that wasn't the case, they firmly shared the understanding that their opponent was someone who'd do that kind of thing.

"Uh, um, Ryuuen-san. About Class C and Class D becoming allies, how are they gonna decide who gets the higher rank? Wouldn't they normally not be able to agree...?"

"Obviously Class C's gonna compromise. No matter how you look at it, they're headed straight for last place on their own. I can just picture 'em, crying and begging Class D to help them out in exchange for letting them take the glory."

"Oh, I see," Ishizaki said, striking his fist into his palm in understanding.

"That's the key point. The issue of ranking, which would be a source of endless dispute if they were equals, becomes a viable alliance precisely because of the difference in their positions. They've certainly played a troublesome hand. As a result, their side has swelled to fifty people and the difference in numbers between them and us, who lost Komiya's group, now exceeds twenty. The tables have completely turned."

Katsuragi explained the situation was no longer optimistic, but Ishizaki once again slapped his palm.

"Then how 'bout we team up with Class A? Together we'd have sixty people!"

"And would we, who are similarly at a numerical disadvantage, concede and give first place to Class A?"

"Eh? Uh, well, that's—can't be helped, right? Ah, but no, that's no good...!"

Ordinarily, an alliance was not something easily formed. For two classes competing for the seat of Class A, not even a single class point was something they could readily compromise on.

To begin with, there was far too little merit for Class B in teaming up with Class A only to hand over first place.

There was no trust between them and it was uncertain if they could even form an alliance. Even if they did, there was no guarantee they could beat C and D. Rather than shouldering multiple risks like that, it was more efficient for Class B, in its aim for the top, to defeat Class A directly and secure third place or higher.

"If this had been a move right at the start, we would have still had several options, but for them to form an alliance here on the third day is more troublesome than I imagined."

Even the path of defeating the crucial Class A was now hampered by the difference in numbers created by the elimination of Komiya's group. It was inevitable that this would hinder their battles when the number of usable areas drastically decreased.

"What will you do, Ryuuen? Today's actions may well decide the outcome of this exam."

His judgment as leader was now being tested.

He was the sole focus of Katsuragi, Ibuki and Ishizaki, all eyes were on Ryuuen.

The initiative had, at some point, slipped from Ryuuen's grasp and was now passing to the opponent who should've been at a disadvantage.

The possibility that the lower-ranked alliance would launch a preemptive strike to defeat either Class A or Class B couldn't be dismissed.

"Things are finally gettin' interesting."

For Ryuuen, one thing was certain: there wasn't much time left.

Still, he couldn't come to a conclusion right away.

Leaving word for his comrades to wait, Ryuuen turned his back on the three of them and began to walk toward the sandy beach.

Part 1

AFTER THAT, RYUUEN, who'd been standing alone at the water's edge thinking as he stared at the sea, took a map out of his pocket. From their current situation, what could he do to lead the class to victory? Defeating Class A in an all-out battle before the lower-class alliance closed in on their area was the most rational and simple option. Should he make his move early on this third day—

After that, there was also the all-or-nothing strategy of using their remaining forces to target only Ayanokouji's group's VIP—

"Don't like this one bit."

Choosing that option meant his judgment was being influenced by the hastily formed lower-class alliance.

It was nothing less than the side that succeeded in a surprise attack and seized the advantage being forced onto the defensive.

The feeling that he wouldn't let Ayanokouji have his way welled up inside him.

If that was the case, then he could also go all out and attack the lower-class alliance.

They must be thinking that we won't make a move against an alliance that has swelled to fifty people with Class B...

"Heh, he ain't that naive."

Attacking Class A, attacking the alliance—Ayanokouji had probably considered both.

Either way, Ayanokouji already anticipated in his mind how Ryuuen would fight.

"What do I want to do... No, what do I want?"

Victory for Class B was a given, but there was something he craved just as much.

And that was to beat Ayanokouji.

What should he choose to achieve that and be satisfied?

As he averted his gaze from the sea and turned around, he found a lone girl walking on the beach.

All by herself, she was smiling at the gently lapping waves.

Ryuuen lightly rolled up the map, stuck it in the back pocket of his gym uniform and started walking toward the person.

"Lookin' pretty happy all by yourself, Shiina."

"Oh my, good morning, Ryuuen-kun."

Shiina, who returned the short greeting, turned to face Ryuuen and smiled cheerfully.

"Since we're at the beach, I was taking a little walk."

After answering, Shiina looked at Ryuuen's stern expression and surmised his state of mind.

"I heard that there is a high probability that Class C and Class D have joined forces. What do you intend to do?"

As Shiina walked slowly along the deserted beach, Ryuuen matched her pace and walked alongside her.

"There ain't nothin' to it. I'm gonna win this special exam and I'm gonna do it with my own damn power."

Ryuuen declared forcefully, as if to hide his own indecisiveness.

"Yes. We believe in your words, Ryuuen-kun and we will follow you, now and always."

Seeing Shiina smile, Ryuuen returned a slight smile of his own.

"Do whatever you want for the next 30 minutes or so."

Ryuuen turned his back to return to the tent, but Shiina called out to him.

"Ryuuen-kun, if the beginning of a novel you were reading was hopelessly pessimistic, what kind of ending would you imagine?"

Such a question. Anyone else probably would've scoffed and ignored her.

He stopped and thought about it seriously. Then he immediately found the answer within himself.

"Unfortunately, I'm not a fan of stories with depressin' beginnings. But most stories are made to be convenient, ain't they? If that's the case, then wouldn't they usually turn out for the better?"

"That's true. The structure of a story is such that readers are most moved when it turns from darkness to light, so works with sad starts often become the foundation for depicting rebirth, atonement and healing. Conversely, if a story begins on a bright note, a sad ending often awaits."

After replying, Shiina continued.

"However, it's a wide world out there. There are many masterpieces that are sad from beginning to end."

"What're you gettin' at?"

"That it's best to be mentally prepared for whatever might happen. Not just for this special exam, but for what lies beyond as well..."

Just as there was a chance of victory in an exam he thought he might lose, defeat lurked in an exam he thought he could win. And, that it wouldn't necessarily always follow that rule.

"So in the end, it means we don't know shit about what's comin', huh."

"Fufu, perhaps that's so."

"But still—I'll force my way through with my own power. Whatever it takes to take down Ayanokouji."

"I believe that's for the best."

Looking into Shiina's eyes as she answered, Ryuuen gave her a sharp, testing gaze.

"And that's even if I force some kinda cruel choice on you down the line?"

Ryuuen knew full well that it was a malicious question. That was precisely why it was a question that, ordinarily, he shouldn't have voiced.

But Shiina met his gaze without looking away.

"If it would be for the sake of everyone... for the sake of the Class B that is so important to me..."

After she answered, Shiina gazed at Ryuuen with a smile.

"In that case—I won't hesitate. No matter who my opponent is, or what the outcome may be."

"Good."

After meeting the gaze of Shiina, who answered with resolve, Ryuuen returned to the tent where Katsuragi and the others waited.

Part 2

DAY 1, DAY 2. Each class tried its best to avoid combat and focused solely on securing supplies.

They held one another in check and watched, scurrying about various places to gather supplies.

The only spectacular development, to repeat myself, was the surprise attack by Class B and the few-minute shootout on the second day that we initiated to secure supplies.

However, moment by moment, the off-limits areas were steadily increasing.

For now, it was only the outer perimeter, two squares deep. In other words, each class simply had to move away from the coast and shift slightly inward; avoiding large-scale combat would've been easy at that point.

But from the third day onward, that would almost certainly not be the case. The representatives of the Class C and Class D alliance, who set up a base in K13, began a discussion, joined by several students from both classes.

"Where've you been all morning? I even went to your tent to get ya, y'know?"

"My bad, I had some business to take care of."

When I offered a light apology with my right hand, Hashimoto stared at it quizzically.

"Ain't it kinda dirty?"

"It's nothing serious, don't worry about it. More importantly, let me hear what you were discussing."

"Hm? Oh, right—Kanzaki, please continue."

"I was just saying that we've reached a difficult phase. We've used most of our handheld provisions and it wouldn't be surprising if they were depleted by noon. Also, Sumida and Minamikata have seemed somewhat unwell since this morning. They themselves say they are still fine, but I don't believe they will last until the exam is over."

I received Kanzaki's report on the Class D students.

"If one is the VIP, it would be a bit of a hassle, but if they're guards, having them retire now may be an option. In any case, I want you to tell them not to

overdo it. The damage will only be greater if they lie to themselves and force it."

"...Ah, yes. Saying that will likely put them both at ease. Moriyama, my apologies, but would you mind relaying Ayanokouji's words to them?"

Nodding as if to say, "Leave it to me," Moriyama headed off at a run toward the tents that were being taken down.

"But man, we're obviously runnin' low on supplies. We got nothin' but a bunch of starving folks over here, too."

Pressing his stomach lightly, Hashimoto muttered wearily.

"Yes. And it's already the third day of the exam; there must be a limit to how much longer we can continue collecting from a distance. Which means... a battle over supplies is finally about to begin. Let me hear your thoughts."

When Kanzaki asked me about our plan for the day, I nodded silently.

"There are broadly two methods for determining our plan. One is to envision the objective you wish to achieve and map out a path to it. The other is to gauge the enemy's aim and thwart their intentions."

I spread out the map and began to explain in a way that was easy for Hashimoto and Kanzaki to understand.

"On the first day, Class B—or rather, Ryuuen—launched a surprise attack on Class C. What do you suppose the reason was?"

"What's there to suppose? He figured he could deal a huge blow to the enemy by catching them off guard. It's the story of him taking a risk and successfully pulling it off, ain't it?"

"If the lottery results had been different and Class A was next to us, would he have attacked in the same way?"

Kanzaki crossed his arms, thought for a moment, then nodded.

"Wouldn't Class A have been the ideal enemy, instead? If you think about it that way, attacking becomes the obvious choice."

"My thinking is different. I believe that if Ryuuen couldn't launch a surprise attack on Class C, he wouldn't have initiated a fight using his trump card tactic from the very beginning. Why did it have to be the lower-ranked Class C? Because in order to win, he considers my existence to be one of the most troublesome obstacles."

"To Ryuuen, you're his arch-rival now. That makes you the best opponent to take down with a sneak attack."

"I can't say I don't get what you're saying, but even so, I can't accept the conclusion that he wouldn't have attacked Class A. Even if they weren't ideal, he should've had no problem attacking."

If they could knock the top-ranked Class A to last place, Class B would be able to pull itself much closer to that position. What Kanzaki wanted to say was simple.

"There's a troublesome presence in Class A from the start. Needless to say, it's Koenji. At the beginning, it was impossible to judge whether he intended to participate in this special exam or not. In fact, you felt he was an element of uncertainty too, didn't you?"

"...Yeah, that's true."

"Even if he didn't intend to participate, Koenji was still with Class A for a short time after the start. Launching a surprise attack there would create the unnecessary risk of waking a sleeping lion."

"I see... So if Koenji took issue with the surprise attack and cooperated with his class and by some chance launched a counterattack, the situation would instantly become impossible to read, is that it?"

Ichinose must have reported on that point as well. Kanzaki muttered.

"In fact, the Class B students who came into contact with Koenji were eliminated, after all... I see."

He was a person with enough potential to make one think he could change the course of the battle all by himself, a fact no one would deny.

"In any case, after much consideration, Ryuuen executed a surprise attack and gained a huge advantage over Class C. But now, compared to Class A, he's lost fourteen guards and can no longer use his core tactic of disabling the overall GPS. Now that the number of out-of-bounds areas is increasing, the value of this tactic is growing with each passing moment."

"If the opponent's GPS stops working when you start fighting, even for just thirty minutes, you won't know where they're coming from. It wouldn't be strange to be completely immobilized."

He himself demonstrated, through the surprise attack he launched, that a successful ambush could inflict enormous damage, even if only for a short time.

"So what's your take on it? Does Ryuuen plan to attack, or defend? Let me hear what you think."

"He'll wait until the last possible moment without launching a hasty attack. He's waiting for the time when the out-of-bounds areas expand, making it impossible to escape far away and forcing the four classes to gather whether they like it or not."

That was the closest thing to the optimal solution. The problem was whether Ryuuen could choose that answer. If he impatiently went after Class A or the allied classes, Class B might be eliminated surprisingly quickly.

"Then should we attack instead?"

"No, avoiding engagement is best for now. We'll stick to a defensive strategy, just like on the first and second days."

Even if we did nothing, the exam's end time was fixed.

A development in which we would all randomly fire at each other within the shrinking area was sure to come.

And that, in fact, was the very development we were hoping for.

Part 3

AT 11:00 A.M., as supplies appeared, the restricted area simultaneously expanded and an announcement was made that in one hour, the available area would become an 81-square, nine-by-nine grid from D4 to L12.

The supplies were located in a total of eleven spots: D4, D8, D10, E6, F6, G7, H10, I12, J5, K10 and L10. It seemed some were in places that were extremely difficult to retrieve, or just barely reachable and the more difficult the supply crate, the higher the proportion of them contained food.

"They're really testing us... but J5 and K10? That's just asking too much."

Hashimoto let out a wry smile and waved his hands back and forth as if to say it was impossible.

From our current position, it seemed best to focus solely on moving toward the center during the 11:00 a.m. event.

"It's a shame we can't retrieve the food, but it can't be helped."

Before I could say anything, Kanzaki said as much, having apparently reached the same conclusion.

"That's right. I want to avoid the risk of pushing ourselves unnecessarily, losing stamina, or getting injured. The greatest strength of the allied classes is our numbers. To avoid pointlessly whittling them down, ignoring the treacherous routes is the correct choice."

We were short on many things, but it was time for patience.

"However, I want to send a few people ahead to secure the food at H10."

It was highly likely they wouldn't make it by walking, but if they maintained a light jog, they could just barely get there.

As if he'd already mentally prepared himself, Hashimoto gave a stretch.

"Well then, guess I'll step up. I'll make a run for it and see if I can secure them. Takemoto should be ready to go, too."

"To prevent them from narrowing down our VIP, we'll assign several mobile guards from our class. Besides, there's no guarantee that Class B won't try to come at us with tactics to stop individuals."

With that, Kanzaki called over several male students and told them about the plan.

The classmates watched the backs of the group that departed immediately.

"Let's follow after them at a reasonable pace."

To prepare for when and how the restricted area might expand next, both classes first began to advance toward the area from H10 to H12.

For a while after that, a period of time began where, just as we had for the past two days, we exchanged messages with the VIP every five minutes and kept a constant watch on the movements of the other classes. The possibility that Class B might aim for H12 wasn't zero, but perhaps judging it too difficult due to the distance, it seemed they decided to focus on gathering supplies in the western area, where they could be secured reliably.

"Just as you predicted, it doesn't seem like Ryuuen is making a move to attack either side yet."

"Yeah. But going on the offensive isn't necessarily a bad move."

"Oh, is that so?"

"It's simply a matter of the priority of fighting changing depending on what you prioritize. If closing the gap with those above is the most important thing, then the best move is to attack Class A right now and defeat their three VIPs. Alternatively, quickly securing G8 and forcing Class A to take a detour, like over the mountain, could also be interesting."

"Well, as long as they beat Horikita's group, losing to us once isn't a big deal for them, huh."

The reason Ryuuen wasn't moving was either because he prioritized beating the allied classes over victory against Class A, or because he determined that was the choice that would lead to his own victory.

Perhaps it was a strong indication of his will to avoid the risk of engagement to the utmost limit and conserve his stamina.

And before long, a report came in from the commander to our VIP that the supplies had been secured.

Part 4

WE SECURED AREA H12 as planned and waited there.

The designated areas weren't expanded at the 1:00 PM event. Neither Class A nor Class B made any significant moves and just like that, it was time for the 3:00 PM update.

The commander contacted Shiraishi and the additional designated areas were announced.

Upon hearing that, Hashimoto and Kanzaki exchanged a glance and then both looked over at me almost simultaneously.

"Looks like the situation's finally changed, huh?"

Up until now, the designated areas had been shrinking inward from the map's outer perimeter, one row at a time.

That pattern was broken for the first time. Rows 4 and 5 and columns K and L all became designated areas. In other words, the remaining area was now shifted slightly southwest of the center.

Class A, which had been staying in F5, would likely now have to hurry toward G8.

And it seemed highly likely that Class B would stay put, not panicking.

If they moved carelessly toward the center, they would also run the risk of being caught in a pincer attack.

One could say Class B's fate depended on whether they regretted not acting sooner, or if they had another plan and remained unfazed.

"We're inside the area and getting too close to the center is kinda sketchy, y'know? If it's the same as yesterday, the area probably won't shrink at the 5 PM event, so is waiting and seeing the right move here?"

Hashimoto muttered, map in hand, saying that was what he would do.

"However, waiting right on the edge of the designated area has its own risks. If we're ambushed ahead of us during the next update, our escape route will be completely cut off."

"I get what you're saying, Kanzaki, but are you suggesting we move forward one whole area? Honestly, a ten-minute time difference is practically nothing."

"We can secure a better position if we move now. If we move to H10, it will be easier to flexibly move in any direction—north, south, east, or west."

Kanzaki pointed with his index finger, indicating that a spot south of the center of the remaining area would be ideal.

"But won't that make it easier for other classes to attack us? What do you think, Ayanokouji?"

"I can't say for certain, but considering how the designated area expanded from the northeast this time, the probability of the mountain being left is extremely low. Moving a little closer now would be the better option. H10 isn't a bad choice."

Moving carelessly too far north or west would only increase the chances of attracting other classes.

Our new destination was a short move to the north. As for supplies, they had appeared at our newly designated destination, H10 and also at J12, so we decided on a policy to retrieve them from just those two locations.

"Form a retrieval squad and send a small group to J12. In the meantime, the rest of us will move to H10. It will probably be our last destination for today."

The third day was entering its latter half, but we decided to continue observing Class A's and Class B's movements.

Part 5

EVEN AS 3:30 p.m. and then 4:00 p.m. arrived, Class B showed no signs of attacking.

They'd been based in area E12 since morning, with no major movements to be seen. They were only organizing small groups to collect supplies, just like us. Meanwhile, Class A, as if chased by the restricted area, had fled south and was about to reach G7.

If they continued on, their final destination would either be there or they would advance as far as G8.

Either way, it seemed that area would be their goal for the day.

Finally, we closed the distance to the point where we could reach the enemy's base in a matter of minutes.

However, it was time to change course.

"It looks like we should make an adjustment."

"An adjustment?... What do you mean by that?"

It was true that events had taken a turn I hadn't anticipated, but in that case, all I had to do was restore the balance from my end.

"Kanzaki! Come here a sec!"

Just as we arrived in H10 and were taking a break, Watanabe waved his hand and shouted.

I knew at once that something happened, so I, being nearby, headed over to Watanabe with Kanzaki. There, lying in the shade of a tree, was the figure of Ninomiya, breathing heavily.

Amikura, who was anxiously by her side, looked at us while placing a hand on her forehead.

"She hasn't been feeling well since this morning... I think she's started running a fever. I think she's at her limit."

Ninomiya had her eyes slightly open, but she seemed unable to even pretend she was all right for our sake. She would occasionally cough, her expression twisting in pain.

"She should retire immediately and have the school come pick her up."

Kanzaki nodded when I said that and Norihito immediately ran off to the VIP.

"A few students have been coughing since this morning. It's possible we might have a few more students retire between tonight and tomorrow."

I couldn't rule out the possibility that it wasn't just a matter of poor health, but that some kind of cold was spreading.

Even though we were outdoors, the students had been constantly moving around in close proximity for the past three days.

I reiterated that there was no need to push themselves.

This was likely also an effect of having shared the food we obtained with Class C, who hadn't been able to secure much, to support them. A lack of nutrition could disrupt the autonomic nervous system too, leading to a weakened immune system, making it easier to become ill.

"Sorry to bother you while you're busy, but today's final event is about to start."

I left Kanzaki in charge of the situation and returned with Hashimoto to where Shiraishi and Sanada were.

When 5:00 p.m. came, the analyst's tablet was updated.

As soon as the screen lit up, Hashimoto let out an involuntary whistle. An announcement was made that the restricted areas would increase again and it was decided that the survivable area would shrink to a six-by-six grid from D7 to I12.

"Since the area's gettin' smaller, the number of supply drops is down to eight. Looks like we're gonna be sleepin' on emptier stomachs tonight than yesterday. The only ones we can grab nearby are in G9 and H12 or so—"

"I'll go to G9. Takemoto... and about six others, lend me a hand."

I called over Moriyama, who was passing by and asked him to gather more people, telling them we were going to retrieve supplies.

"You're goin' too, Ayanokouji? You can just save your strength for the final day, y'know?"

"No, there's something I want to do. I'll explain the details to Takemoto on the way, so have Shimazaki fill you in."

"O-Oh, got it. Be careful out there."

I told the members to get ready to leave in three minutes and I began my own preparations.

A weapon, one bottle of water and portable rations. I also took a one-person tent.

After that, I took Takemoto, Moriyama and the others and hurried to the northern part of G9.

We found the supply crate right away and inside were seven single-serving meals. Of course, for an alliance of just under fifty people, it was a drop in the bucket, but even that was very much appreciated.

I looked at my watch and saw that it was about to be 5:25 p.m.

I had Takemoto check the status of Class A and Class B and found that Class A had finished collecting supplies and was about to enter area G8. Class B's situation hadn't changed since morning.

"It's already evening, but it's pretty scary with them just a stone's throw away. Let's hurry back."

Moriyama said that and I and Takemoto followed his lead, beginning our swift return to H10.

After walking for about ten minutes, I called out to Takemoto.

"Class A is moving as planned. Contact the commander now and tell them to disable my personal GPS the moment the next GPS update occurs."

"This is what you were talking about earlier... Are you really going to do it?"

"Yeah, I'm not coming back today. You remember the plan for after you return to the main group, right?"

"...I know. I've properly shared with Shimazaki what to do if you get taken out, or if you don't. Don't worry."

Takemoto nodded, though he still looked somewhat uneasy. Moriyama gently put his hand on his shoulder.

"Leave it to me until we get back. I'll make sure he gets there safely."

He gave a thumbs-up, so I returned the gesture.

Well then—there wasn't much time left until 6:00 p.m., so I decided it was time to really hurry.

Part 6

IN THE EVENING, after finishing their supply retrieval, Horikita and the others arrived at G8 around 5:25 p.m. This arrival time was a result of their constant wariness of an ambush, which had them keep the option of taking the route south from E6 to E8 open until the last possible moment. And just as they had five minutes prior, they received a report that the students from Class B and the Class C/D alliance were keeping their distance from G8.

"I wonder what happened to the eight GPS signals that went to retrieve supplies at G9?"

The instructions she'd been emphasizing over and over were confirmed by Matsushita through her VIP, Wang.

"It seems that at 5:25, they were all observed moving back toward H10."

"What the hell? So Ryuuen didn't make a move after all, even though they were up against a small group?"

They assumed that if one side moved, the other would move to intercept, but it didn't lead to a confrontation. As a result, the group of eight students from Class C and Class D succeeded in retrieving the supplies without any trouble.

"It can't be helped. No one could have predicted that Koenji-kun would take down nine people."

"...Yeah, I guess. But one thing's for sure, he wasn't fightin' for us. He even casually dropped by the beach and retired afterward. This ain't a game."

Horikita nodded once in agreement with Sudou's words. Koenji accidentally entered a state of combat with ten students from Class B who moved to retrieve supplies and he defeated nine of them. All nine people he took out were guards; the VIP wasn't among the defeated students. However, coordination between the analyst and the VIP and the VIP and the commander, was essential for accurately retrieving supplies. Immediately after learning of the battle, Horikita had them use tactics to identify the individuals, confirming that the only student who escaped was Morofuji Rika and that her role was the VIP.

"In any case, we need to focus on ourselves rather than the other classes right now. I don't think they'll attack us with just those eight people nearby, but tell everyone to remain vigilant."

Since they were only ten or fifteen minutes away in a straight line, the possibility that they would attack using individual GPS shutdowns was not, for

the time being, zero. That was why she communicated to Matsushita to keep watch without letting her guard down.

It was fifteen minutes later that Horikita, unable to fully shake her tension, finally felt a sense of relief.

After three GPS updates, the Class C students who'd been staying north of G9 finished retrieving their supplies and moved southeast. It was when she finished confirming that they were about to rendezvous with their allies in their designated waiting area, just before passing slightly through G10 and on to H10. There were only twenty minutes left. It was a distance that neither Class B nor the Class C/D alliance could possibly cover.

"Good work, everyone—we can get some proper rest around here today."

At her voice, her classmates all lowered their weapons at once and took their tents out of their backpacks. Because the trees were dense, they could not pitch their tents together, so each of them began to work separately.

It was just then.

"Uwah!"

A loud scream suddenly came from one of the boys, Hondou.

Horikita's heart skipped a beat for a moment, but the cause of the scream was immediately clear.

It was because a tree branch had pierced his tent, opening up a small hole.

"Damn, there's seriously no space to pitch a tent here."

"It can't be helped. This is the best position if we're to prepare for tomorrow. Be careful as you work."

In about five minutes, Horikita finished setting up her own sleeping quarters and stretched once.

"This is rough—"

Although they hadn't engaged in combat, they were about to face the third night with food constantly scarce and not enough water. Her body was already in a state where it was beginning to show signs of its limit. It was a harshness unlike that of any uninhabited island exam from the past two years.

A short distance away, Horikita spotted Karuizawa and two other girls who'd just finished their work and recalled what she wanted to talk about during the day if she had time. She approached them.

"Do you have a minute?"

"Hm? What's up, Horikita-san?"

Since she had even less stamina than Horikita, the signs of her fatigue were pronounced, but she put on a smile and looked at Horikita.

"There's something I want to ask you... but it's difficult to talk about here—"

She excused herself to Shinohara and Onodera, who were near Karuizawa and they moved to a spot a short distance away.

"Something you want to talk to me about? It's something you don't want overheard, right?"

"Yes, well, a little—"

As a cool breeze gently enveloped the two of them, Horikita took off her goggles as if to catch her breath.

The time was almost 6:00. As a rule, they had to keep them on until the exam ended, but she judged that it wouldn't matter anymore. Seeing this, Karuizawa also took off her goggles.

"It's pretty hot keeping these goggles on, isn't it?"

Karuizawa let out a breath and relaxed into the pleasant breeze.

"Ask me anything. We're friends, aren't we?"

Without even looking at Horikita, who'd been unable to broach the subject, she asked and Horikita steeled her resolve.

"It's about Class C and D. In the end, we've come to the evening of the third day without the GPS signals of either class decreasing significantly all day. It's a situation where there's no doubt that the two classes have joined hands."

"Yeah, there's no mistake about that. It's easy for losing classes to team up."

This much had been talked about all over the class from last night until now.

It wasn't something that required a private conversation between the two of them.

If that were the case, she immediately understood that Horikita wanted to take it one step further.

"What's bothering me is *when* the two classes decided to team up. We couldn't make contact with other classes when the special exam details were announced and their starting positions were far apart, with our class in between."

Since communication between commanders was also impossible, there was definitely no contact.

"Class D is a special class. They might have felt sympathy seeing Class C in a wounded state. However, that doesn't mean it's easy to suddenly accept a half-destroyed enemy. It shouldn't have been easy to form an alliance without some prior arrangement..."

"Yeah. Hirata-kun and the others said the same thing. They were speculating about all sorts of things, like maybe he not only threw the match but also gave them Private Points."

Karuizawa spoke while reminiscing and while Horikita agreed, she voiced another possibility.

"Right after he left the class, he and Ichinose-san became close... well, 'close' might be the wrong word, but I've sensed that they've been closing the distance between them."

The opening ceremony when he left the class. That day, Ayanokouji already met with Ichinose in addition to the Class C students after school. Perhaps their cooperation had been in motion beneath the surface since then.

Wanting confirmation on that point, Horikita replied to Karuizawa.

"I see... yeah, I think so too. In fact, I'm sure of it."

"So you think the same."

"Yeah. The relationship between Class C and D has definitely gotten deeper than before."

Karuizawa nodded firmly. In response, Horikita made a mental note that she might need to reconsider the future.

"Um... you kinda dodged this the other day, but can I ask you something a little more personal?"

"Hm, I dodged something? What are you talking about?"

"Even though you're enemies now, do you like Ayanokouji-kun, Horikita-san?"

"Huh? Wh-when you said 'more personal,' you meant *that*?"

"It's pretty important to me."

"I-I already told you, I've never been in love with anyone, have I not?"

"But you're flustered."

"When someone asks you a question like whether you like someone or not, it's only natural to get flustered."

Placing both hands behind her back along with her goggles, Horikita averted her gaze.

"Then do you like Sudou-kun?"

"Of course not. He's a dependable classmate."

"See? You answered instantly. And it was a similar question."

With a grin, Karuizawa pointed at Horikita as she made her point.

"That's—"

It was true; when it came to Ayanokouji, her mind would freeze for a moment and she couldn't think straight.

She felt it for some time.

It wasn't as if she'd never questioned it.

And yet, she still hadn't found the right answer for her own feelings.

"If you're holding back because of me, you don't have to. I don't think it's a bad thing to like the same person... besides..."

For a moment, the smile vanished from Karuizawa's face, replaced by a shadow.

"Besides... what?"

She couldn't help but ask.

"It's not just me and you who like Ayanokouji-kun, Horikita-san. Ichinose-san does too."

"...She does...? No, I'm not that surprised, but... is that true?"

"It's true. And I think their relationship is probably more than you imagine, Horikita-san."

"You mean... they're dating?"

For a moment, she wondered if that might be one of the reasons they had formed an alliance.

But Karuizawa shook her head and continued quietly.

"Um, I don't think so... but it's something close to that, I guess."

"I'm sorry, I don't quite understand what you mean—"

Just as she started to ask for more details, noisy voices came from the direction of the campsite.

Karuizawa in front of her also sensed the faint disturbance and their eyes met.

Just as it seemed to have gone quiet for a moment, the noisy voices returned.

This time, they didn't die down and with the passage of time, the clamor grew twice as loud.

Mixed in with those voices, the sound of a projectile flying could be faintly heard.

A dry sound echoed repeatedly.

"Is someone shooting? Am I imagining things?"

That was the question. However, the dry sounds continued to come from the direction of the tents.

"...There's no mistaking it."

The sound of someone firing a paintball gun rang out.

During the exam, they'd fired paintballs for practice several times, so it was by no means an unusual sound.

Even so, a sense of unease filled her.

The time on her watch showed it was just past 5:57 PM.

Strictly speaking, it was a time when the exam was not yet over.

But it was impossible.

She received a report that all eight GPS signals remaining nearby were on their way back to the enemy's main force. From that point, even if they aimed for Class A, there was no way a normal person could've made it in time.

"Let's go back."

The two of them ran toward the direction of the sound.

She hoped it was just a shot fired on accident, or playing around.

Horikita strongly wished for that, but upon returning near the tent, she noticed the disaster.

Ijuuin, standing stunned nearby, noticed Horikita's presence and turned around.

"Ugh... I was shot!"

Ijuuin clutched his abdomen, where a paintball splattered and the alarm on his watch was ringing. And as she looked around, between the erected tents, she caught sight of Mori with a splash of paint across her back.

"How many enemies!?"

"I-I don't know. Someone suddenly started shooting from the woods... a-and, but Sudou and the others went chasing after them that way!"

In the direction he pointed, several students were still running, weapons in hand.

She thought about returning to the tent to retrieve her weapon, but decided it was better to rush over even a second sooner, Horikita immediately followed after the students.

While readjusting her goggles, she took the handgun from the holster on her leg that she hadn't removed and scanned for the unseen allies and enemies.

Ahead, the sound of gunfire continued, two, three times.

She'd fired the handgun several times in practice, but even so, she'd yet to fire a single shot in actual combat.

It was the same for her allies fighting back ahead of her, who'd been caught completely by surprise. A sense of urgency grew within her, thinking that it was no different from when Class C was ambushed.

"Where... where are you...?!"

If there were multiple enemies, she felt she should've spotted at least one, but she saw no one other than her classmates. Kicking up dirt and treading on leaves, Horikita spotted a human silhouette ahead and raised her gun.

But it was an ally, not an enemy. She found Onodera sitting down, having been shot in the back. Noticing the footsteps, Onodera turned around, her expression regretful, but she immediately pointed to the northeast.



"Don't worry about me—that way!"

"Thank you!"

She passed by her and rushed ahead, gun raised. Where her vision opened up slightly, she saw several students continuously firing their paintball guns toward a single point.

"Corner him! This way!"

"He went that way!"

Lost amidst those voices, Horikita tried to grasp the situation and called out to Miyamoto, who was holding a shotgun.

"The enemy? How many?"

"It's Ayanokouji! Ayanokouji! He came barging in here all on his own!"

"...!"

At that moment, several classmates moved in from the left and right, trying to circle around behind a large tree.

"So he's over there...?"

Miyamoto nodded. Even Horikita, who'd just arrived, could see at a glance that Ayanokouji was completely surrounded and in an inescapable situation. He'd already been cornered.

There was no way for him to hide from the paintballs fired by the students surrounding the large tree.

Not only were Horikita and Miyamoto in front of him, but there were also male and female guards to his left, right and rear. It was truly a hopeless situation.

To attack alone and infiltrate the Class A campsite was far too reckless.

Although he'd taken down several guards, she wondered if it was worth the value of a student like Ayanokouji.

Horikita felt a sense of doubt at an action so disproportionate to the risk, but there wasn't enough time to find an answer.

Another three or four seconds—

And with that, this commotion would come to an end.

Before his classmates could complete their encirclement, Ayanokouji moved.

He took half a step forward from behind the large tree, aimed only at Ike and moved to raise his weapon.

Was his intention to take at least one person down with him if he was going to be defeated?

However, just a fraction of a second faster, the Class A students placed their fingers on the trigger.

"Fire—!!"

Hondou shouted as if giving a command; the situation was perfectly set up for a 100% elimination.

But—

It was then that Horikita realized it. She realized what Ayanokouji's aim was and why he was able to charge in all by himself.

"No! Don't shoot!"

Almost at the same time as the sound of someone's gunshot, Horikita screamed.

However, four of the students who had their weapons ready already finished pulling the trigger.

Paintballs hit Ayanokouji's right hand, right foot and the area near his side one after another, just as he was about to shoot them. The alarm blaring from his watch clearly indicated he was out.

"I did it! I did it! I'm the one who took down Ayanokouji! Serves you right, Ayanokouji!"

Ike, who hadn't heard the voice telling them to stop, jumped for joy.

The casualties were three people: Ijuuin, Onodera and Mori. It was a one-for-three trade, but it was a different story when the opponent was Ayanokouji. The students must have even thought they'd come out ahead by defeating the leader.

In a situation where it wouldn't have been strange to be celebrating, Horikita squeezed her eyes shut.

"It's no use... He isn't out..."

"Huh? I'm tellin' ya, they were clear hits! His watch is goin' off and everything!"

The classmates exchanged high-fives, unable to contain their excitement.

But the one who was calmer and more composed than anyone was the man who should have been out.

"My bad, Ike. It looks like you're the ones who are out, not me."

"What the hell is that...?! I don't get i—"

"...It's six o'clock. It's already past six o'clock."

The watch Horikita confirmed by bending her left arm had just passed 6:00:32.

"Huh...? Wha...?"

"The moment it turns 6:00 p.m., that day's test ends. All subsequent eliminations are rendered invalid and the student who fired the shot to take someone down is eliminated instead—that was the rule, wasn't it, Horikita?"

A solo attack, aimed at a moment when their guards were down.

The anger of having their comrades taken out and the perfect opportunity to defeat a traitor.

The students, driven by impulse, had completely forgotten about the current time.

If it was even one second past 6:00 p.m., the elimination was invalid. The signal emitted from Ayanokouji's watch clearly recorded him as safe.

"If you charge into the enemy camp alone, you won't get away unscathed. You deliberately used that, didn't you..."

"That's right. My bad."

Ayanokouji answered and glanced at Horikita for just a moment, but immediately looked away.

Sometime after 7:00 p.m., the school staff arrived and supplied Ayanokouji with a new tracksuit, after which the four students who fired and hit him outside of test hours retired by self-reporting.

The result of one person charging in alone was that he forced a mistake from his opponent and got as many as seven students eliminated.

While the commotion still continued, Ayanokouji silently began to set up his tent.

"H-Hey, what the hell are you doin' settin' up a tent here?!"

"I was under the impression I was free to set it up anywhere, but am I being a nuisance?"

"Of course you are!"

"That's no good, Hondou-kun. It's better not to keep Ayanokouji-kun at a distance."

"Huh? So what're you sayin', Hirata? That we should sleep with the enemy?"

"Fighting outside of hours is forbidden and if Ayanokouji-kun cheats, he'll be retired. What I'm trying to say is that if we keep Ayanokouji-kun at a distance, it will be easier for him to escape. Besides, at nine o'clock tomorrow morning, he absolutely has to start from the same area as us."

"O-Oh, right. So we can just blast him with paintballs when morning comes...!"

"Because you understood that, you decided to set up your tent here too, didn't you, Ayanokouji-kun?"

"Even if I were to keep my distance and set up camp somewhere else as if to escape now, it's obvious you'd just come to surround me in the morning anyway. It's better if we both don't waste our energy."

"Hey, you know... I don't think you realize you're in the enemy's cage, do you...?"

Next to Hondou, Shinohara, who'd been glaring with resentment over Ike being eliminated, grumbled this.

"That might be true."

Answering matter-of-factly without denying it, Ayanokouji went inside the tent he'd pitched.

Horikita was unable to say a single word and could only stare, dumbfounded.

Chapter 7:
The Time of the Decisive Battle

THE UNINHABITED ISLAND survival game exam, a maximum of three nights and four days, finally reached its last day.

At this point, the number of students remaining in each class, excluding the commanders, was as follows.

***Class A**: 3 VIPs surviving + 27 remaining students in total*

***Class B**: 3 VIPs surviving + 24 remaining students in total*

***Class C**: 2 VIPs surviving + 12 remaining students in total*

***Class D**: 3 VIPs surviving + 35 remaining students in total*

Perhaps because Class A, which secured supplies over a wide area in the north and Class B, where food appeared steadily in the west, were able to maintain the health of all their students at a minimum standard. Both classes had only one student retire each. On the other hand, Class C, which was suppressed by Class B right at the start, was half-decimated and had few students left. The supplies they obtained were also very scarce and their alliance with Class D forced an even more severe food problem upon them.

The time was now just past 8:40 in the morning.

Horikita completed taking down the tents and other things early on, prepared to move at a moment's notice.

There was an unusually tense atmosphere, different from the past three days. More than half of the area was already unusable and the four classes were just a stone's throw away from each other.

Class A's final location yesterday was G8, Class B's was E12 and the Class C-D alliance's was H10.

The final mind games would begin at the approaching hour of 9:00 a.m.

Would they go on the attack, or prioritize defense until the very last minute?

Horikita looked around once, checking on the state of her classmates.

Some were restless and fidgety, others more irritable than usual, but these were still the least of her worries.

The number of students weakened by their loss of stamina from four days of survival was also beginning to increase.

"The immediate problem is—something else, though..."

"What are we gonna do, Suzune? About him."

Sudou quietly approached the pensive Horikita and spoke.

Horikita quietly followed Sudou's gaze.

Giving no impression at all of being in enemy territory, his figure, calmly packing up a one-person tent, looked exceedingly composed from any angle.

Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. For Horikita, he was once the person she trusted the most, relied on the most and most—such a person.

Most of those around him were glaring at Ayanokouji with undisguised gazes of aversion.

The solo attack on Class A before 6 PM yesterday was completely and utterly unexpected.

He pretended to return to his main group, then used his superior physical abilities to close a distance a normal student couldn't have. He not only took out several classmates with his paintball gun, but also pulled off the incredible feat of getting them disqualified for a rule violation by using the exam's end time.

"Yesterday seriously had me in a cold sweat. I only couldn't shoot because Ayanokouji just happened to get behind a tree in my line of fire, but if he hadn't, I might've been out just like Ike and the others..."

Sudou, recalling the same scene, said quietly.

"It was understandable. A surprise attack by a single person and a talented former classmate at that. For those few minutes, everyone in the class lost their composure. He initiated the battle with exquisite timing."

The two of them looked toward Ayanokouji and briefly recalled what happened yesterday.

"Everyone seems quite bloodthirsty, don't they?"

Hirata approached Horikita and Sudou.

"No kidding. Charging in alone like that and getting the better of us..."

"Especially since the opponent was a former classmate."

"Yeah."

"Are you alright?"

"...I'm alright, I think."

Ayanokouji's appearance greatly unsettled and influenced Horikita's inner thoughts and mental state.

"Let's try to look on the bright side. Fortunately, it was only the guards who were taken out."

Hirata said, having the VIP defeated would've been the worst possible outcome. It was a good thing they'd at least avoided that, especially since everyone had been defenseless.

"That's true... He personally took out three people. It wouldn't have been surprising if a VIP had been among them."

Since she'd been a short distance from the campsite, Horikita didn't know the details of the raid.

"It seems several people managed to coordinate on the spot and form a defense to protect the three VIPs. Looks like our practice paid off, doesn't it?"

Sudou nodded and Horikita also gave a nod in response to the positive news.

"I'd like to do one last check before 9 o'clock. Do you have a moment?"

"Of course."

On the map Hirata spread out, all the areas that were prohibited were marked with an X.

"As I believe I mentioned yesterday, this is developing into a rather unfavorable situation for us."

Class A was based in G8.

Until yesterday, they'd safely completed events in the area to the north, but now the entire northern area was restricted.

"I wouldn't be surprised if the results of the eleven o'clock event push us even further toward the center."

The expansion of the restricted area and the prediction of where supplies would appear.

Once again, ahead of the battle that was likely to happen today, Horikita pressed her lips together firmly.

"Supplies are little more than a bonus at this point. We've gathered a decent amount of important ammunition, so I believe we don't need to push ourselves to get more from here on out."

"Yeah, I think that's fine. If a fight breaks out, some students will likely be eliminated, so the food supply should balance out. Worst-case scenario... we'll

just have them hold on until evening without a meal. And about the timing for our remaining tactic, am I right to assume you don't intend to change it from what you've already told us?"

"Yes, that hasn't changed. More importantly, what's crucial now is the position we take up."

Considering Class C and D was in H10 and Class B was in E12, they had to maneuver themselves to be ready for any expansion of the next restricted area.

"If we lean too far west, we've got Class B and if we lean too far east, it's the Class C and D alliance, huh. This is a damn hassle."

"That said, I can't exactly be happy about a scenario where the southern area shrinks, either. While it would save us from having to move, we'd also risk losing our escape route... Depending on the situation, we could even face the worst-case scenario of a pincer attack."

"For my part, I think we should bite the bullet and move from G8 to E9. What do you think?"

"That's not a bad idea... In fact, that's probably the correct answer. I was thinking the same thing."

If they had to choose an opponent, barring a pincer attack, it was none other than Class B. Their VIPs were unscathed and their number of guards was nearly identical. It was precisely because they were competing for the same rank.

Moreover, Class B already used its total GPS shutdown tactic, giving Class A a slight advantage on that front.

"So it means we might finally be going up against that bastard Ryuuen, huh?"

"If they were to clash with us, it would be a huge gamble for them, win or lose. They wouldn't have enough stamina left to defeat the allied classes. So I'd like to think they won't be too eager, but..."

A four-way standoff would have made a stalemate easy, but now it was a three-way affair.

With the sudden formation of a large alliance, Horikita was left with no choice but to make a bitter decision.

After they finished discussing their general plan once more, they took a short breather, but the conversation didn't end.

"Up until now, everything has gone more or less as expected, with the exception of the matter concerning Ayanokouji-kun. The decisive moment of

this special exam is right now, today, on this final day. The restricted areas closing in on the center to an extreme degree is also something I'd envisioned. The fact that we've saved our GPS shutdown tactic should definitely prove useful to us."

The key to the special exam wasn't to outwit and defeat opponents like Ryuuen, but to keep as many VIPs and guards in the game as possible until the very end.

They'd use the GPS shutdown tactic entirely for defense, not for offense.

That was the crucial decision Horikita made at the very beginning, a strategy she shared with the entire class. As for identifying individuals, they hadn't used it on anyone besides Morofuji and she thought it might not be needed again. Naturally, she had Matsushita lock on to Ayanokouji's GPS using his tag.

"You think you can get away from here, Ayanokouji?"

Perhaps unable to bear just watching any longer, Hondou approached Ayanokouji with an assault rifle in hand.

"Hey, Hondou!"

Sudou shouted at the sight, but as if they'd been waiting for one person to make a move, several boys and girls surrounded Ayanokouji with weapons in hand.

"We gotta punish the class traitor. I'm not about to let him do as he pleases any longer. I'm definitely taking Ayanokouji out right here."

"Stop that, Hondou-kun. Forcibly surrounding him here won't solve anything. The act of completely sealing off an opponent's path, even indirectly, is considered restraint. It most certainly won't be permitted."

"B-but! Are you just gonna let him do what he wants, then!?"

Everyone with a weapon directed their frustration toward Horikita.

"...I'm not saying that. Letting him escape is a threat to us. So it's self-evident that we must defeat him here. But we mustn't do it the wrong way. We are to maintain a suitable distance and wait for 9:00 a.m."

A path about a meter wide would suffice. Horikita figured that as long as they maintained enough space for Ayanokouji to walk freely, no problems would arise according to the rules. In response, the classmates glanced at one another, then moved to either side to create a path.

After looking at the narrow path, Ayanokouji looked toward Horikita and the others.

"The right call. Headquarters is undoubtedly tracking every student's GPS in real-time, 24/7. They know I'm in enemy territory and they know I'm surrounded like this. If my GPS didn't move and I was eliminated right at 9:00 a.m., the school would investigate the situation. I'd naturally claim I was restrained with my path completely blocked. The probability of you being penalized for a violation would be high."

Yesterday, Ayanokouji was eliminated after 6:00 p.m. and was rescued by school staff who rushed to the scene. Although malice wasn't found on the part of the students who fired outside of exam hours, they all received the penalty of elimination for a rule violation.

She couldn't let them repeat the same mistake.

No matter who Ayanokouji was, if things stayed like that until 9:00 a.m., he would have no chance of escape.

At best, the most he could do was fire his paint gun at the same time and take one person down with him.

"Aaargh, this is so damn frustrating... The enemy's right in front of my eyes! Dammit!"

Forced to clear a path and wait for 9:00 a.m., bound by the rules, Hondou yelled, frustrated by the dilemma.

"If this were a real battlefield, my method of fighting would be completely useless. But this is a special exam. It's a strategy that's only possible because I can use the rules and be protected by them. You should try copying it sometime, if you get the chance."

It was a provocative statement. Perhaps it was meant to bait someone into attacking rashly.

Just in case, Horikita once more told them to wait until 9:00 to fire.

Karuizawa watched the situation from afar, clenching her hands tightly.

And the time passed 8:50.

"Ten more minutes! We won't let you escape! Absolutely!"

With the exam's start time drawing near, Ayanokouji quietly took a step forward.

Tension ran through the Class A students as they aimed their muzzles, fingers on the triggers.

"What are you planning to do, Ayanokouji-kun?"

"What am I planning? Nothing. If there's a path, I'll walk it."

Ayanokouji started to walk. In response, the Class A students began to walk at the same pace.

They had sixteen guards in total, both boys and girls. Horikita took into consideration her classmates' feelings that they had to defeat Ayanokouji there, but in truth, she didn't want to send a single one of them

"I'm goin' too—"

Horikita grabbed Sudou by the shoulder, stopping him as he tried to dash off from her side.

"Don't... I'm sure it's no use."

"What's that supposed to mean, Suzune?"

"If he had resolved to fight us at nine o'clock sharp, we could defeat him. But I'm sure he won't fight. He'll pour every ounce of his being into getting away."

In the dense, tree-filled forest, Sudou was probably the only student who could keep up with Ayanokouji's outstanding physical abilities. In other words, he could easily shake off the sixteen of them in a chase that would only last a few minutes.

It was because he had that confidence that he could calmly spend the night in a tent next to Class A.

"But I'm confident I can keep up with him. He's got a lot of luggage, too."

"...That's exactly why I can't let you go."

At 9:00 a.m., in a worst-case scenario, a one-on-one fight between Ayanokouji and Sudou could occur.

If that happened, it was impossible to know who would win.

If by some chance Sudou lost and Ayanokouji escaped, Class A would suffer an even greater blow.

"But, hey, doesn't this mean we're playin' right into Ayanokouji's hands from start to finish...?"

"I know. But, just as he said himself, he skillfully used the special exam's rules this time. This isn't a situation that can be solved with brute force."

Moreover, the guards who pursued him would also exhaust their stamina.

The reason she didn't stop them was that she figured she couldn't.

The depths of the forest grew noisy as nine o'clock arrived.

Before long, the guards who lost sight of Ayanokouji returned, having used up their ammo and stamina.

Part 1

A LITTLE AFTER 10 a.m., just as my watch told me I shook off the Class A students and entered H10, Takemoto and Hashimoto came out to greet me.

It was the place I'd told them to wait if I managed to return safely.

"Yo! I got the report yesterday that you were out right at the very end and I got nervous for a second, but then I heard you were safe because it was after six? Man, you really do some crazy shit."

Despite his words, Hashimoto was smiling from start to finish and looked incredibly pleased.

"This guy's been all worked up ever since he found out you took out a few Class A students and even made them attack you after exam hours. He's been obnoxiously bragging about it this whole time, you know?"

Looking exasperated, Takemoto said, “Good work,” and lightly placed a hand on my shoulder.

"Of course I'm pumped! I was thinkin' there was no way you'd escape from the middle of enemy territory and now here you are right in front of me... You really are something else, man."

"We kept losing points in the beginning. I'm glad I could make up for it, even just a little."

"More than enough. Well, the only real bummer is that we couldn't get the VIP, I guess."

"About that. I want to give out instructions right away."

Flanked by Takemoto and Hashimoto, I started back toward the main group where Kanzaki and the others were waiting.

"What kind of instructions?"

After hearing the instructions, Hashimoto and Kanzaki exchanged a glance and though surprised, they immediately began selecting the people needed to carry it out.

I was grateful that they got their heads working before they even asked about the true meaning of my instructions.

I didn't say it there, but there was something I came to understand from infiltrating Class A.

It was that Class A was slightly lacking the tension it should've had.

This was likely because Horikita reassured her classmates early on by publicly declaring she would use her Protection Point to protect the class if they lost. On the other hand, Ryuuen's class was probably different. Even though Kaneda had a Protection Point, everyone was fighting desperately.

That seemed to be linked to their so-called higher motivation, one of the factors that would decide the outcome.

Shortly after, I regrouped with everyone and selected the students to send toward Class B. However, as the risk was extremely high this time, we didn't take the VIP. We sent out only two people: one student who was prepared to be sacrificed and one scout. And then, the rest of us waited for that time, 11 a.m.

The remaining survival area announced on the analyst's tablet was a 5x5 grid from D8 to H12.

And the provisions that appeared were at D12, E8, F10, G9 and H12.

But that wasn't the only important point. Although the restricted areas had been announced little by little with each new event cycle, on the final day, all of them were announced at once.

At 1 p.m., it would be the 16 squares from D9 to G12. At 3 p.m., it would shrink drastically to just four usable squares from D11 to E12. At 3:30 p.m., E11 and E12. And at 4 p.m. the exam would end—it looked to be a fierce battle in an area so narrow that with only two zones left, it would be practically impossible to survive without getting out. Moreover, the grace period for staying in a restricted area was no longer one hour, but came with the grand bonus of a forced expulsion after an accumulated 60 seconds if you stepped into one after 3 p.m.

"Damn, this is crazy... If we leave even one of their guards standing, we could get wiped out..."

Hashimoto grumbled that it was by no means enough space or time to get away.

But deciding they should focus on the immediate task, he shook his head once and continued.

"Only five spots and other than E8, the four left are all food, they say. We can for sure get the one at H12."

Looking at the situation, I decided what to do and gave my orders to the entire group through Hashimoto and Kanzaki.

"—I will now explain the strategy."

In response, the expressions of the students, including those from Class D, all tensed up at once.

Part 2

PREPARED FOR A confrontation with the allied classes, Class A retrieved the supplies that appeared in the southern G9 area and immediately completed their move to the F9 area. The time was 12:00 PM.

Horikita and the others temporarily stopped to receive a new report from Matsushita.

"It seems a Class C student was just eliminated between E12 and F11. The remaining student appears to be turning back, but... what in the world could this mean?"

Upon receiving the bewildered report from Wang, Horikita and Hirata looked at each other.

"Did they try to retrieve the supplies at F10 without using a VIP? And then Class B ambushed them when they strayed a little from the path?"

"...I don't know. But there's no doubt that Ayanokouji-kun is the one giving the orders. Tell Matsushita-san to immediately use a tactic to find out who the retreating student is."

"Y-Yes!"

Wang received Horikita's instructions and immediately relayed them to the commander via radio.

Not even a minute later, another message came in from Matsushita, who used the tactic, to Wang.

"The retreating student is Nishi-san from Class C and her role is Scout!"

"A Scout... In that case, we can likely rule out the possibility that they were after supplies..."

"Could it be that they used two people as bait to lure out Class B? No, but that would be a rather ineffective way to go about it."

"They've just pointlessly lost a guard. And there's no guarantee the scout will even make it back safely. Their true intentions are still unclear, but for now, let's monitor the movements of both classes from here. While securing a location that's easy to defend in case we're attacked."

Ten minutes later Horikita and the others noticed something was wrong.

It became clear when communication came in immediately from Matsushita to their VIP, Wang.

"Horikita-san! Class C and Class D have apparently started moving north! To be precise, all their GPS signals are moving northwest from H10 toward G9!" Kushida, who was standing right near Horikita, spread out a map and Horikita peered down at it.

"For them to move to G9 at this stage... doesn't that mean there's a chance they're targeting us?"

"...Yes. Well, if they're trying to take someone down, it's only natural they'd target Class A over Class B—"

"A-And there's one more thing to report! Class B, which had been on standby in E12, has also started to move north!"

Both classes started moving five minutes earlier, with what seemed like perfectly coordinated timing.

"No way... Could it be that Class D contacted Class B for this very reason...!?"

"It's possible. They might've proposed a pincer attack to take down Class A."

With Kushida calmly analyzing beside her, Horikita immediately relayed it to her classmates.

"W-w-w-what're we gonna do!? There's no way we can win against three classes!"

"If they are coming for us, staying here just means we'll get caught in a pincer. I think running is an option, don't you? There's a chance they'll run into each other in the meantime."

She was forced to make a decision, even though it wasn't certain that they were targeting Class A.

"—We're moving. Let's fight Class B at E10."

No matter how advantageous their defensive position was, that advantage would be blown away in an instant if they engaged with three classes. She judged that challenging Class B to a fight gave them a higher chance of victory.

Everyone hurriedly shouldered their bags again and immediately began to advance toward E10.

The next GPS update confirmed that Class B entered E11 and the allied classes were about to enter G9. Class A continued toward E10, but ten minutes and two GPS updates later, the situation began to change again.

As a result of the other classes realizing they'd begun to move five minutes earlier, Class B stopped their northward advance and began to retreat back the

way they came, toward E12. Meanwhile, Class C and D stopped moving north and began to move west.

"They must have sensed we were trying for a swift conclusion and pulled back. But I was fully aware they'd notice. We'll proceed to challenge Class B to a fight."

As the words left her mouth, a sickening feeling clung to her. It was because she was enveloped in a sensation of being swept away by a raging current that allowed no resistance. The Class C student sent towards Class B. If they conveyed the message to cooperate and defeat Class A, fully prepared to be eliminated, then the entire development involving all four classes was none other than a scenario orchestrated by Ayanokouji.

Her ideal had been to stand her ground and observe until the very end. And yet, starting with a single raid from Ayanokouji, she allowed him to manipulate the state of the battle with such ease.

"This is Class A's weak point, Horikita-san. I'm sure you were prepared from the start for the risk that others with the shared goal of pulling down the top class would team up."

"...Yes, you're right. For us, from here on out—this is where we show what we're made of."

Horikita acted, believing it would lead them down the path to their own victory.

Part 3

1:00 P.M. THE event updated and revealed zero new supplies. This meant the phase for gathering supplies was completely over. The current locations of each class were Class A at D11, Class B at D12 and the Class C and D alliance at E10. As a result of the repeated attacks and retreats up to that point, the situation progressed to a point where all classes were rapidly closing in on each other. Though they hadn't made contact yet. Receiving a rapid-fire report from the analyst, Class A shouted to inform everyone of the restricted area. A little after 1:05 p.m., the VIP Yukimura received a new message from the commander and urged everyone to halt.

Barely fifty meters away from that exchange.

Class B, who advanced northward, also stopped in their tracks.

"Class A is right in front of us. They're probably a few dozen meters away. Everyone, stay sharp."

Katsuragi took a half step forward and quietly informed his classmates.

"Every single one of you better take down at least one of them before you get taken out. Now that we're this far, who gives a damn how many we beat in that first-day ambush? Any useless deadweight is a candidate for expulsion."

With those words, Ryuuen put intense pressure on them, firing them up and making them advance forward quietly.

One step, two steps. They moved forward, treading on dirt, leaves and small twigs.

"But are you sure about this, Katsuragi? We let one of Class A's VIPs get away..."

Ishizaki spoke up. A short while ago, Ryuuen immediately used tactics to identify the two GPS signals that had unnaturally separated from the main Class A group. Their identities were the escort, Miyake Akito and the VIP, Wang Mei-Yu.

"If three VIPs are taken out, it's a total wipeout. They probably split off to avoid the risk of being annihilated in a massive brawl. For us to send pursuers, we would similarly need a VIP and a guard—a minimum of two people. But in a two-on-two, there's no telling how it'll turn out. Miyake's athletic ability isn't bad, either. On top of that, it's not just Class A nearby; Class C and Class D are also approaching. Acting separately is far too dangerous."

While they wanted to defeat them if they could, Ryuuen judged it too risky to split off a small part of their forces to send after them in this situation. Class B staunchly maintained its stance of protecting the VIP with all its members.

"Something's off..."

At that, Katsuragi's expression tightened.

"Huh? What's off?"

They weren't engaging with the Class A group in front of them. It was taking longer than expected to make contact.

"We should be running into them any time now—this is a frustrating wait."

If they moved in any of the three directions other than south, where they would run into Class B, it wouldn't be difficult to avoid contact. If they fled, they wanted to pursue immediately, but they could only learn the other classes' latest movements every five minutes. They couldn't give chase right away without receiving the new locations.

Class B, which continued to advance slowly and with maximum caution, was informed of the latest positions by the commander five minutes later, but it was then that they learned a troublesome fact.

It was because Class A hadn't moved in any of the four cardinal directions.

"R-Ryuuen-kun... It says... Class A's GPS and our GPS are overlapping...!"

"So they used a tactic here, did they?"

For the next thirty minutes, they would be unable to track Class A. They knew that was a possibility, but it meant a period of extreme disadvantage for the other classes.

Katsuragi immediately gave orders to protect the VIPs from all four sides. This was because they couldn't afford to have their three VIPs taken out under any circumstances. Fortunately, in preparation for such a situation, Katsuragi made them learn several hand signals as a way to issue commands without speaking.

Having them retreat from the inevitable battle ahead was one option, but without their VIPs, they couldn't grasp the other classes' battle situations and if the guards were wiped out, they would eventually be cornered and defeated. In the end, it was most efficient to keep them close. At least, that was how Ryuuen was thinking and acting.

Would they run, or would they attack?

Everyone fell silent, holding their breath, so as to not miss the slightest footstep or any sign of trouble.

The VIP who received the information from the commander took a pre-prepared slip of paper and scribbled on it gently, careful not to tear a hole in it.

Then, they showed it to Ryuuen, who was standing nearby.

'C and D ahead'

It was news that even the allied classes, who'd been approaching in a pincer formation, were now close. If the vanished Class A circled around, the risk of Class B being caught in a pincer attack would increase.

Deciding there was no time to hesitate, Ryuuen made the decision to retreat south for the time being and just as he raised his arm to give the command—

"They're behind us!"

The one who shouted was Isoyama, who was in the rear. Multiple paintballs began to assault Class B from behind.

"They got behind us?! Fall back while returning fire! C and D are coming, hurry!"

Once things had gotten to that point, hand signals were meaningless, so Katsuragi shouted, simultaneously ordering them to fight and retreat. The battle with the enemy that got behind them began.

"No doubt about it! It's Class A! I saw Sudou!"

"H-haha—!"

Hearing her classmate's voice, Ibuki broke into a fierce, frightening smile.

"W-what's with that creepy laugh? You're givin' me the creeps, Ibuki!"

Ishizaki, hiding behind a tree with her, looked at Ibuki, slightly taken aback.

"You know, I honestly didn't give a damn about things like that ambush on Class C at the start."

She ejected the magazine from her submachine gun, confirmed that there were plenty of rounds left and then slammed it back deep into place with a *clack*.

"Because I've finally met the opponent I'm supposed to take down."

"Ooh... pretty ambitious for you. Thinkin' Class A is the biggest enemy, huh?"

"Huh? You think I care about crap like that? I've just been itching for a fight... because I wanted so, so badly to see that look of frustration on that Horikita girl's face!"



She said as she mercilessly fired paintballs from her submachine gun. A wristwatch alarm rang out, indicating she hit someone more than ten meters away.

When the magazine ran empty, she quickly removed it and reloaded a new one. Ibuki still had seven spare magazines she'd been saving up until then. She could shoot more than enough.

"All my pent-up grudges, I'm gonna pay them back right here, right now!"

"O-Oh. Well, I guess it's not a bad thing to be motivated... For now, I'm gonna back up a bit, so don't push yourse—What the...?"

It was inevitable that that place would soon become a danger zone and just as Ishizaki tried to fall back a little, Ibuki grabbed his arm and stopped him.

"You're my support."

"Huh? Give me a break. I've gotta protect Ryuuen-san."

"You don't need to protect a guy like that. More importantly, you're going to be my shield."

"No way in hell!"

"You're holding that big-ass weapon, so just charge in, will you?"

"If I go now, it's like I'm asking them to shoot me!"

"As long as I can take down Horikita, that's all that matters!"

"It's not all that matters!"

During their loud exchange, Class A also noticed the enemy students hiding behind the large tree and fired paintballs at them without mercy. A paintball faintly whizzed past the tip of Ishizaki's hair.

"Whoa, that was close!"

Ibuki glared at Ishizaki, who was breaking out in a cold sweat.

"If we wait here, we'll get taken out eventually, so go, Ishizaki! C'mon! Hurry up!"

"Agh, fine! I guess I've got no choice! Follow me, Ibuki!"

Ishizaki burst out and using his large build for cover, Ibuki stuck close behind him and burst out as well.

Meanwhile, on the other side, were the Class A students who'd used tactics to circle around to the rear. One of them, Sudou, had just taken out his fifth person.

"I'm out of ammo! Let me reload!"

Blessed with great physical ability and having polished his skills in practice to a level his classmates could not match, he was putting on an ace-level performance without holding back.

Yukimura, who was hiding nearby, handed Sudou a fully loaded magazine. As the designated VIP, Yukimura couldn't attack, but providing support didn't violate the rules.

"Class B is down to thirteen! The guy Sudou just took out was probably one of their VIPs!"

Information about eliminated students came in periodically over the radio.

"Oh, for real? That's lucky...! Just two more!"

"Ah, no, wait! It looks like we lost one, too. Mii-chan's out!"

His joy was short-lived; in the blink of an eye, the VIP count was two to two.

"What's the situation with Class C and Class D?"

"Hirata's holding them off now. It seems we anticipated their counter-strategy, just as Horikita read."

"That's Suzune for ya—"

Sudou smiled, overcome with delight, but then he heard multiple sets of footsteps approaching from the front.

"They're closing in! You stay hidden!"

He gave the order to Yukimura, then leaned his upper body out and aimed his gun at the approaching Class B students. Meanwhile, the Class B students, despite noticing Sudou, showed no sign of aiming at him and were all facing a different direction.

He landed a paintball on the abdomen of Nomura, who got the closest, but the remaining few forcefully broke past Sudou's flank.

"I won't let you get away!"

He aimed at their backs and took out one more, but the dense trees blocked the remaining two and he couldn't get a clear shot.

"Tch! I'm leaving this place to you guys!"

Leaving a few students with orders to protect Yukimura, Sudou gave chase to the two.

"There's Satou! Take her out, no matter what!"

Class C, Class D and Class B.

As if their objectives had aligned, all of their guns locked onto Satou.

But the next moment, as they pulled their triggers, Satou's figure vanished in an instant.

"Kya!"

It was by the hands of someone Satou herself had never expected.

"Are you okay?!"

Sudou pulled Satou into his arms, saving her from the predicament of being showered in paintballs.

"Y-Yeah, thank—!"

Before Satou could finish her thanks, even more paintballs grazed past them.

"They're comin' at us with everything they've got. Are they plannin' on using up all their ammo here?!"

Sudou fired back a few warning shots, but knowing he couldn't aim properly while protecting Satou, he quickly took his finger off the trigger.

"Don't you think somethin's weird...?"

"W-Weird?"

"Look at the paintball marks around us. It's obvious way more guns are pointed at us, right? Even though there are a bunch of other allies hidin' around."



He said, looking at Inogashira and Okitani hiding behind the large trees to their left and right a short distance away.

The marks where paintballs had actually hit and burst were visible, but that was only at the beginning; now, concentrated fire was being directed at Sudou and Satou's position.

"Isn't it because you're here, Sudou-kun?"

"...Nah, it's been like this since before I jumped in. In other words, doesn't that mean Class B knew you were the VIP before we even started fightin'?"

"H-How...? Really?"

"Probably... They're ignoring the guards and are weirdly obsessed with taking you down."

Sudou was confident he could handle it well if the target was aimed at him.

But with a strategy that so blatantly targeted only Satou, that became difficult.

That was because even Sudou couldn't fend them all off if the other side was prepared to sacrifice two or three people.

"Maybe they figured out the VIP's identity somehow... and what's worse, maybe everyone's—"

"Can they do something like that? M-Maybe... it got exposed when Ayanokouji-kun came here!?"

"I guess it's true he might've unconsciously protected the VIP, but where were you then?"

"U-Uhm. I was right inside the tent—-I was scared, so I just stayed hidden..."

Hearing her words, Sudou broke out in a cold sweat as a certain possibility came to his mind.

But right then, whether or not the answer was correct meant nothing.

"I... I don't think I can get away. At least you should run, Sudou-kun and protect the other VIPs—"

"If that's what it takes to win, maybe that's what I should do. But I'm not gonna let 'em take you out this easily... We just gotta fight!"

The accuracy of the incoming shots was by no means high.

Sudou surmised that the skill of the unseen enemy guards wasn't great.

He'd leap out, betting it all and take down all the enemies before Satou was shot.

Having made his decision, Sudou leaped out in front of the enemy.

Part 4

FROM THE SURROUNDING clamor, Class C and D soon learned that an intense firefight had begun. At the same time, the commanders reported that Class A likely used a tactic, along with who'd been taken out. Eight from Class B and five from Class A. Perhaps as a result of getting the drop on them from behind, a slight advantage had begun to emerge in that short amount of time.

"Looks like Class A circled around back and engaged Class B."

"Yeah... If we keep advancing now, we can trap Class B between us—"

"But you get it, right, Kanzaki? The orders we got from Ayanokouji were..."

"I understand."

Nodding, Kanzaki immediately ran to the rear. He then began to move out with the members he'd spoken to in advance. After seeing them off, he turned his attention back to the front.

"It's been about five minutes since the shooting started, right? For all that, maybe not as many people have been taken out as I thought."

When he murmured, speaking to Takemoto, who walked beside him, Takemoto also nodded in agreement.

"Doesn't that just mean they're fighting while prioritizing defense?"

"Well then, shall we get going—"

Just as he rose from his crouch, a paintball hit the shoulder of Matoba, who'd been preparing beside Hashimoto.

"Hgh!?"

His watch announced that he was out and Hashimoto, judging it was dangerous to stay there, immediately fled.

"It's Class A! Hirata's here, Hashimoto!"

Matoba, who'd been shot, shouted as he glared in the direction the paintball came from.

"Hirata? Didn't he circle around behind Class B...!"

There, Hashimoto understood that it wasn't their entire class, but that Class A sent only some of their students around back, leaving several behind to deal with the alliance.

"Take us out with a small group? Are they serious?"

At that point, Class A had 16 to 19 guards remaining. Assuming they assigned half of them to Class B, it wasn't realistic for the remaining eight or nine to take on an allied class of about 40 people. The number of paintballs that occasionally flew their way was by no means large.

Even when they shot back, there wasn't an overwhelming retaliatory volley.

"...What's going on...?"

Hashimoto thought they split into two groups, but they might have actually been divided into even smaller units.

The advance had initially begun with the intention of pressing Class A with Class B and the allied classes to drop them to last place. However, Class A's use of tactics shut down the overall GPS and part of Class A circled around behind Class B. Meanwhile, the allied classes continued to advance, figuring it didn't matter if the target they were trapping switched from Class A to Class B, but the ones they were actually facing were from Class A.

Just then, a faint shout could be heard from the direction Kanzaki went, the complete opposite of where Hirata's group was hiding.

"Damn, what the hell... I can't even tell who's fighting where anymore...!"

With the VIP no longer nearby, he had no way of grasping the details of the battlefield. That being the case, he cleared his head for a moment. The only thing Hashimoto could do was to confront Hirata and the other Class A students and win.

But that was difficult. Hashimoto attacked, using his paintballs without hesitation, but they kept changing their positions and he couldn't get a clear shot.

What's more, the paintballs they shot back always grazed just past Hashimoto.

"Not bad, Hirata... You're way more skilled than I thought. There's no hesitation or mercy in your aim."

Hashimoto broke out in a cold sweat, letting slip his frank impression of Hirata, who was hiding up ahead.

He knew from the start that Hirata was good at sports, but his miscalculation lay elsewhere.

The naked killing intent, unbecoming of a mere honor student, was what surprised Hashimoto more than anything.

Even if it meant a mutual takedown, he would absolutely defeat his opponent.

Even that level of intent seemed to be flying toward Hashimoto along with the paintballs.

"—Hah..."

While confronting his rising heart rate, Hashimoto racked his brain for a way out of the situation.

Judging by the back-and-forth so far, Hirata had slightly more momentum, but their skills were evenly matched.

The number of rounds left in his magazine was less than half and it was entirely possible that Hirata had a spare.

Even if he tried to use the terrain to flank him, it wouldn't be easy, given who his opponent was.

"...No matter how you look at it, I'm at a disadvantage, huh."

If that was the case, should he settle for a mutual takedown? No, that conclusion could wait a little longer.

The only area where he could confidently say he had the upper hand was with his words.

It wasn't too late to use them.

Since his position was exposed anyway, there was no problem with raising his voice.

"Never seen you with such a desperate look on your face before! Did getting abandoned by Ayanokouji really piss you off that much?!"

It was a taunt meant to agitate him, thinking it would be a win if it made his aiming hand waver.

The loud voice that echoed through the forest was soon swallowed and silence returned.

"How 'bout it? I could ask Ayanokouji to negotiate pulling you into our class. You're a sharp guy and the girls love you. I bet we could get you a seat at the table, eh?"

He considered psychological warfare to be the key to victory and thoroughly tried to rattle him.

Hashimoto thought that if Hirata responded skillfully, he'd have him right where he wanted him.

However, even as time passed, Hirata still didn't respond.

"Givin' me the silent treatment, huh? You could at least say some—"

Just as he was about to call out again, a sound of rustling through the bushes came from the direction where Hirata was likely hiding.

"Tch...!"

It was Hirata who moved first. But Hashimoto's reaction wasn't delayed. Conscious of their remaining ammunition, they read each other's lines of fire. Firing using tree trunks for cover, sliding with their bodies half-turned, a series of short feints canceled out each other's aim. The bullets flew in high, thin arcs.



"Whoa, that was close!"

Just after Hashimoto pulled his face back behind the tree, the paintball hit the trunk and splattered spectacularly.

The rise in tension was extraordinary, as a direct hit meant instant elimination.

The series of exchanges at a relatively close range was a rapid succession of impacts. Bullets grazed the tree bark and pulverized the fallen leaves on the ground. Hashimoto spun his body at a sharp angle, trying to get to Hirata's flank, but Hirata had read his move. Lowering his stance, a single shot returned from the hip grazed Hashimoto's shoulder, leaving a stain.

"Kuh...!"

A cry of anguish, not of pain. The trivial mistake born from losing the exchange of wits sent a chill down his spine.

"And I don't have time to be wasting on one guy..."

He held his weapon vertically and tried to recall the times he pulled the trigger during the fight, wondering how many rounds he had left.

He had certainly fired more than forty shots, leaving only a few at best.

Should he change the magazine early, or should he use up every last shot?

His opponent showed no sign of reloading either and likely had a similar number of rounds left.

Both were close to emptying their magazines, hinting at the need to reload. The existence of spare magazines dulled the choice between offense and defense. To retreat meant defeat. To push through meant victory. But half the battle was a dialogue of the mind—in other words, psychological warfare. Every piece of information, from each other's breathing and the trembling of their fingers to their habits of shifting weight on the soles of their shoes, was crucial. For a moment, Hashimoto hid in the shade of a tree before trying a ploy in a low voice.

"Ayanokouji was sayin' he felt bad about what he did to you, Hirata."

As his voice broke the forest's silence like a rolling pebble, Hirata's gaze faltered for just an instant at those words.

Betting on that slight mental disturbance, Hashimoto leaped out. He squeezed the trigger with all his might.

He certainly caught Hirata by surprise. But—although two bullets flew out, they missed and unluckily, a third failed to emerge. He was out of ammo.

Hirata immediately composed himself for a counterattack and pulled the trigger in return.

Near Hashimoto's ear, *bang*!, paint splattered and color spread across the edge of his goggle's field of view.

His vision was obstructed. That was a huge disadvantage.

He dove back behind the tree and immediately kicked off the ground.

His vision reduced to about thirty percent, Hashimoto immediately chose to create distance. He had to move quickly between the trees and regroup. Hirata could've shot Hashimoto in the back, but he too ran out of ammo at that exact moment. He pursued him, determined not to let him escape. They changed locations, once again bringing themselves to a close-range standoff.

It was a tense situation where the match would be decided in an instant if either of them showed the slightest opening.

With no time to worry about appearances, Hashimoto slid his goggles onto his forehead, removed the assault rifle's magazine and immediately swapped it with his spare.

He then desperately rubbed the stained goggles with his fingertips to get the paint off, but seeing no significant improvement, he had no choice but to slide them back over his eyes.

"So this is what they call a desperate situation...!"

Hashimoto still had fifty rounds left. But when they ran out, it would be over.

On the other hand, Hashimoto didn't know how many rounds Hirata had.

Of course, the same was true for Hirata. He didn't know how many rounds his opponent had.

There was even a possibility that he had no spare magazine and had just fired his last shot.

In that case, should he risk it and close the distance before Hirata could escape?

In a battle of attrition, mental fatigue would set in before physical exhaustion. Should he aim for a quick, decisive battle, or try to bait a mistake from his opponent in a war of attrition? Their breaths overlapped as the pale afternoon light streamed into the forest.

Who would be the first to make a fatal misstep?

Breathing heavily, Hashimoto peeked the muzzle of his gun just slightly from behind the tree.

Sweat dripped from his chin. He saw Hirata's shadow move at the edge of his vision.

It was now or never.

Hashimoto took aim and leaped out at once, closing the distance to Hirata.

Immediately after, a dual gunshot rang out.

The paintballs whizzed past each other and a sound like the air itself was splitting echoed through the forest.

"...!"

Hashimoto felt a hot sensation on his chest. Lowering his gaze, he saw the paint that had hit him slowly spreading.

Hirata's shot, fired at almost the same time, had been slightly faster.

The elimination tone sounded.

It should have been a lifeless electronic sound, but strangely, it sent a chill deep into his body.

"Damn it—!"

The shock sent Hashimoto to one knee.

His breathing was ragged and his throat was parched as if it were on fire.

The match was decided—he understood that logically, but his heart hadn't accepted the end.

"...That was some serious spirit, Hirata. This match is my loss."

He praised Hirata in a hoarse voice.

It was a defeat that came after fighting with all his might.

Hirata didn't answer, he simply lowered his gun slowly.

The movement stopped after a brief pause.

His gaze, fixed on the kneeling Hashimoto, didn't move.

The muzzle of the gun slowly rose once more.

"Hey... Hirata...?"

Hashimoto's breath caught as he looked into Hirata's eyes.

He could see a finger being placed on the trigger.

Hashimoto was already out and the match had been completely decided.

If he were to add a follow-up attack, a heavy penalty awaited Class A.

"If this is a joke, I'm not laughing."

The muzzle was pressed against his forehead. It was truly point-blank range.

A position from which he might be seriously injured if the trigger were pulled.

He might get shot.

Just as that impossible delusion crossed his mind, the trigger—was squeezed partway and then Hirata's finger stopped moving.

Silence fell.

The wind passed through the forest. The smell of paint mixed with the dampness of the earth.

Hirata said nothing, lowered the gun and turned his back.

The students of Class A and Class C were still fighting in a different area and he had to go support them.

In the ears of Hashimoto who was left behind, an echo lingered as if he could hear the unsqueezed trigger and a gunshot.

"Guess I pushed the honor student a little too far—"

It was a sharp fear, no different from actually having been shot a second time.

Part 5

AS THE REMAINING time drew near, the state of the battle in various locations also seemed to be finally reaching its climax.

"The tactic's effect has worn off and it seems Class A's current locations were all displayed at once. As of now, there are a total of 43 students remaining. As for the breakdown by class—"

Shiraishi calmly explained the situation.

"Just as you said, Ayanokouji-kun, it's turned into quite a chaotic battle, hasn't it?"

"Appoint a commander, gather supplies, keep your distance, read the enemy's movements and avoid engagement. Then, devise a strategy in preparation for the final decisive battle. They can carry things out reasonably well up to this point, but once the firefight actually starts, anyone would lose their ability to think calmly. What's more, without their VIP nearby, they can't even tell their own precise location, let alone the enemy's. Should they go right or left, forward or back? While they're wandering, they run into other classes, creating a chain of eliminations. The ones fighting right now aren't trained soldiers or even people who have played this survival game over and over. They're just a bunch of high school students."

The important thing was to throw the field into intense chaos. To sow discord and reduce their numbers.

Once a little more time passed, the numbers would decrease further. And at that time, the action to take was already decided: have the VIP escape. They had no choice but to avoid total annihilation and switch to running until time ran out.

It was the same for Horikita and Ryuuen.

"It appears Kanzaki-kun and the two Class D VIPs have now arrived at G11. The suspension of the global GPS will be lifted shortly. Will the pursuers move immediately to target the three of them after this?"

"Fifty-fifty. The battlefield has already expanded and it's not certain if the VIPs who've noticed will be able to give information to their guards. Either way, if there's any suspicious movement, we'll use our tactics to get them away immediately. Just as planned."

"Understood."

As I nodded, Shiraishi took the radio and told Shimazaki to prepare to use the individual GPS shutdown tactic. The targets weren't the Class C VIP, but the two Class D VIPs who were currently escaping. There was no restriction that a tactic had to be used on one's own class, so as long as it wasn't a problem in and of itself, no issues would arise from using it on anyone from any class. However, only the commander of the class that executed the tactic would know their current location, so that point alone required caution.

What was important was not letting anyone figure out where the escaped Class D VIPs were.

"Just now, another one from Class A, Yukimura-kun—the second VIP—was eliminated. That means the only one left is Satou-san, correct?"

"That's right."

"I imagine Class A is surprised right about now. Wondering why their three VIPs were found out and are being so persistently targeted. And by all three classes, no less."

The one big mistake Class A made before the final day.

It was the evening of the third day, when I showed up at Horikita and the others' campsite.

At the time, I arrived while the GPS suspension was still active and I didn't attack right away.

I attacked only after carefully checking the positions of my former classmates.

The objective wasn't to eliminate as many people as possible, but to find out who the VIPs were.

Having received an unexpected attack, the Class A students' thoughts would've been split into two main camps: 'defeat the intruder' and 'protect the VIP'.

Defeat if the VIPs were all eliminated and the maneuvers to protect them. It was an action that'd become ingrained in them over several days of having it drilled into their heads. The guards immediately ran to protect the three.

Those three were Wang Mei-Yu, Satou Maya and Teruhiko Yukimura.

"Didn't you ever suspect it might have been a fake?"

"If they could have predicted the attack beforehand, it could’ve been a feint. But the attack came when they thought the danger was over for the day. The probability of it being an act is low."

And so, I decided to give the information I'd obtained to Class B this morning as well.

That was because it would be easier for them to fight if they knew who the VIPs were.

If they chose not to believe the information, there would be no negative repercussions, so it was information they had nothing to lose by receiving.

Of course, if even a small number of students approached Class B carelessly, they would be shot.

In fact, the student I sent was shot and eliminated, but that was no problem.

Even after being eliminated, as long as it wasn't during a battle, some conversation was possible.

That would be effective in defeating Class A and that information would also act as the catalyst to get Class B to attack Class A.

"So, they were skillfully outplayed by you alone, Ayanokouji-kun."

"I think Class A's movements weren't bad, considering they knew they were a target. Now, all that's left is to take out the remaining Class B students and this special exam will be over."

Even if capable students like Sudou or Hirata remained, they couldn't continue to operate if the VIP was defeated.

"...Excuse me, there's a message from Shimazaki-kun."

Shiraishi's expression stiffened slightly as she listened to the radio. She must have received some bad news.

"It seems Class B is putting on a lot of pressure in some combat zones. As a result, the number of eliminations from our allied classes is rapidly increasing. It appears there's a fierce battle going on in F11."

I wanted to leave things to them to some extent, but it seemed it would be better if I made a move.

"Only in the event that Class A is wiped out first, come and see me after three o'clock if you can make contact."

"Understood. What will you do now, Ayanokouji-kun?"

"Adjustments."

Leaving Shiraishi with Yamamura, I started to slowly make my way to F11.

Epilogue:
Show Me What You've Got

THE WATCH, INDICATING F11 to E11, struck 3:00 p.m. and Class A, having lost three VIPs, was forced out entirely and eliminated.

Just as I slowly removed my finger from the trigger, Yamamura and Shiraishi, along with Kanzaki and the two VIPs from Class D, appeared before me as I quietly surveyed our surroundings. There were five of them in total.

"Were the remaining guards taken out?"

"Yes. We were attacked by two Class B students while we were running away... According to Ichinose-san, it seems those two had their personal GPS signals turned off, so they completely caught us by surprise. We used the tactic you gave us permission to use beforehand and escaped and thanks to you buying us time, we were saved."

Shiraishi reported the situation, though she was still breathing heavily.

"Tell me the details."

Yamamura, who was similarly out of breath, seemed unable to speak yet, so Kanzaki spread out a map instead.

"The ones left in Class B are Ryuuen and Ibuki, as well as Yamashita and Yoshimoto. Their location is D11—"

"Then there are three left. I just took down Yoshimoto there a moment ago."

It seemed he hadn't received the latest information from the commander yet.

"...It seems several signals disappeared before we got here, but was that all you, Ayanokouji-kun?"

"I cleaned up the area within my line of sight to a certain extent. But it seems the two troublesome ones are still left."

The ones remaining from Class C were me and the VIPs, Shiraishi Asuka and Yamamura Miki. From Class D were the guard Kanzaki and the VIPs Beppu and Himeno. In terms of points, Class B and Class C had 102 points, while Class D had 201 points.

If the exam ended now, first place would be secured and second and third place would go to a sudden death match, huh.

"It seems there's no doubt that Class B's VIP is Yamashita-san. I just got a message from Shimazaki-kun."

"I figured. There's no merit whatsoever in making Ibuki the VIP."

Class A taking last place was already set, so there was no risk of expulsion, but the rankings for third place and above weren't decided.

The key wasn't the number of VIPs, but the number of guards.

With one hour remaining, if even one guard from any class survived, they could unilaterally decide the outcome.

Should I leave Beppu here, who still had stamina to spare, or should I leave Himeno?

"What do you suppose their next move will be?"

"No matter how small the playable area has become, they'll likely stick together. As for their tactics, there's a possibility they still have one personal GPS jammer left, but with only one, they can't track our movements without a VIP, so it's not a huge problem. By the way, how much ammo do you two have?"

"Um, I have a full load. I... haven't fired any shots... I also have two magazines... I'm sorry..."

"On the contrary, I've used up pretty much everything. Whatever's left in here, maybe 10 or 20 rounds, that's all I've got."

"Then take this."

I handed Kanzaki the two magazines I had prepared as spares.

"I appreciate it, but doesn't this break the rules—?"

"It's not robbery or anything. It's just a transfer."

"But what about you? Do you have enough ammo?"

"I have 22 rounds left. That should be enough."

"Then I can't accept this. You should be able to use it more effectively than me."

"Don't worry. The important thing is for the guards to protect the VIPs and escape until the very end. Besides, sometimes it's more convenient not to be carrying an excessive amount."

It wouldn't be an even match if I had 100 or 200 rounds, after all.

Fighting in such a tense situation was the only way to enjoy it when the outcome was uncertain.

Now that third place or higher was guaranteed, I could cast aside any unnecessary thoughts and indulge in the survival game.

Ryuuen would probably rather take down Shiraishi, Beppu and Himeno rather than confront me directly.

But as time passed, the area would shrink further, forcing a confrontation.

"What... are you going to do?"

"Ryuuen won't be satisfied with the exam ending like this. If he doesn't fight, he's guaranteed either second or third place, but if he fights and wins, he has a chance to seize first."

Five minutes passed and the GPS updated.

The reports that came in from both Shimazaki and Ichinose stated that all the changes on the GPS were minor.

They maintained their state of standing still in roughly the same location without using any tactics.

"Sorry, but Beppu, could you come with me for a bit?"

"What are you going to do...?"

"I'm not too keen on this stalemate leading to a sudden death match. If there's no movement in the next ten minutes, I'm thinking of making a move ourselves."

I had Yamamura and Shiraishi, as well as Kanzaki and Himeno, stand by for the moment. I instructed them to move immediately if anything changed on the GPS, then walked forward with Beppu.

It was certain they were checking the GPS data from when I charged into Class A alone on the evening or morning of the third day to identify individuals, so word of my movement would undoubtedly reach them.

Ryuuen wasn't stupid enough to be unable to perceive our movements and our objective.

Part 1

AT 3:20 P.M., with forty minutes left until the end of the exam, I made my way to the center of E11, asking Beppu for the enemy's position every step of the way.

"...They're coming. All three of them, they're really close now, right in front of us...! What if Ryuuen and Ibuki split up...? What should I do?"

"That's unlikely. Yamashita isn't very athletic and she's probably nearing her limit. She can't keep up with your pace as a guy and it wouldn't be easy for them to track you with a five-minute delay taken into account."

"I hope you're right... To be honest, I'm at my absolute limit..."

He gave a wry smile, his legs screaming after having walked and run around the deserted island for nearly four days.

"In that case, all you can do is lie low and pray they don't find you."

"Yeah, I'd rather not do that..."

Considering the remaining time, he would almost certainly be found and taken out.

"You're in there, aren't you! Ayanokouji! You should be grateful I came all this way for a fight!"

From ahead, Ibuki's shout reached me.

"What's with her, is she a tsundere or something...? Well, I'm outta here, then?"

After making his light-hearted jab, Beppu raised a hand and quietly departed.

I tore my gaze from his retreating figure and moved forward, one step at a time.

With the eliminated students having withdrawn, the deserted island was now sparsely populated. The surrounding sounds were clearer than ever.

It’d been a survival game where, until now, everyone fired without question upon seeing an enemy.

But as I walked onward, both Ryuuen and Ibuki emerged from between the trees.

Faintly behind them, I could also see Yamashita.

"Hah, we've been playing this exam seriously, all trial and error, but in the end, it's just a flashy shootout with no brains involved that wears everyone down. It's no wonder an idiot like Ibuki, who can at least move, is still standing, right?"

"Sounds like you were pretty successful. How many people did you take out?"

"I don't remember how many I beat. Besides, because those three Class A VIPs got eliminated, I missed my chance to take down Horikita!"

She seemed frustrated about that, her voice laced with anger.

"I don't like it, but it's thanks to the information you sent. A convergence of interests, I suppose?"

Judging by the deadlocked results, Class A might have been the one left standing if I hadn't passed on the information.

"It would be a problem for the other three classes if Class A didn't lose. Right?"

"Yeah. But I'd like to hand you a loss just as much. Time's running out. Let's settle this here and now and decide our ranks."

His low voice echoed from straight ahead. As Yamashita fell back, both of them disappeared between the trees.

Of course, they wouldn't think of a two-on-one as cowardly.

If it were a normal fight, they would’ve realized they had no chance of winning and wouldn't have taken the bait.

But this time, the situation was different. They could defeat me just by hitting me with a paintball.

Without bothering to take cover, I advanced to see what my opponents would do.

I couldn't be careless at a distance of less than ten meters, but there were still more than twenty meters between us. It wasn't too late to react after seeing the muzzle of a gun.

Or rather, you could say it was because I didn't have enough ammo left for a long-range firefight.

Ammunition unilaterally favors the side that has more of it. But an advantage doesn't necessarily guarantee victory. I had about twenty rounds left. All of my actions needed to be structured by calculation. Without taking a deep breath, I

calmly processed the variables before me: distance, angle of cover, Ibuki's habits, Ryuuen's line of fire.

"Die, Ayanokouji!"

Ibuki, who went out of her way to shout, reminded me of Ishizaki, who I fought on the rooftop.

Immediately after, a submachine gun poked out and fired off a somewhat random spray of bullets.

That wasn't meant to take me down, but to serve as bait—to make me take cover, cutting off my sight and hearing so I wouldn't know Ryuuen's position. Submachine guns have little ammunition.

The moment she fired off all thirty rounds, I kicked off the ground and closed the distance to Ibuki.

Seeing this, Ibuki spun around and slipped low between the trees.

I dropped my stance and fired a short burst. The trajectory wavered slightly, shaving off one leaf, then another and grazed Ibuki's shoulder, but since the paintball didn't burst, her wristwatch didn't signal a hit. Ibuki glared at me, her teeth bared in a grimace that resembled a smile.

Then she hid securely behind a tree and began to reload. Since I didn't know Ryuuen's current location, it was difficult to flank her to close the distance.

The faint sound of scraping plastic reached me. Taking that as my cue, I moved a few steps to the side. By changing my position, I altered the line of fire and peeked through the trees to assess the situation.

Deep among the trees, Ibuki's shadow moved slightly.

The moment I confirmed a gun muzzle peeking out in the corner of my vision, I reflexively dropped my body low.

The sound of a paintball slicing through the air rushed past, practically grazing my ear, before it splattered against the bark of a tree behind me.

Before I could even confirm the miss, Ryuuen was already moving to a new position. I wanted to follow him with my eyes, but Ibuki, having finished reloading, had started moving again, so I broke my line of sight.

"She's fast, as expected."

The petite Ibuki moved between the trees, running like a small animal. Moreover, she seemed accustomed to shooting with some accuracy while running. Bullets flew sporadically from her lightweight submachine gun, striking the large tree that was protecting me.

Wary of her getting behind me, I took a few steps back and changed my position as well.

Faster than the eye could follow, a branch swayed and leaves danced.

Predicting her line of movement, I fired two bursts.

The bullets struck the trunk and wood chips flew.

It wasn't a direct hit, but it was enough to stop Ibuki's advance for just a moment.

"Where are you even aiming? You think you're gonna hit me with a shot that pathetic? You're a lousy shot."

Ibuki's voice echoed between the trees.

It was a provocation. But I didn't answer, just regulated my breathing.

Ibuki showed her face again.

There was even a smile on her face. Was it confidence, or perhaps overconfidence?

But as there was no hesitation in her movements, their straightforward predictability remained unchanged.

The position of her hips the moment she jumped out, the height of her gaze, everything was consistent.

And then, at that moment, Ryuuen moved again, scattering paintballs in my direction.

In a situation where one hit meant it was over, my attention was unwillingly diverted and I focused on evasion.

Then I pulled the trigger three times toward Ryuuen as a warning, forcing him to back down. I had only taken my eyes off her for two or three seconds before turning my body and gaze toward the spot where I thought Ibuki had last hidden.

"Gotcha—!"

The shout came from two trees over from where I had set my sights.

Thinking I hadn't noticed she moved, she boldly revealed herself and took aim at me.

"Wha—!?"

It was true that I was looking at the place where Ibuki had hidden just a few seconds before. My body was facing that direction, too, but there was one thing

that wasn't: the muzzle of the weapon held firmly in my hand. The muzzle alone was pointed toward Ibuki, who just jumped out, seeing her chance to win.

I confirmed the feel of my finger on the trigger and pulled.

The bullet's trajectory cut through the air, flying in a straight line.

Ibuki reflexively twisted her body, but she couldn't completely dodge it.

A paintball hit her right thigh and burst. The judging tone echoed through the forest a moment later.

Ibuki’s eyes widened in surprise and she collapsed onto the ground. The electronic sound repeated.

"Agh, dammit! So this is how it ends!? This is so fucking annoying!! I told you I didn't want to do this!"

I had no time to listen to Ibuki's bitter complaints as the wind stirred behind me. I immediately turned and pulled the trigger on Ryuuen, who was aiming at me. But the gun didn't fire. Meanwhile, Ryuuen had fired while moving his body, so his shot barely missed my shoulder and failed to hit.

"Out of ammo here—"

With my weapon in one hand, I broke into a run, heading south.

He looked calm at a glance, but in truth, he pursued me without hesitation, like a beast about to pounce.

That was the price for using up too much ammo on the small stuff.

Right as I finished off Ibuki, the magazine was clearly and completely empty.

Not a single paintball remained in my assault rifle.

I bluffed by aiming behind me, but Ryuuen continued to advance without flinching at all.

A determined pursuit, shouldering the risk of his own defeat.

My watch showed that the area had switched to E12.

But I had no time to look closely at my watch.

As straight and as short as possible, but the deep forest would not let me escape so easily.

To the right, to the left, sometimes from underfoot.

Nature attacked, preventing me from running at full speed.

A paintball came flying from behind.

Unable to worry about appearances any longer, I threw the cumbersome weapon in my right hand onto the ground.

What awaited me beyond the forest was, of course, a sprawling sandy beach.

There was no cover at all.

I stopped after running about twenty meters across the sand.

"I surrender."

I raised both my hands and said so to Ryuuen, who aimed his weapon at me from behind.

"So even you can't dodge every bullet here, can you?"

A calmer voice than I'd expected came from behind me, though he was out of breath.

"Impossible. There's no way I can dodge them all."

If it'd been a concrete surface where my feet wouldn't get stuck in the sand, could I have put up a bit more of a fight? No, that was probably impossible.

If my opponent only had one or two shots left, it would've been a different story, but that wasn't the case.

That slim possibility had just vanished with the *clack* of a magazine being replaced.

"Gotta take every precaution when I'm up against you, Ayanokouji, right?"

"—Maybe. But why did you decide to fight me? It seemed like Ibuki was against it."

"Even in a 2-v-1, there's no guarantee we'd win a shootout against you. She probably thought she had a better chance of winning if she took an all-or-nothing shot at the VIP."

With my hands still in the air, I moved only my neck to look behind me.

"And you thought differently?"

"Nah. If it were just about winning, I'd have thought that was the better move, too. But settling things by running away on a rare occasion like this? That ain't any fun at all. A far cry from victory."

Ryuuen had racked up loss after loss until now; perhaps his obsession with victory had led to this 2-v-1.

"I understand your reason. But if that's the case, why haven't you shot me now that you've finished reloading? If the victory you desire is to defeat me,

you're one step away from achieving it. All you have to do is put some force into your fingertip and pull the trigger and it'll all be over."

Without even a one percent shred of a lie, that decision would get me eliminated.

But the reason he didn't was likely because he wanted a certain victory.

Even though he already won, he couldn't believe he could actually win.

"Hah—you've got a point. I've gotten pissed off watching scenes like this in movies and shows myself. Like, 'If you've got time to talk, just shoot already.'"

"Correct. While we're standing here like this, Yamashita might be getting targeted by one of our guards."

"Maybe. But there are things you only understand when you're in a situation like this yourself."

Ryuuen was laughing, but he hadn't let his guard down in the slightest.

He wasn't getting too comfortable with his overwhelming advantage.

"I just wanna know, is this really you surrendering? How is the one existence I thought I couldn't beat going to escape this predicament? Or do you even think you *can* escape? If you do, I wanna see it. Even if it means risking my own defeat."



After taking a breath, Ryuuen took a single half-step back from me without changing his posture at all.

"No matter who you are, there's no way you can dodge every single bullet I fire, right?"

"I already told you it's impossible. The muzzle velocity of these paint guns is about 90 m/s. Meanwhile, the average human reaction time is 0.2 to 0.3 seconds. If we were about 20 meters apart, there'd be some leeway, but at this distance, it's hopeless. Even if I could instinctively dodge a few shots, it's absolutely impossible to keep dodging them all until the magazine is empty."

I glanced around lightly and stated the objective situation.

"If there were no rules, I might have the option of taking that slim chance to dodge, close the distance and disarm you—but taking a weapon is obviously prohibited. Or if I had a handgun, I could've at least fought back, but anyone carrying a handgun is required to wear a holster visibly on their leg, so it's impossible to conceal one. With both overpowering you and fighting back sealed off, the only thing I can do now is keep dodging."

Ryuuen glanced at my feet to double-check.

Of course, I didn't have a handgun.

"Yeah, that's right. No matter how you look at it, you're cornered."

"You've cornered me this perfectly and you're still telling me to show you a way out?"

"I'd like to see it, but—if you can't, you can't. I'll take you down and go hunt the remaining VIP and guards. You're betting everything on your last remaining guard, huh?"

Readjusting his firm grip on the gun, Ryuuen lowered his tone of voice a notch.

Considering the time remaining, he would have to finish me off soon and re-enter the forest.

"Bet everything on the last guard... That's not a bad suggestion."

"The ones left are Kanzaki and Yamamura? Sorry, but I ain't got any intention of losing to small fry."

"Is that so? I'd say that depends on the conditions."

Sensing something ominous in my words, Ryuuen furrowed his brow.

"Keep walking forward a few more meters. Right, stop there."

Ryuuen made me walk, then stomped his foot on the sandy spot where I had just been standing.

"Guess there's no way you pulled a trick like luring me here to a spot where you'd buried a weapon, huh."

It seemed he considered the less than one percent possibility and wanted to eliminate it.

"The idea of being lured isn't a bad line of thought. After I ran out of ammo, I threw down my weapon and ran away from you, but can you really say I was just running away?"

"...Huh?"

"Doesn't it feel a little strange—that I fled frantically, got lost, left the forest and ran onto this beach? The area we can move through is already limited, but there's no way I haven't memorized the map. If I were going to run anyway, it would’ve been a hundred times better to keep running in circles inside the forest. There's no merit to fleeing to a beach like this with no cover whatsoever, where the sand trips you up so you can't run properly and you can't even dodge."

"...'Cause the forest has all the damn cover you could want. But still, I don't get it. Why would you lure me here, to a place that only gives me the advantage?"

"It's a matter of perspective. Having no cover leaves you defenseless, but at the same time, it leaves your opponent defenseless too. It's an environment where even a poor shot can hit an enemy with a paintball if they pull the trigger up close."

Ryuuen's brow furrowed even more.

After all, it was a simple fact that while it was advantageous to Ryuuen, it wasn't to me.

"And the forest is too quiet. But here, you can clearly hear the sound of the wind and waves. The risk of making unnecessary noise by stepping on a twig is low. It's the perfect place to sneak up from behind."

"From behind...?"

Ryuuen couldn't carelessly look away from me, knowing I was not to be underestimated.

I continued to throw words at Ryuuen, who must have been starting to feel a chill down his spine.

"You were chasing me. But at the same time, I was giving orders to my remaining guard. I told them that once it was confirmed to be one-on-one, I would lure Ryuuen to this spot, so they should approach from behind and finish him off—"

"And you think I wouldn't notice?"

"Could you really? You focused completely on chasing me. It was a pursuit that could be called obsessive. But as a result, it's hard to say your awareness of what was behind you was perfect. Are you not aware of the reality of your situation, that you have a gun pointed at you, as if someone is aiming from a few meters behind you right now?"

"Don't make me laugh. That's a bluff."

"You think you'd definitely know if someone approached? But one of my remaining guards is Yamamura. She's skilled at erasing her presence, she's lightweight and nimble. She doesn't have great athletic ability, but she's one of the most suitable people for sneaking up quietly."

Amidst the quiet, repeating sound of the waves, Ryuuen strained his ears.

But it would be difficult to pick up the breathing of an opponent who was standing still.

"If Yamamura is behind me... then why haven't you had her shoot?"

"Same as you. You wanted to get all the answers, didn't you?"

"Kuku... This is what makes it so damn interesting. I thought I'd cornered you into a situation where I was under absolutely no threat, but you've made me consider the 'what if.' Let's say, just for argument's sake, that Yamamura is behind me. What would you do if I turned around and counterattacked before she could fire? Yamamura would be out and I'd be sure to shoot you down before you could pick up her weapon."

"That might happen, or it might not. If you're curious, you can always test it."

I could tell that Ryuuen, standing before me, took a sharp breath.

Unlike before, he was becoming very wary of his unseen back.

If Yamamura was standing behind him—

As the last guard, that would mean game over.

He thought. Was he really being followed without noticing?

No, that couldn't be, he thought, yet doubt remained as to whether he'd been paying attention to his back.

The important thing wasn’t whether she was there or not.

It was that he had to act under the assumption that she was.

He had to turn around quickly and land a paintball on Yamamura before she could shoot.

Even if he could manage that without difficulty, if by some chance a shot was fired before Yamamura was ruled out, Ryuuen would have to dodge that paintball at all costs. That wouldn’t be easy.

Then again, trying to take me out first was nonsense. He'd just get shot by Yamamura in the meantime and it would be over.

I could read Ryuuen's thoughts as if they were my own.

He couldn’t ignore what was behind him.

Above all, since I didn't have a gun, his only option was to dodge.

In that case, there was no harm in glancing behind for a moment.

If no one was there, he just had to return his gaze and posture to normal in less than a second.

Even if I tried to run, I wouldn't get far on this wide beach, as my footing would be poor.

Just after he let out a faint breath—

He twisted his body, turning around with the muzzle of his gun.

Ryuuen's field of vision. The forest visible in the distance and the deserted beach.

There was no one behind him.

A moment of relief.

All that was left was to turn back toward me and shoot the one without a weapon to secure his victory.

But faster than his gaze could return, I put a great deal of strength into my right hand.

It was true that I held no weapon.

Nor did I have any means of escape.

However—I did have the means to fight.

I, too, twisted my body around toward Ryuuen.

Convinced of his victory, Ryuuen turned back to me and pulled the finger that was already on the trigger.

I could not dodge all the bullets that would fly out, but that wasn’t a problem.

Between the index finger and thumb of my right hand.

A single, damaged paintball was wedged there.

With all my might, I threw it at Ryuuen, like a pitcher throwing into a mitt.

At the same time my abdomen was stained, Ryuuen's abdomen was stained the same color.

"Wh—!?"

Only the faint hum of the motor that fired the pellet remained.

Almost simultaneously, our watches beeped, announcing we were out and sealing both our defeats.

This paintball was fundamentally the same as the ones loaded in the magazine, but with one key difference. Normally, it wouldn't break easily even if a person hit their target by throwing it.

Repeated trial and error.

How much force was needed to break it on impact?

How hard of a surface did it need to hit to break?

What was the most efficient method?

How damaged did the membrane preventing the paintball from bursting need to be for it to rupture?

It was something I spent time preparing over the past three days, repeating trials to create the perfect amount of damage so that it wouldn't break.

"You... threw it...!?"

"There's nothing in the rules against it. It's just that using a weapon is more reliable and convenient, so it's something nobody needs to do."

Ryuuen glared at the obnoxiously loud alarm on his watch and slammed his weapon onto the ground.

"Did you drag this out just to show off some tricky little stunt? What if I'd pulled the trigger without hesitating? You wouldn't have had any time for a counterattack like this."

"The moment I lured you to the beach, your overwhelming advantage was guaranteed. I predicted with high probability that you wouldn't shoot me right away. Besides, I had my own circumstances to consider. While it's true I wanted

to purely enjoy the match, ultimately, I was fine with losing here. Because I'd already achieved my goal."

"...Your goal?"

"I'll make it official here. I, Class D and Ichinose have joined forces. I can't say how far this alliance will go or to what extent, but we are united in aiming for the top. But even if you call it an alliance, the other students, especially those in Class C, wouldn't just accept it. That's why my top priority was to drive them into a situation where they had no choice but to form one."

"So that's what this was about. In other words, the reason my surprise attack worked was—"

"Yes. The time of highest risk in this special exam is when the classes are close to each other. Barring the final phase, the starting point is the most dangerous. Everyone rushes to move away from the other classes. They communicate constantly with their commander via GPS to confirm they're putting distance between them. You wouldn't have thought to use your strategy from the get-go if we quickly moved away, either."

But in reality, as soon as Class C confirmed the other classes moved away, they stopped in their tracks.

"By making it seem like we shifted our focus to teaching how to use the weapons first and formulating a strategy, I created an environment that was easy for a surprise attack."

"So you left your classmates defenseless and let them take the hit?"

"That's right. Unfortunately for you, winning a shootout wasn't my first priority. I just wanted to create a situation where Class C would have no choice but to rely on Class D, whether they liked it or not."

Even Hashimoto and Morishita, who were relatively well-informed, were highly skeptical of the alliance.

And for good reason. They felt there were more disadvantages than advantages to teaming up with Class D, who’d so far shown few notable achievements. Even if you simply said you’d form an alliance, it wasn't something they could easily accept.

However, if they were cornered, it was a different story. If they couldn't find a way to survive the special exam without Class D's help, it was a different story. If a path to second or third place opened up on the road to rock bottom, it was a different story.

And so, the Class C students came to plead for Class D's cooperation on their own.

"Of course, we probably could have forced an alliance even without the surprise attack. But what do you think would've happened if an unscathed Class C and Class D had joined hands? Even someone as bold as you would find it reckless to challenge nearly eighty opponents. That's why you can't easily make a move even against a moderately weakened Class C and D alliance. On the other hand, Class A would feel similarly. They'd think that at this rate, it would become a muddy battle between Class A and Class B for last place."

Ryuuen, too, spread out the map in his mind, tracing what he would've done.

"In that case, this thought naturally arises: 'Perhaps we could join forces with Class B just for this special exam, crush the lower classes first and then settle things between us.'"

Do what the opponent did to get back on even footing.

Of course, it wouldn't be easy. They might not be able to build enough mutual trust to act as a completely unified front like Classes C and D. However, there was a possibility they could build a cooperative relationship strong enough to avoid direct conflict and pincer the C-D alliance.

"I never would've thought you'd take a surprise attack on purpose... So you're saying I shouldn't have done it?"

"It was a matter of sooner or later. The reason I had you attack the waiting Class C on the second day was also because I wanted to wear down our forces a little more. There were any number of ways to break my allies' spirits."

That defeat on the second day was the clincher.

Realizing they had no other choice, the Class C students personally requested an alliance with Class D.

"In the end, that idiot Ibuki was the most right, huh. This is the pathetic result of being too damn fixated on you."

A declaration of defeat. But it was somehow different from the pathetic figure he'd cut in the classroom last time.

"I've seen your process of using any environment to win. In that case, from here on out, I'm not gonna show you any mercy in the truest sense."

"So you've been holding back on me until now? How very kind of you."

Ryuuen slowly picked up his weapon, averted his gaze from me and stared out at the sea.

Then, without responding to my words, he started walking down the beach. After watching him go, I turned back once to retrieve the weapon I intentionally dropped, then returned to the base, arriving late.

Then I returned to the ship and waited. Although we were told we were free until the end of the special exam, there wasn't enough time to do anything and the scheduled time arrived just like that.

There hadn't been an official announcement yet, but with Class A already wiped out and Class B without its guard, there was almost no doubt that Class A would be last, Class B third, Class C second and Class D first. Since Horikita and Koenji in Class A had Protection Points, there would be no expulsions.

Just as Hashimoto came over to offer me words of praise, an announcement was made for us to disembark.

It seemed the results of the special exam would be announced outside.

As we started walking to disembark together, students nearby muttered about what a tough exam it’d been, but was that really the case? The previous special exam and then this special exam. It was certainly true that this one had been harsh in comparison, due to the long period of isolation, the considerable fluctuation in Class Points and the fact that a student would be selected for expulsion, even if they could be protected by a Protection Point.

When we got down to the wharf, we were instructed to freely take one bottle from several types of labeled plastic bottles lined up, but they were all water and tasted the same, so I grabbed one at random before stepping onto the sandy beach. It seemed there was no need to line up by class, as a teacher told us to wait wherever we wanted.

My eyes searched for Hiyori, whom I hadn't seen once during this deserted island exam.

And in the distance, I found her talking with our classmate Kaneda.

She didn't look injured or unwell; she seemed to be in good spirits.

I wondered whether or not I should go talk to her.

As I pondered for a moment, Yoshida, who spotted me and Hashimoto, rushed over, resting his elbow on my shoulder with a grin to celebrate our second-place finish.

Unable to move as I pleased, the three of us simply waited as time passed.

The teachers moved about frantically.

For a simple special exam results announcement, the atmosphere was strangely solemn.

It wasn't the state of each class, but the teachers' demeanor that was odd.

Even Hoshinomiya-sensei, who should’ve been suppressing her joy, wasn't letting her guard down at all.

Something was definitely off.

Even Hashimoto and Yoshida, who hadn't noticed at first, picked up on the strangeness.

The newly brought-in cardboard boxes were completely unopened.

"Man, don't you get a really bad feeling about this?"

"...What a coincidence, Hashimoto. I was just about to say the same thing."

Both of us sensed the strangeness and realized that something new was beginning.

Eventually, the exhausted Yamamura and the others were led back to the base by a teacher and as soon as the last survivors were gathered, they were made to stand on the beach with no time to rest.

There was a clear difference in physical condition and stamina between the students who were eliminated early on and those who had survived until the end, but no consideration was shown for it.

Or perhaps even this difference was all just a prelude to what was coming next.

As the students watched, Mashima-sensei picked up a megaphone and brought it to his mouth.

"The Uninhabited Island Survival Game Special Exam is hereby concluded __"

What should’ve followed those words was the announcement of the results.

But they changed into words that confirmed the oppressive atmosphere the students felt was real.

"From this moment, the Uninhabited Island Special Exam will now begin."

Those were words that heralded a new battle.

This was something entirely different from the 'lenient' survival game, whose penalties were little more than an extension of play.

The curtain rose on the school's battle of 'trust' and 'betrayal' to sift through the students and determine whether they were worthy of graduation.

Author's Afterword

THIS IS KINUGASA, who, as of this November, has finally hit a major milestone.

From age 19 to 40. It seems that before I knew it, I had dedicated more than half my life to writing.

I'm a proper old man now. An age that was once called the beginning of old age. Truly, I am old.

However, the fact that I'm able to continue my work is all thanks to you. Thank you all so very much.

With Volume 3 being the Uninhabited Island arc, I wonder if anyone was actually hoping for girls in swimsuits?

Sorry! No such luck!

But, maybe there will be next time (then again, maybe not).

And so, I'll let you keep your hopes up, as the answer will be carried over to Volume 4.

This volume's story was spread a bit thin across the entire third year, but while the framework for the next volume will also involve a large group, the plan is for a special exam that will focus on a much smaller cast of characters.

There will be new meetings and partings, and it will be one of the major turning points of the third-year arc, so I hope you'll look forward to it.

Now, that was a look at this volume and a preview of the next...

I have one important announcement to make here.

While I've managed to somehow push my body past its limits until now, recently, in order to maintain the publication pace, I've been continuously placing a great burden on my family and all related parties.

Even with the writing of this third volume, honestly, I'm amazed we managed to get it ready for release...

It was a daily, grueling battle, to the point that I don't think I could ever do it again.

While I've managed to persevere this far with a great deal of support, I have concluded that trying to maintain this pace would not only cause further trouble and worry for those around me, but also fatally impact the work's quality more

than ever before. Therefore, with the release of this third volume, I have decided to allow myself a little more time for the next release.

Normally, the next volume would be out at the end of March, but instead it will be at the end of April, one month later, or the end of May, two months later.

I cannot state anything for certain right now, but I intend to aim for the earliest possible return.

I apologize for the inconvenience to all of you who are eagerly waiting, and I ask for your understanding.

It's a bit early to be saying this, but let's meet again in 2026. See you then!

LegacyEMTLs Afterword

Hey y'all! It took us a bit of time with this volume due to the majority of staff being busy irl because of the timing of this volume, but here we go. Unfortunately, we were not able to get to the Short Stories so you can read them translated by Drago at https://www.reddit.com/user/AdventurousArt8711/. In any case, I want to thank EVERYONE who contributed to this volume for their hard work despite the annoying timing of the release. I would like to thank **you**, the reader, for choosing to read our translation of this volume. We certainly appreciate your support. I hope you enjoyed the volume. peace ✌

- Colibri

LegacyEMTLs Credits

Colibri - Lead / Dev

somehow still alive

FS7 - JE Checker

I like taking credit for things I didn't do again

Stella - JE Checker

It was really nice to see some action after several volumes without it. Looking forward to the next one! Even with the high chances of expulsion, I hope Hiyori will shine in some way and leave a mark on Kiyotaka.

Takuya Yagami - JE Checker

Read Swan Song on Royal Road, peak story

Writer - English Editor

Jeno is hot

3F - Illustrator

A whole lotta nothing; #TeamHiyori